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DMin Dissertation

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Dedicated to

The thousands of unrecognized front line warriors, especially those in Jharkhand, who are part of God's Third Wave. These men and women are changing the face of Christianity. A silent revolution sweeping across the world through them beckons the attention of God's people.

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ABSTRACT

This study is based on the observation that large numbers of Oraon tribals in the state of Jharkhand, India are embracing Christianity, and an increasing number of small churches in the region is evidenced. The Oraon new believers, however, lack adequate spiritual nurture, resulting in spiritual stagnancy, a leaning to syncretism, and practice of unhealthy traditions. These traits leave the Oraon churches spiritually impoverished and unsustainable. The study seeks to ascertain appropriate measures to infuse and instill such health and vitality.

Chapter one describes the nature of the Oraon people movement first and then places it within its national context. Brief definitions of key terms and concepts underlying this studyare included. Similarities with Christward movements around the world, particularly in Africa, Latin America, and Asia are highlighted.

Chapter two then describes the process of indigenization of Christianity and the emergence of the indigenous church in India. A brief description of subalterns in India, who have been the predominant population[1] among whom these movements have taken place, provides the foundation for this study targeting the *Kurukh* people. The chapter concludes by identifying the distinctives of the current Christward movement succinctly as the "third wave."

Chapter three is a detailed sketch of the history, culture, religion, and life in general of the *Kurukhar*.[2] Their worldview and religious beliefs factoring positive responses to Christ are discussed, and finally suggestions are made to instill health and

[1] See Appendix D, Plates 7, 8.

[2] See Appendix D, Plates 9, 10.

vitality in the *Kurukh* Christian church. Chapter four discusses the importance of considering contextualization and inculturation of the gospel as an indispensable need to build a healthy and sustainable *Kurukh* church. Chapter five brings the study to a conclusion by resolving the identified problem through the raising of appropriately trained and equipped *Kurukh* leaders within their own context to disciple *Kurukh* believers through contextual Christian religious education.

INTRODUCTION

Kadga, a primitive village in the Eastern tribal belt of India, is inhabited by a group of indigenous people who call themselves *Kurukhar Adivasis*[1] but generally are known to most people as *Oraon* tribals.[2] A good number of these *Adivasis* are scattered throughout the mountainous regions and have lived off the land and forests, cultivating and hunting.

One day, a *Kurukh Adivasi* (*Kurukhar Adivasis* in singular form) named Dayal, who had found work in a city forty kilometers away, visited the village of Kadga. He shared with the people his experience of a personal encounter with Jesus and of embracing the Christian faith. Dayal explained to them that he had found the "true God" called Jesus, and he wanted his people to hear the story. Captivated by what they heard, the people made a collective decision to abandon belief in their god Dharmes and the spirits they worshipped and to espouse Jesus. What they heard from Dayal appealed to their hearts, for they were told that Jesus could heal their sicknesses, protect them from harm, bless their children, and lead them into a good future. Within a month, over fifty of them were baptized by Dayal.

The incident described above and the process through which this community of people heard the gospel and embraced the Christian faith generally mirror the manner in which *Kurukhar* and other *Adivasis* in the region are responding to Christianity, and they are now responding in noteworthy numbers. A significant "Christward movement" is

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[1] The term *Adivasi* translates as "ancient dweller." Plural: Adivasis.

[2] Christopher Lakra, *The New Home of Tribals* (Faridabad, India: Om Publications,1999), 3.

The word *tribal* and the name *Oraon* are a category and name that have been imposed upon this people group by outsiders; such imposition bears with it a certain disparaging and pejorative element.

now happening among the *Kurukh Adivasis* in the state of Jharkhand in Eastern India.[3] The present congregation of Christians in Kadga village is one of hundreds of small *Kurukh (Oraon)* churches that are multiplying.[4] Although Dayal is a low literate, lacks theological education, does not live in Kadga, and visits the congregation just once every three months or so, he is considered the spiritual leader and senior pastor.

Currently, about seventy-five men, women, and children meet once every week to worship Jesus and listen to whatever exhortation the local pastor, appointed by Dayal, has to share. The Kadga church comes alive with singing and dancing during worship. Fellowship and a strong feeling of community are enjoyed during gatherings; however, Bible-based teaching, essential for spiritual growth, is woefully lacking. Likewise, Dayal's occasional visits are inadequate to meet the increasing need for mentoring the local pastor and discipling these new believers. They are spiritually malnourished and unaware of the need to grow in spiritual disciplines. Biblical knowledge is limited to miracle narratives in the Gospels and the book of Acts. The low literacy among villagers hampers further knowledge through personal study of the Word. This reality, along with the absence of adequate leadership between Dayal's visits, leaves the people spiritually floundering.

The spiritual condition and deficiency in Christian disciplines in Kadga's believers is reflected in social compromises and syncretism. There is a tendency for them to thoughtlessly incorporate earlier religious beliefs, symbols, and practices into their newly acquired faith. Their low literacy level leads them to use the Bible more as a

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[3] See map in Appendix D, Plate 1.

[4] See map in Appendix D, Plate 5.

magical talisman than as the written Word of God to be preached from, read, understood, learned, and imbibed to find its practical expression in daily life and behavior.

Men and women of the community gather often around a bonfire at dusk. Locally brewed rice wine is freely distributed, and there is singing and dancing before retiring for the night. Christians continue to participate in this community practice. One of the sources of income for the people is the production and sale of home-brewed rice wine to neighboring tribes and villages. That practice continues as well.

Deaths and marriages in the community are important occasions in which every member of the community is expected to participate. Rituals continue for up to ten days in the belief that the ancestral spirits also participate in these events. The spirits are invoked, entertained, and then sent back to rest once again. Each night during this period, there is excessive drinking, singing, and dancing. Every night of the full moon also is considered a night of festival and is specially observed. Rituals are performed, and everyone, including the Christians, innocently participates in these observances.

The socio-cultural setting in which the *Kurukh* church is currently growing places tremendous external pressure on individual Christians to conform to existing customs and traditions. Scripture is neither taught nor understood properly. The church is inclined toward syncretism. Lack of properly trained leaders who are equipped to take adequate measures to disciple new believers stunts the church's growth and spiritual well-being. It is perceived that if the church is left in its present state, the movement to Christ and the growth of the church may not be sustained. Deficient spiritual nurture of *Kurukh* Christians results in stagnancy, syncretism, and unhealthy traditions. It also impedes church multiplication.

This study addresses this problem within the *Kurukh* church in the state of Jharkhand. The observation is made that the present growth of the *Kurukh* churches in Jharkhand bears similarity to church growth among other tribal populations in India and church growth among people around the world living in similar socio-cultural contexts. The study identifies elements in the existing *Kurukh* culture and worldview that are conducive to people's receptivity to the gospel. The stated objective of this study is to find relevant ways to instill spiritual health and vitality through a relevant and contextual method of identifying, training, and equipping leaders who will then disciple *Kurukh* Christians through ongoing Christian religious education. In other words, this dissertation takes the first steps in creating a strategy to contextualize the Christian faith and leadership in the culture of the *Kurukhar* in Jharkhand. The expected outcome of implementing such a strategy is to adequately address the need to raise mature *Kurukh* believers who will establish indigenous churches that will become self-supporting, self-governing, self-propagating, self-missionizing, self-theologizing, self-renewing, and self-regenerating within the *Kurukh* culture.

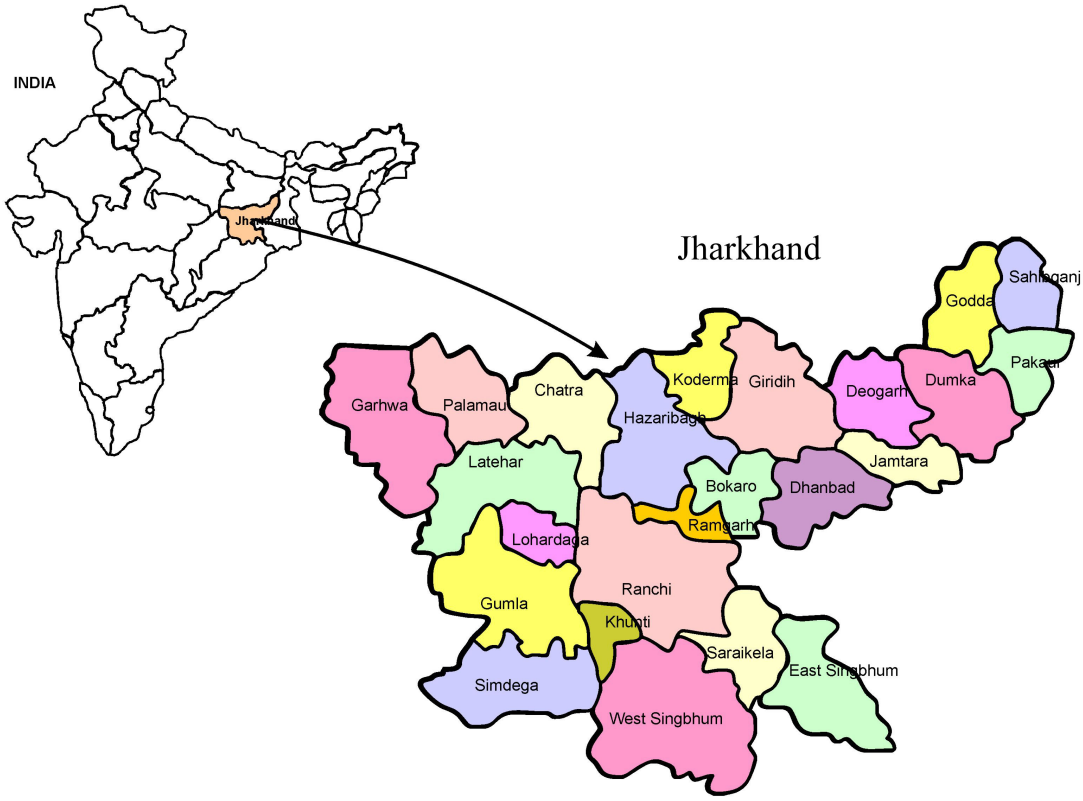


Figure 1: Map showing the region of this research and study



Figure 2: *Kurukh* believers worshiping in a small church building

(Photo source: Samuel D. Stephens)

CHAPTER ONE

This first section of the study, through a brief review of existing research, establishes that people movements to Christ in India have historically taken place among a populace belonging to a particular socio-economic stratum. A further observation is made that similarities exist between such Christward movements in India and those in other parts of the world, especially Africa, Latin America, and Asia, thus leading to the logical assumption that the current indigenous people movement to Christ in India is part of a global phenomenon. Important terms and phrases are briefly defined here[1] and in the Glossary.

People Movements to Christ in India

Historically, people movements to Christ in India have been mostly among two lower castes, the *Dalits,* or so-called untouchables, and the tribal people.[2] Most of the early Protestant missions during their initial work in India, in contrast, deliberately attempted to win converts from the higher castes; however, they had very little success.[3] Atul Aghamkar's description of the efforts of the American Marathi missions stands out as a classic illustration. He writes, "In the beginning, the focus of their work was to win *Brahmins*. It was understood that the conversion of the Brahmins and other high castes

[1] Detailed definitions are included in Appendix A.

[2] Atul Y. Aghamkar and Vishwas Padole, *Christian Mission in Maharashtra: Retrospect and Prospect* (Bangalore, India: TETRAWPOI [The Evangelical Theological Research and Writing Project of India], 2010), 119.

[3] Ibid.

could lead to the conversion of the masses. However, such strategy proved hazardous with very little results."[4]

In spite of this lack of results among high castes, the gospel was and continues to be received with greater fervor and the church has grown with greater vigor among the lower castes and the marginalized people,[5] or those people who have been socially excluded, denied of rights and privileges freely enjoyed by other majority groups, and relegated to the fringes of society.

Roger Hedlund makes a significant observation of this phenomenon: "Indigenous Indian Christianity is found in the Little Tradition of the so-called fringe sections largely (not exclusively) of Pentecostal, Charismatic or Evangelical origin."[6] Two striking facts call for due consideration. First, Hedlund points out that observed Christward movements are among people of "Little Traditions" and "fringe sections" such as the lower castes, outcastes, and tribal communities. This fact coincides with a declaration made by the India Theological Association in 1998 stating that "in recent times, India has witnessed the rise of many subaltern groups that find in Jesus a new inspiration and empowerment to carry on the struggle for their own liberation."[7] Second, Hedlund posits that the movements are largely of Pentecostal, charismatic, or evangelical origin. They do not bear resemblance in their worship style and administrative structure to denominational or so-called mainline churches established through foreign missions. These movements

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[4] Ibid.

[5] Roger E.Hedlund, *The Quest for Identity – India's Churches of Indigenous Origin* (Delhi: ISPCK, 2000), 3.

[6] Ibid.

[7] Ibid.

were born, instead, through the efforts of indigenous leaders with Pentecostal and charismatic leanings and evangelistic zeal.

These characteristics seen in the Indian context are noticed in Africa and Latin America as well. There too the gospel seems to find a more welcoming abode among the subaltern people of the little traditions.[8] The gospel comes to people in such socio-cultural contexts truly as the Good News that brings with it liberation, emancipation, and freedom from oppression and their struggles. As such, it is quickly embraced. One plausible reason is that certain elements of the Christian faith, such as its origins and the growth of the early New Testament church, have similarities to subaltern and little traditions and so they have instantaneous appeal.

What is the common thread that can be established among these various people movements to Christ around the world? What is it about the gospel and Christianity that has appealed to this particular category of people? What are the elements of the gospel and Christianity that are attractive to them? What are the elements of their socio-cultural context that make it easy for them to accept and embrace the gospel? In what unique ways would the Kurukhar need to be discipled and trained to avoid syncretism and shallow Christianity? These are the questions addressed in this study. To begin, it is important to have definitions of key terms and concepts.

Definitions of Key Terms and Concepts

Before these questions are addressed, the need arises to define several key terms and concepts (some that have already been used in context), including Christward movements, caste, *Dalit*, great tradition and little tradition, subaltern, *Adivasis*,

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[8] Ibid.

indigenous and indigeneity, autochthonous, and church planting movement. The above terms are defined briefly in the following paragraphs. Historical background and other details are included in Appendix A.

Christward Movements

This phrase underscores the uniqueness of the conversion to Christianity of large numbers of people at the present time. It denotes people introduced to Christ and drawn to the biblical narratives of the Person of Christ rather than to institutionalized Christianity, established traditions, and externally induced practices. The phrase also delineates such people movements as an indigenous Christian movement distinct from other religious, social, political, or cultural movements.[9]

Caste

The caste system in India is one of the world's oldest forms of social stratification, dating back to more than a millennium before Christ. The caste system, which is peculiar to India, has now become an exploitative structure through which those of the higher castes are in possession of economic sources and political power.[10] Under the caste system, Hindus are divided in to four major categories in the following order of hierarchy: *Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas*, and *Shudras.*[11]

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[9] Donald A. McGavran, *The Bridges of God: A Study in the Strategy of Missions* (New York: Friendship Press, 1955).

[10] Raj Irudaya, *Mission to the Marginalized: A Subaltern, Feminist, and Interreligious Reading of John 4:1-42* (Bangalore: Asian Trading, 2007), 34.

[11] Govind Chandra Pande, *Foundations of Indian Culture Volume II* (New Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass Publishers Private Limited, 1984), 140.

Dalit

The word *Dalit* is derived from the root word *dal,* meaning oppressed, broken, and crushed, rightly depicting the conditions under which these people have remained for centuries.[12] Indian society in general may be said to fall under three major categories: caste, *Dalits*, and tribal people. The four predominant castes in their hierarchical order form the first major category, which is *caste community*.[13] The second major category of Indian society is a fifth caste, or *outcaste community,* which is related to the above four caste segments but outside of them and perceived by the other castes as sub-human or non-human, impure, and therefore "untouchable." These are the *Dalits.*

Great Tradition and Little Tradition

The twin concepts of great tradition and little tradition was developed by Milton Singer and Robert Redfield while they were studying the orthogenesis of Indian civilization.[14] Robert Redfield, in his work on culture theory, defines great traditions as that "of the reflective few; as one which is consciously cultivated, refined and handed down in a formal learning situation" and the little tradition as that of "the largely unreflective many as one which keeps itself going, is taken for granted and is not put under much scrutiny or deliberate refinement and improvement."[15]

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[12] James Massey, *Dalits in India: Religion as a Source of Bondage or Liberation with Special Reference to Christians* (New Delhi: Manohar Publishers & Distributors and ISPCK, 1995), 15.

[13] The most general category of caste (Varna) is used here although the four castes are subdivided into numerous other castes. The present categorization will suffice to explain the position of the *Dalits*.

[14] Robert Redfield, *The Little Community, and Peasant Society and Culture* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1962), 134.

[15] Ibid.

Subaltern

The word 'subaltern' is generally used in reference to people of inferior rank.[16] The original concept of subaltern identity finds its roots in Antonio Gramsci's writings on cultural hegemony.[17] "Subalterneity in South Asian studies refers to the subordination of South Asian society under British colonial rule. It also means the power of the indigenous elite over other sections of the populations.

Adivasis

The third category of Indian society is comprised of people grouped by the government as Tribals or Scheduled Tribes (ST). Claiming to be the original people of the land and referencing their cultural and religious relatedness to things of the earth/land, these people prefer to be known as *Adivasis*, which means ancient or original dwellers, rather than tribals. The term "tribe" or "tribal" was not originated by those identified as tribals. It was imposed upon them later by anthropologists, missionaries, and the constitution of India.[18] In India, this term has a very strong pejorative connotation, implying backwardness and people who are primitive, uncivilized, forest dwellers.[19]

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[16] V. Thomas, *Understanding Subaltern History: Theoretical Tools* (Bangalore: BTESSC / SATHRI, 2006), xiii.

[17] Ranajit Guha and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, *Selected Subaltern Studies* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1988), 330.

[18] A. Wati Longchar, *An Emerging Asian Theology: Tribal Theology: Issue, Method and Perspective* (Jorhat, Assam: Tribal Study Centre, Eastern Theological College, 2000), 2.

[19] Ibid.

Indigenous and Indigenize

Dictionaries define the term *indigenous* as "produced, growing, or living naturally in a country or climate; not exotic; native; hence figuratively inherent."[20] An indigenous church would then mean a church that is native, produced, existing, and growing naturally in its context. The verb "indigenize" indicates a process of changing the form and nature of an existing foreign or alien entity to conform as much as possible to the milieu in which it is planted or placed. An indigenized church in the context of this study would describe a church initiated by foreign missions following foreign form, function, and governance but in course of time changing in part to adapt to the local cultural context.

Autochthonous

The word *autochthonous* finds its roots in the ancient Greek word *autochthon*. It is a derivation from a combination of two words, *auto*, meaning "self" and *chthon*, meaning "soil." Literally it translates as "people materialized from earth by themselves."[21] *Merriam-Webster's* dictionary defines it as "formed or originating in the place where found."[22]

Church Planting Movement

The term *Church Planting Movement* (CPM) is currently widely used as missiologists have identified an emerging pattern of indigenous church multiplication in various regions of the world through movements rather than individual addition. Such a

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[20] *Oxford English Dictionary*, s.v. "Indigenous."

[21] *Webster's Third New International Dictionary of the English Language, Unabridged: A Merriam-Webster's*, s.v. "Autochthonous."

[22] Ibid.

pattern is seen in the rapid increase among the *Adivasi* people of India and it is therefore critical to this study. David Garrison's simple working definition of a church planting movement captures the essence: "A Church Planting Movement is a rapid multiplication of indigenous churches planting churches that sweeps through a people group or population segment."[23]

Definitions of Contextualization, Contextual Theology and Inculturation

Terms and concepts such as *contextualization*, *inculturation,* and *indigenization* are often encountered in theological writings and discussions. Vague and inadequate definitions hold every possibility for confusion and misunderstanding, and even for being misled. K. Thanzauva, a tribal theologian, observes that the words *inculturation* and *indigenization* are quite often used interchangeably while the concepts are also considered as having the same connotation.[24] An attempt is made here to define briefly the concepts of *contextualization, contextual theology,* and *inculturation* for greater clarity. (These definitions are further expanded in Appendix A).

Contextualization

Contextualization is the process of clothing a message sought to be conveyed in symbols and forms native to the receptor culture so that the product shaped by the mind of the hearer is identical to the original message and its meaning.[25] The gospel is not communicated to inanimate beings but to living, breathing human beings consciously

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[23] David V. Garrison, *Church Planting Movements: How God Is Redeeming a Lost World* (Midlothian, VA: WIG Take Resources, 2004), 2.

[24] K. Thanzuava, *Theology of Community: Tribal Theology in the Making* (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2004), 77.

[25] Charles H. Kraft, *Christianity in Culture: A Study in Dynamic Biblical Theologizing in Cross-cultural Perspective* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1979), xxiii.

engaging their minds, hearts, and consciences. It is communicated with an expectation and a persuasive invitation to respond.

Contextual Theology

Thanzauva, citing Stephen Bevans, broadly defines contextual theology as "a systematic and coherent articulation of how a community of faith confesses Christ in a particular context."[26] He more specifically defines it as "a way of doing theology in which one takes into account: the spirit and message of the gospel; the tradition of the Christian people; the culture in which one is theologizing; and social change in that culture."[27] The close relationship between gospel and culture is the main concern of contextual theology.

Inculturation

Inculturation is the process through which the Christian faith interacts within a particular culture through the use of symbols, language, art forms, and imagery and thereby influences the manner in which its people understand the Gospel, and practice and propagate it.[28] Enabling the Christian faith to be clearly understood and embraced by people within a given culture as their way of life is the intention and purpose of inculturation.[29]

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[26] Ibid.

[27] Ibid.

[28] John Corrie, *Dictionary of Mission Theology: Evangelical Foundations,* ed. R. Paredes (Nottingham, England: InterVarsity, 2007), 181.

[29] Ibid.

Indigenous Movements in Africa, Latin America, and Asia

During the twentieth century, churches experienced explosive growth in the non-Western world. They took on many characteristics that are expressions of the local cultures in which they are rooted. The sheer number of indigenous and independent congregations created a shift in the traditional perception among people that Christianity is part of Western culture.[30] It may be observed that gradually in the last century the center of Christian theological influence, which used to be the Western world, has moved south toward Africa, Latin America, and Asia, with the growing number of indigenous churches playing a dominant role.[31] Hedlund identifies two important characteristics of this trend. First, growth is seen among the non-traditional churches, which may be categorized as indigenous and independent. Second, growth is predominantly among the socially and economically marginalized and "backward" people, who might be more precisely described as the subaltern and followers of little tradition.[32]

This observation is significant because it points to the fact that certain elements of the gospel and the Christian faith in particular have a greater appeal to a certain category of people than to others. For brevity, those movements in Africa, Latin America, and Asia that share similarities with the socio-cultural and economic ethos of India alone are cited in Appendix B.

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[30] Paul G. Hiebert, "Missiological Education for a Global Era," in *Missiological Education for the 21st Century,* eds. Dudley Woodberry, Charles Van Engen, and Edgar J. Elliston (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1996), 36.

[31] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 28.

[32] Ibid.

A glimpse of the growing phenomenon of Christian movements in Africa, Latin America, and Asia serves as a backdrop in efforts to study and understand the movement that is indigenous to India. Having defined certain key terms and phrases pertinent to this study, the following section explains the origins of the indigenous church in India, which dates back to the first century A.D. The section also establishes that indigenous Christianity is not a recent phenomenon and cites noteworthy contributions of indigenous Christians during the eighteenth century onwards. A few elements of the Christian faith that continue to induce indigenous movements are also highlighted.

CHAPTER TWO

Chapter one may be described as broad brush strokes on the canvas providing the backdrop by defining key terms and concepts that are critical to this study. The chapter described the present indigenous Christward movement observed in India and sought to establish it as part of a global phenomenon.

Chapter two seeks to provide a historical perspective of the beginnings of the indigenous church in India, which is traditionally attributed to the Apostle Thomas, followed by Syrian Christians from Persia. A brief description of the process of indigenization, which began in the nineteenth century, is then given, followed by a narrative of the search of Indian Christians—lost in a quagmire of colonial history, socio-cultural disparities, and a diversity of religious faiths and practices—for self-identity.

While it is possible to list a host of individuals as contributors to indigenous Indian Christianity, four are considered in this section because they are akin to the spirit of nationalism that prevailed during their lifetime and because of the high esteem in which they and their work were held by both Christians and non-Christians alike. This section highlights indigenous Christian movements and indigenous missionary movements from the early twentieth century. The study then points out that these indigenous movements have taken place for the most part among the subaltern—lower castes, *Dalits* and tribals—pointing out that Christianity came to these people as a liberator from cultural, social, and colonial hegemony. This section closes with the observation that the current indigenous Christward movement is distinct from the past as a unique third wave.

The Emergence of the Indigenous Church in India

Indian Christianity comprises an ancient community as well as a present entity that is making an important cultural contribution as well as a moral and spiritual force in contemporary society.[1] Both the past and present, therefore, deserve a closer study while keeping in mind the unique struggles faced during colonial times, the period of increasing nationalism leading to the struggle for national independence, post-independence nation building, and the current winds of Hindu fundamentalism. Following the history of the Thomas Christians, the study of Indian indigeneity begins with the question of identity.

Several traditional claims prevail with regard to the origin of Christianity in India. Indian church history lacks sufficient documentary evidence to support these various traditions any earlier than the close of the fifteenth century.[2] As rightly pointed out by Geevarghese Panicker, the challenge in reconstructing history with documented evidence is not peculiar to Indian Christianity alone but, to some degree, the origins of the Indian people, on the whole; as he says, "In all Indian literature, there are few professedly historical works."[3] Bishop E. Sargunam summarizes various traditions and theories held by historians and posits that Christianity in India originated under three major historical and cultural traditions:

1. First, the Dravidian tradition (St. Thomas, which is described in more detail in the section that follows)

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[1] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 54.

[2] Antony Mathias Mundadan, *History of Christianity in India* (Bangalore: Theological Publ. of India, 1984), 14.

[3] Geevarghese T. Panicker, *An Historical Introduction to the Syriac Liturgy* (Kerala, India: St. Ephrem Ecumenical Research Institute, 1989), 11.

2. Second, the Syrian tradition
3. Third, the European tradition and the arrival of Western missionaries in the fourteenth century.[4]

Since the focus of this study is the emergence of the indigenous church, scholarly views on just one tradition are taken into account, the Dravidian tradition. It traces Christian origins to the arrival of the apostle Thomas.[5] This tradition has remained widely prevalent as it pertains to indigenous Christianity even before the second century. The significant point here is that Christianity already had rooted itself in the Indian soil in the first century, and Christian concepts had permeated into the life, thought, and the sacred writings of the Indian people.[6]

The Tradition of St. Thomas and the Thomas Christians of India

Christianity in India, because of its dating back to the first century, in reality may be considered among the most ancient religions of the country.[7] According to Mundadan, indigenous Christianity in India finds its original roots in the Dravidian or "the Thomas tradition,"[8] which attributes to the apostle Thomas the birth of a Christian community in the present state of Kerala in Southwest India. Down through the centuries, despite being surrounded by strong non-Christian influences and opposition, this Christian community

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[4] M. Ezra Sargunam, Samuel Jayakumar, and S. Devasagayam Ponraj, *Christian Contribution to Nation Building* (Chennai, India: Mission Educational Books, 2006), 322.

[5] Antony Mathias Mundadan, *History of Christianity in India* (Bangalore: Theological Publ. of India, 1984), 61.

[6] M. Ezra Sargunam, Samuel Jayakumar, and S. Devasagayam Ponraj, *Christian Contribution to Nation Building* (Chennai, India: Mission Educational Books, 2006), 320.

[7] Ibid.

[8] Antony Mathias Mundadan, *History of Christianity in India. Vol. 1* (Bangalore: Theological Publ. of India, 1984), 49-61.

has preserved its Christian faith. Although detached from the mainstream of the rest of the Christian world, this ancient community has kept its identity endowed by its apostolic origin. Father Mathias Mundadan states that these early Christians of Malabar[9] in the state of Kerala became a distinct religious group.[10] Historian C.B. Firth supports the tradition, saying, "It was one of the early eastward movements that brought Christianity to India. Tradition asserts it was brought in the first century by one of the twelve apostles, St. Thomas. This belief has been the constant tradition of the Syrian Christians of Malabar, and it has been widely believed in the West also that this apostle's sphere of work was in India."[11] Unfortunately, we have no historian like the author of Luke's Gospel, who recorded in considerable detail the apostle Paul's mission to the Gentiles, to record the gospel's eastward march by others, including Thomas.[12] We have only what has been passed down as the traditional story.

Tradition both within India and the early church outside of India has it that St. Thomas landed in Cranganore in about 52 AD. It is said that here he won his first converts from among Jewish traders settled there and then moved on to work among their neighbors.[13] Barrett's well-researched summary statement underscores the tradition's authenticity: "According to Malabar tradition, Christianity was introduced into India by

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[9] Malabar, which is traditionally known to be the homeland of this Christian community, is on the southwest coast of India.

[10] Antony Mathias Mundadan, *History of Christianity in India. Vol. 1* (Bangalore: Theological Publ. of India, 1984), 38.

[11] Cyril Bruce Firth, *An Introduction to Indian Church History* (Madras, India: Published for the Senate of Serampore College by ISPCK, 1968), 4.

[12] S.H. Moffett, *A History of Christianity in Asia* (San Fransisco: Harper,1992), 25.

[13] Cyril Bruce Firth, *An Introduction to Indian Church History* (Madras, India: Published for the Senate of Serampore College by ISPCK, 1968), 3-6.

the apostle Thomas in AD52. A bishop is known to have been sent from Jerusalem to India in AD 345, and a traveler in AD 530 reported Christian communities in the southwest and Ceylon."[14]

What is important for this study is not proof of the Thomas tradition but the fact that the lifestyle of the St. Thomas Christians of the pre-sixteenth century was unique from the rest of India. P.J. Podipara briefly describes it as "Indian in culture, Christian in religion and Oriental in worship."[15] The traits of an early church that originated and grew outside the Greco-Roman world were evident in the ecclesiastical life of the church and its members. There was no centralized administrative structure of a monastical pattern. Also, as a church that preceded colonial beginnings in the country, it continued to exist free from the fear and favor of the imperial power that existed in India later. Therefore, Barrett says, its authentic, early traditions remained intact and incessant.[16] For example, the territorial administrative system that developed after the diocesan pattern within the ecclesiastical setup of the Thomas Christians of India was not structured as found in the Eastern and Western Empires (i.e., the Greco-Roman world). Instead, the "law of Thomas"[17] was the plumb line by which the church's authenticity and orthodoxy was

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[14] David Barret, ed., *World Christian Encyclopedia*, vol. 1 (New York: Oxford University Press, 1982), 373.

[15] Francis Thonippara, "St. Thomas Christians: The First Indigenous Church of India," in *Christianity is Indian: The Emergence of an Indigenous Community,* ed. Roger E. Hedlund (Delhi: Published for MIIS, Mylapore by ISPCK, 2000), 63.

[16] David Barret, ed., *World Christian Encyclopedia*, vol. 1 (New York: Oxford University Press, 1982), 373.

[17] Francis Thonippara, "St. Thomas Christians: The First Indigenous Church of India," in *Christianity is Indian: The Emergence of an Indigenous Community,* ed. Roger E. Hedlund (Delhi: Published for MIIS, Mylapore by ISPCK, 2000), 65.

measured and evaluated.[18] Placid Podipara says the ecclesiastical system of the Thomas Christians of India "was entirely free from the ecclesiastical thought patterns and administrative categories of the other churches, both Eastern and Western, which existed in the Roman Empire."[19]

Francis Thonippara posits that

> these Christians developed an individuality of their own, profoundly influenced by the socio-political environment of India and, in particular, Malabar. Their everyday Christian life and very specifically within their church administration demonstrate this influence. Thus, this Indian church, although later ruled by Persian Bishops, preserved a kind of autonomy and individuality of their own.[20]

The church adapted significantly to the local ethos. Historical records indicate that the Portuguese missionaries arriving from the West during the sixteenth century in later years were surprised to see the extent to which the Thomas Christians were acculturated.[21] The Thomas Christian community is, therefore, one proof that Christianity is not a Western religion exclusively, and that Indian Christianity is as old as Christianity itself.[22] This ancient community of Malabar, deeply rooted in the Indian soil, is an indigenous church and stands as evidence of its longevity over the centuries. Portuguese

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The Law of Thomas stands for the whole lifestyle of the St. Thomas Christians, including the ecclesiastical, liturgical, spiritual and socio-cultural aspects of their lifestyle. This "Law of Thomas" was well adapted to the cultural-religious milieu of Malabar.

[18] Francis Thonippara, "St. Thomas Christians: The First Indigenous Church of India," in *Christianity is Indian: The Emergence of an Indigenous Community,* ed. Roger E. Hedlund (Delhi: Published for MIIS, Mylapore by ISPCK, 2000), 63.

[19] Placid J. Podipara, *The Malabar Christians* (Alleppey, India: Prakasam Publications, 1972), 83.

[20] Ibid., 82.

[21] Antony Mathias Mundadan, *History of Christianity in India*. *Vol.1* (Bangalore: Theological Publ. of India, 1984), 36-38.

[22] Ibid., 78.

author Gouvea and other writers described the way of life of these Christians.[23] From their descriptions, there is no evidence to brand these Christians and the faith that was practiced by them as foreign to the soil. These Christians were genuinely accepted as a part of society in the Malabar region, and that society had also, to some degree, framed their understanding and practice of Christianity.[24]

Indigenization of Christianity

As the gospel is translated[25] and interpreted within specific cultural contexts in cultural forms, languages, and symbols, the result is a mutual exchange.[26] The gospel makes a greater impact on the culture, and in the process Christianity is enriched, enhancing its history, theology, and social expressions.[27] Indigenous study of the Indian church reveals several "cultural incarnations" of the gospel. In addition to the individuals mentioned specifically later, there is much evidence in the theological, cultural, social, and literary contributions of Indian Christians such as Keshub Chander Sen, Brahmanandhab Uphadyay, H.A. Krishna Pillai, and Paul Kadambavanam, to mention a few; the "indigenized foreigner" Catholic missionary turned *Sanyasi,* Robert De Nobili of the Madurai Mission; and Bartholomew Ziegenbalg, the first Protestant missionary to step on the Indian soil and the German who printed the first Tamil text and later trained

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[23] Ibid., 36-38.

[24] Francis Thonippara, "The First Indigenous Church of India: St. Thomas Christians," in *Christianity is Indian: The Emergence of an Indigenous Community:* ed. Roger E. Hedlund (Delhi: Published for MIIS, Mylapore by ISPCK, 2000), 71-75.

[25] Translatability of the Gospel coined by Lamin Saneh.

[26] Lamin O. Sanneh, *Translating the Message: The Missionary Impact on Culture* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1989).

[27] *Oxford Encyclopaedia of South Asian Christianity,* Vol. 1 (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2012),335-339.

indigenous workers at the Tranquebar Mission in South India, all of whom in the Danish Scholar Kaj Baago's words may be referred to as "precursors of indigenous Christianity" in India.[28] William Carey, universally called the "Father of Modern Missions," calls for special mention here as a pioneer of the indigenous church in Bengal. Carey's clearly stated objectives of his Serampore Mission reflect his intentions:

1. Churches established should be led by Indians.
2. No overseas control should be imposed on Indian churches that were to maintain fraternal relations with foreign church bodies.
3. Indians should be esteemed and treated as equals.
4. Serampore Mission will endeavor to develop Indian leadership.[29]

The inclusion of the church union movement in India is very much in order as an expression of the process of indigenization. The successful efforts, resulting in the formation of two separate entities, The Church of South India (CSI) and the Church of North India (CNI), brought about several changes in Western traditions within the established church and contributed to indigeneity.[30] Theologians have always expressed that the West has not adequately represented Christian spirituality to the spiritual Indian.[31]

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[28] Kaj Baagø, *Pioneers of Indigenous Christianity* (Bangalore: Christian Institute for the Study of Religion and Society and the Christian Literature Society, 1969), 8, 9.

[29] Sunil Kumar Chartterjee, "Pioneers of Indigeneity in Bengal," in *Christianity is Indian: The Emergence of an Indigenous Community*, ed. Roger E. Hedlund (Delhi: Published for MIIS, Mylapore by ISPCK, 2000), 182.

[30] *Oxford Encyclopaedia of South Asian Christianity, Vol. 1* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2012), 335-339.

[31] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 255.

Kumaradoss further opines that the felt need of Indian Christians during the nineteenth century for an alternative public sphere void of missionary control and monitoring, with liberty to experience and express the Christian faith in life outside the parameters of Western tradition and cultural expressions, is a critical factor that spawned indigenous thought, indigenous theology, and indigenous Christian movements.[32] This fact is further illustrated in this chapter. It is also pointed out that language has played a significant role in indigenous movements. Due credit must be given to the enormous contributions made by foreign missionaries to language development and their attempts at theologizing Christian concepts, doctrines, and the gospel into the vernacular.[33] At the time it was not intentional to create an independent church but it was the outcome of an extreme protest against what was perceived as "Colonial Christianity."[34] Importantly, Felix Wilfred records,

> the converts who were in a position to challenge indigenous structures of authority were simultaneously disempowered within the Church. European missionary domination within the Church and its allied institutions was so pronounced that missionaries presented an appearance of almost infallibility. In contrast, the converts were identified as inferior and often uncomplimentary remarks were made about the motives of their conversion.[35]

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[32] Vincent Kumaradoss, "Creation of Alternative Public Spheres and Church Indigenization in Nineteenth Century Colonial Tamilnadu: The Hindu-Christian Church of Lord Jesus and the National Church of India," in *Christianity is Indian: The Emergence of an Indigenous Community,* ed. Roger E. Hedlund (Delhi: Published for MIIS, Mylapore by ISPCK, 2000), 182.

[33] E. Johnson Rathinasamy, "Indigenous Christian Origins in Central Tamil Nadu," in *Christianity is Indian: The Emergence of an Indigenous Community,* ed. Roger E. Hedlund (Delhi: Published for MIIS, Mylapore by ISPCK, 2000), 208.

[34] Felix Wilfred. "Multiple Religious Identities?" *Dharma Deepika: A South Asian Journal of Missiological Research* 16, no. 35 (June 1, 2012): 52.

[35] Ibid.

Indigenous Identity

A study of indigenous Christianity in India logically leads to the search of Indians for self-identity. What were the factors that contributed to such a search that were followed by new expressions? C.B. Firth's following observation throws light on some of the factors leading to India's search for self-identity:

> The most prominent feature of Indian history in the first half of the twentieth century was the nationalist movement. This had already begun in the later years of the previous century when the spread of English education and Western civilization, which had proved so fascinating when first introduced and have continued to exercise a potent influence right down to our day, also provoked a reaction. On the religious side, the reaction took the form of a reassertion and defense of Hinduism in modified versions, such as those of the Arya Samaj and the Ramakrishna Mission. On the political side, it appeared as an impatience of British rule and an aspiration towards Swaraj (self-governance).[36]

The question arises from what is known of India's colonial history. Although the colonists rarely or never demonstrated any interest in religion, they were considered Christians. This image of Christianity, as a result, left Indian Christians facing an identity crisis.[37] Who were they, in contrast to colonial Christians from the West? Adding to the predicament, Christianity brought by the missionaries carried a two-fold burden. First, it was perceived as an alien, not indigenous, religion. Second, it was the religion of the colonizers. The emerging Indian Christian identity, therefore, always necessitated a second and third explanation apart from the primary elucidation of the faith itself.[38] In other words, apart from explaining the Christian faith and that they were Christians, they

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[36] Cyril Bruce Firth, *An Introduction to Indian Church History* (Madras, India: Published for the Senate of Serampore College by ISPCK, 1968), 248.

[37] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 47.

[38] Sathyanathan Clarke, *Viewing the Bible Through the Eyes and Ears of Subalterns in India,* Religion Online, accessed April 2, 2014, http://www.religion-online.org/showarticle.asp?title=2444.

had to demonstrate that the Christian faith was not Western and that it did not carry with it oppressive political and colonial power.

The characteristics of the Indian Christian identity, although not as well defined during colonial times as it is now, have to be established to be accepted as a truly indigenous identity. Its characteristics, according to Paul Joshua Bhakiaraj, are as follows:

1. That the Christian identity is a religious identity, not attached to any particular geopolitical entity, ethnicity, or culture.[39]
2. That it is inclusive and transformational, one that transcends and absorbs rather than abrogates existing identities.[40]
3. That the Christian identity is one that unites and directs other identities toward Christ.[41]

Following the period of increasing nationalism and the struggle for independence during the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, Indians have struggled for their social, political, national, and religious identity under Western colonialism. Post independence posed the challenge of nation building, which also had to address the national identities of various socio-cultural and ethnic groups along with establishing the country's identity as a democratic and free nation among other nations. The present-day question of indigenous Christian identity in India must be addressed from various fronts: ecumenical identity, Asian identity, Indian identity, and historical identity. Hedlund

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[39] Cornelis Bennema and Paul Joshua Bhakiaraj, eds. *Papers from the First SAIACS Annual Consultation* (Bangalore: SAIACS Press, 2011), 8-12.

[40] Ibid.

[41] Ibid.

opines that first and foremost is the ecumenical identity of indigenous Indian Christians. First, are they included as Christians in the larger recognized *'Oikumene'* (the family of God), or will they stand apart from it? Second is the crucial question of their Asian identity. Asian Christians do not necessarily appreciate Christianity being overly equated with the West. Martin Alphonse opines, "It is not only the Indian church, but the church in Asia as a whole is perceived as Western by the Asian eyes. Hence Asian Christian leaders have spoken from time to time on the need for 'dewesternizing' Asian Christianity."[42] In many parts of the non-western world where there exists the misunderstanding that Christianity is a Western identity and not a faith that embraces all cultures, Christians face an identity crisis. Following a strong post-independence wave of nationalism, India currently faces an increasing spread of Hindu religious fundamentalism (*Hindutva* or Hinduization of India). Within this context, the burden of establishing a Christian identity grows heavier. Third, according to Hedlund, there is the question of what specifically an Indian identity is. Birthed and nestled in a nation of a plurality of cultures and languages, colors, and forms, Indians themselves struggle within this kaleidoscope for affirmation of their national identity. Hedlund, citing eminent sociologist and director of the Anthropological Survey of India K.S. Sing, says:

> Extra-ordinary diversity is characteristic of India from the earliest times. India is a country of multiple identities, highly mixed, a convergence of differences, characterized by a tolerance of differences. Ours is a celebration of diversity, a concentration of regional and national identities, not their obliteration. Christians are very much part of this cultural plurality.[43]

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[42] M. Alphonse, *The Gospel For The Hindus* (Chennai:Mission Educational Books, 2001), 19.

[43] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 255.

Next is the historical identity that seeks to find Christianity a home in India since the dawn of the Christian Era, before reaching Europe beyond the Mediterranean. Roger E. Hedlund, quoting Frykenberg, says:

> Nowhere in the world exist Non-Western forms of Christianity older or more complex than in India. Nowhere did modern missionary movements begin any earlier (or last longer). Nowhere did such missions become larger, stronger or more highly developed. At the same time, nowhere have indigenous institutions, cultures, and leadership entered into the dynamics of Christian expansion in greater measure. Nowhere, at the same time, has cultural, social and political opposition or resistance to Christianity become more pervasive, powerful or subtle. Nowhere today are threats to Christian survival more serious than in India.[44]

Noteworthy Contributions of Individuals to Indigenous Christianity

The emergence of Indian Christian leadership is a vital milestone in the history of the indigenous movement. Early indigenous Christian leaders have truly left a striking imprint upon Indian Christianity, each one in different ways and without compromise, demonstrating the life of a committed Indian disciple of Jesus Christ.[45] The story of heroic individual believers who have made remarkable contributions to India's culture is an old one, with instances going back centuries. These leaders exemplify aspects of the Indian identity of the Christian community. Needless to say, the list is vast, but those of prominence and a few among this host of indigenous witnesses are cited as having been noteworthy and held in high esteem even among non-Christians during the 1700s through the early 1900s: Vedanayagam Sastri, Pandita Ramabai (Saraswati), Narayan Vaman Tilak, and Sadhu Sundar Singh.[46] Others could also be named, but these four serve to

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[44] Ibid., 257.

[45] Cyril Bruce Firth, *An Introduction to Indian Church History* (Madras, India: Published for the Senate of Serampore College by ISPCK, 1968), 249-250.

[46] Ibid., 249-251.

make the case both for their contributions to indigenous Christianity and also because they have been so highly regarded among non-Christians of India, Hindus and Muslims alike.[47] Additional details of the lives and contribution of each of these individuals are included in Appendix C.

Indigenous Christian Movements since the 1900s

Indigenous independent Christian movements represent a vigorous and rapidly expanding section of Christianity in India today. They are demonstrations of the translatability of the gospel, an authentic Indian incarnation of the Christian faith. Movements and individuals who have contributed to them are many. According to Jesudas M. Athyal, "The indigenous Christian movements, often called the key traditions, assumed significance when the mainline Indian church was identified with Western missions and Colonial power."[48] Jesudas further states,

> The history of the modern indigenous Christian movement is integrally related to the social cultural milieu of India. Apart from the ancient Syrian Christian community of Kerala, the Indian church largely comprises of the Dalits and the tribals, the socially oppressed and marginalized sections of the society.[49]

An attempt here is made to briefly highlight a few movements that have influenced the history of the Indian church in some significant manner. Likewise, a few notable individuals who have spearheaded and shaped these movements are listed along with the movements, specifically those who have attempted to develop theology from within their respective cultural contexts in order to make Christian faith meaningful and

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[47] Donald M. Lewis, *Christianity Reborn: The Global Expansion of Evangelicalism in the Twentieth Century* (Grand Rapids, MI: W.B. Eerdmans Pub., 2004), 124.

[48] Jesudas M. Athyal "Multiple Religious Identities?" *Dharma Deepika: A South Asian Journal of Missiological Research* 16, no. 35 (June 1, 2012): 61.

[49] Ibid., 60.

practice of the faith more relevant to its followers. In order to determine which movements and individuals to highlight here, two important factors have been taken into account: first and foremost, the reality of the complex cultural diversity of Indian society, and second, the varied religious traditions, beliefs, and practices that form the mosaic that is India. The list of movements and individuals, therefore, is not exhaustive but a general representation in the history of such variety in culture, language, and region.

As mentioned earlier, indigenous movements are not a new phenomenon in India. There have been several efforts to both indigenize the Christian faith as presented by missionaries and also originate the Christian faith in Indian soil indigenously. Several of them, dating back to the nineteenth century, have been quite successful while others enjoyed momentary success and then dwindled and died.[50] The reasons both for their success as well as their demise are varied and numerous and are outside the scope of what is currently addressed.

David Barrett has recorded over 150 Hindu-Christian movements from1858 to 1975.[51] He says: "From 1858 began the first of many indigenous attempts to form a Hindu-Christian church affirming faith in Jesus Christ but rejecting Western missionary control and retaining Hindu culture and Indian nationalism."[52] Among the early movements that are prominently listed are The Hindu Church of the Lord Jesus at Tinnevely in 1858; The National Church of Bengal proposed in 1868; The Chet Ram of Punjab in 1870; the Church of the New Dispensation at Calcutta in 1880; The National

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[50] Cornelis Bennema and Paul Joshua Bhakiaraj, eds. *Papers from the first SAIACS Annual Consultation* (Bangalore: SAIACS Press, 2011), 69-74.

[51] David Barrett, ed. *World Christian Encyclopedia,* Vol. 1 (Oxford University Press, 1983), 365.

[52] Ibid.

Church of Madras in 1886; the Christo Samaj in 1887 at Calcutta; a proposal for a National Church in India in 1893; the Fellowship of the Followers of Jesus led by Kandiswamy Chetti at Madras in 1920, 1921,and 1933; and the Subba Rao Movement begun in 1942in Andhra, which in 1966 had 300,000 followers.[53]

Barrett lists other indigenous Christian movements that are more recent, such as The Assemblies (Jehovah Shammah) of Brother Bakht Singh; The Indian Pentecostal Church of God that grew among the Telugu people in 1924; The Pentecostal Church of God of Andhra Pradesh; The Ceylon Pentecostal Mission (now renamed The Pentecostal Mission); and the Nagaland Christian Revival Church.[54]

Scores of other indigenous movements have emerged since then with a following of a few hundred to several hundred thousand members. According to Hedlund, research related to this subject is more recent and is only now "beginning to yield information about the hitherto neglected sector of Indian Christianity."[55] A comprehensive and deeper understanding of indigenous Christianity is yet to emerge. Hedlund further reiterates that "the study of Churches of indigenous origins is timely and long overdue!"[56] Rather than an exhaustive listing of indigenous movements, therefore, a brief overview of other spheres of indigeneity that offer credence to the overall picture is more judicious for the present. They are worth considering because they serve as both the cornerstone and the building blocks for the construct of the indigenous church in India.

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[53] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 47.

[54] David Barrett, ed., *World Christian Encyclopedia*, Vol. 1 (New York: Oxford University Press, 1982), 375.

[55] Roger E. Hedlund, *Christianity is Indian: The Emergence of an Indigenous Community* (Delhi: Published for MIIS, Mylapore by ISPCK, 2000), 48.

[56] Ibid.

Indigenous Missionary Movements

The first indigenous missionary movement was birthed in 1888 as a result of a revival within the Mar Thoma Syrian Church. The Mar Thoma Evangelistic Association (MEA) was started with a vision of sending evangelists to different regions of India. After Sadhu Sundar Singh, it was the MEA that first sent missionaries from India to Nepal. During the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, many more such missionary organizations were formed as a co-operative effort of several established denominations by Western missions in India and individual churches fully supported and serviced by Indian leadership and resources. In 1900, as part of the centenary celebrations of the London Missionary Society, a totally indigenous missionary organization was formed called the Home Missionary Society with the stated aim of starting self-propagating and self-supporting churches by Indians with their own resources. The early part of the twentieth century saw several of such indigenous movements started in Southern India. Indian missionaries were sent to Africa and to other "islands of the seas" where Indians were scattered.[57] The first of these was the Indian Missionary Society of Tirunelveli founded in 1903. The first Tinnevely missionary, S. Pakianathan, went to the first indigenous mission field in 1904, leading to the first baptisms in1906.[58]

The population of India at that time was around 294 million, with only 3 million Christians. Educated Indian Christians with missionary zeal and fervor were willing to go to those "outside the fold," but because of a strong spirit of nationalism that prevailed during that time, were not willing to work under foreign missionaries. In a way, it was

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[57] Ibid., 215-222.

[58] Cyril Bruce Firth, *An Introduction to Indian Church History* (Madras, India: Published for the Senate of Serampore College by ISPCK, 1968), 253.

this spirit of nationalism along with missionary zeal that fueled the growth of the indigenous missionary movement. The Indian Missionary Society and The National Missionary Society stand among the very first that paved the way for scores of such Protestant indigenous missionary organizations that followed. They began to sow the seeds of the gospel in faraway places, bearing them in "Indian" vessels. Missionaries who were sent by these organizations served their people in a truly Indian fashion.

Through the dedicated work of these Indian missionaries, Christian witness and work began to spread and gained acceptance more readily among the subalterns and people of little traditions.[59] While converts from higher castes trickled in occasionally, the larger people movements were always from among the tribals and the *Dalits*.[60] From the time of early missions, whether foreign or Indian, any notable or significant people movement towards Christianity has always been from this category, with this trend continuing to this very day. Christian values of equality and human dignity attract large numbers of these people through indigenous people movements to Christ.[61] It is therefore critical to take a closer look at subalterneity, including the people who fall under this category.

Subalterns in India – The *Dalits* and Tribals – A Receptive People

The theory that a significant number of converts to the Christian faith and Christward movements are from among people who generally fall under the category of

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[59] Julius Richter, *A History of Missions in Indi*a (New Delhi: Christian World Imprints, 2013), 416.

[60] Atul Y. Aghamkar and Vishwas Padole, *Christian Mission in Maharashtra: Retrospect and Prospect* (Bangalore: TETRAWPOI [The Evangelical Theological Research and Writing Project of India], 2010), 83-92.

[61] Ibid.

subaltern and of little traditions necessitates the exploration of the subject of subalterneity in India in more detail. This exploration is helpful in providing clarity on the perception of these people of themselves and how they are perceived by others. It must also be noted that historical narratives of Christianity have mostly originated from the perspective of dominant tradition.[62] It is in more recent times that perspectives from the "marginal people"[63] and the marginalized and oppressed subaltern people have surfaced. Christian studies and research from a subaltern approach inquire about the stance of the non-elite perspectives emerging from the weaker sections of society and people considered "below."[64] In other words, the question would be: "what are the perspectives and narratives of origin and history of the oppressed and marginalized?" In the belief that external narratives of subaltern history have been deficient,[65] subaltern narratives of their history have always sought to "deconstruct" and "reconstruct" such existing narratives.[66] It is imperative, therefore, to seek to study the subject of subalterneity from the perspective of the subaltern as well as that of the dominant groups. Such in-depth study from the perspective of the subaltern also throws more light on aspects that trigger the

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[62] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 8-11.

[63] Everett V. Stonequist, a student of R. E. Park, developed this concept in his book, *The Marginal Man.* Stonequist observes that since birth the human being is the responding subject to a stream of social influences. He gradually learns to adjust himself to the expectations of his social group. Through the conscious or unconscious interaction with other persons, he gradually comes to have a recognized place in his particular social world. If well-adjusted to his social world, he becomes a mature and harmonized personality.

[64] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 9.

[65] Robert E. Frykenberg, *History and Belief, The Foundations of Historical Understanding* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, with The Institute of Advanced Christian Studies, 1996), 294.

[66] Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, "Subaltern Studies: Deconstructing Historiography," in *Subaltern Studies IV,* ed. Ranajit Guha (New York: Oxford University Press, 1985), 330-363.

positive response to the gospel that is currently evidenced and on specific elements that draw these people to follow Christ.

Based on some of these principles that include subaltern perspectives, conclusions are drawn later in this study on methodologies for spiritual health and the well-being of the growing *Kurukh* church. Keeping in line with a "subaltern approach to Christian studies,"[67] every attempt is intentionally made to approach the subject from the perspective of the subaltern, being cautious not to impose top-down or from the outside. Traditionally, any attempt at Indianization of Christian theology has been from the "classical stream" or Brahminical thought forms derived from the *Vedas* or Hindu scriptures.[68] Saral K. Chatterji is of the opinion that such theological reflection has also been based on the wrong notion of a "monolithic" Hinduism.[69] These deficiencies need to be addressed.

Uttara Shastree, a sociologist studying people movements among lower castes and religious conversions of the oppressed groups in India, states:

> Social stratification, social inequality is a universal phenomenon, but the Indian caste system, along with its added dimension of the practice of untouchability based on the concept of pollution has been unique in certain fundamental ways. Hindu religious and cultural values have sanctioned the principle and practice of untouchability, a system perhaps unknown in any other part of the world.[70]

For centuries, these so-called "untouchable castes" in India have struggled to overcome various disabilities in the socio-religious, economic, and political spheres. There have

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[67] A subaltern approach to Christian studies seeks the viewpoint of the oppressed rather than that of the dominant.

[68] Saral K. Chatterjee, "Indigenous Christianity and Counter-Culture," *Religion & Society* (June 1989): 1.

[69] Ibid., 6.

[70] Uttara Shastree, *Religious Converts in India: Socio-political Study of Neo-Buddhists* (New Delhi: Mittal Publications, 1996), 2.

been several attempts for the emancipation of these groups, both during India's colonial rule and after its independence. One of these movements was led by Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, and when all his attempts to uplift these segments of India's people failed, he, along with his followers, embraced Buddhism as a revolt against the Hindu social order.[71]

During the nineteenth century, India experienced large socio-religious movements of *Dalits,* and some of them were Christward. These *Dalit* conversions were more of a revolt against an oppressive socio-religious system than a true turning toward Christianity.[72] At this juncture, the Neo Buddhist Movement in particular, led by Dr. Ambedkar, necessitates special mention and inclusion in this study, as certain socio-cultural parallels will be highlighted in the following chapter while discussing the early movement to Christianity among the *Kurukh* people. The Neo Buddhist Movement is also historically the single largest religious conversion movement[73] to have happened among the subalterns of India other than indigenous Christian movements.

The subalterns in India today still are oppressed, broken, subordinated, crushed and split.[74] The term *Dalit* is a descriptive term portraying these characteristics.[75] It is a term the people have taken upon themselves to counter names given by others such as "untouchables" and the government's classifications "scheduled castes," "scheduled

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[71] Ibid., 8-10.

[72] Ibid., xvii.

[73] Ibid., 19-21.

[74] Ibid.

[75] James Massey, *Dalits in India: Religion as a Source of Bondage or Liberation with Special Reference to Christians* (New Delhi: Manohar Publishers & Distributors and ISPCK, 1999), 15.

tribes," and "backward classes."[76] Christward movements among the subaltern and other contemporary expressions of indigenous Christian churches are found in many different regions of India today. By their nature, indigenous movements and their churches multiply. Not infrequently, the new, independent churches formed are the result of a quest for spirituality and human dignity that leads to conversion.[77] A majority of India's Christians are from the oppressed, the products of tribal and *Dalit* oppression.[78] For this reason, conversion movements in India may be seen predominantly as movements of social protest, the response of *Dalits* and the poor to a counter-cultural call; on the other hand, they may be seen as movements of affirmation in quest of dignity, equality and self-identity.[79]

India's cultural development has been enriched in several ways as a result of the contribution of many recent Christward movements and new independent churches. The "translatability" of the gospel is repeatedly demonstrated through these movements in the manner in which they express an authentic Indian incarnation of the Christian faith.[80] Hedlund makes the observation with historical data that four main reasons—emancipation, transformation, liberation, and revitalization[81]—seem to be the deep-seated

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[76] Ibid., 16.

[77] Raj Irudaya, *Mission to the Marginalized: A Subaltern, Feminist, and Interreligious Reading of John 4:1-42* (Bangalore: Asian Trading, 2007), 250-251.

[78] Nirmal Minz, *Rise Up, My People, and Claim the Promise: The Gospel among the Tribes of India* (Delhi: ISPCK, 1997), 28.

[79] Ibid., 44.

[80] Ibid.

[81] The term is from anthropologist Anthony F.C. Wallace.

inducements to indigenous movements among the subaltern.[82] Drawing on conversions in Hyderabad a century ago and the movement among the Malayarans of Kerala, he points out that the people who were oppressed and marginalized found emancipation and liberation through embracing Christianity. Hedlund elaborates further, citing the recent historical investigations by Dr. Jayakumar of the SPG mission to the Nadars and Paraiyars (1830-1930) that the conversion of these people to Christianity brought about a significant transformation.[83] It empowered these so-called untouchable people, by affirming their dignity, to rid themselves of centuries of social stigma and integrate into the mainstream of Indian society.[84] Citing people movements among tribal communities that, in the process of Hinduization, had lost their original culture and were branded as "criminal tribes," Roger E. Hedlund describes how they were revitalized by turning to Christianity:

> A number of tribal communities in India have been absorbed by a process of Hinduization by which their original identity and culture in effect are lost. The result was disastrous in the case of some who were branded as Criminal tribes. Often an erstwhile tribe was assimilated at the bottom of the social structure as degraded outcaste untouchables for the simple reason that they were "poor, landless and dependent on others for their livelihood."[85]

The difference between revitalization and revival, according to Roger E. Hedlund, needs to be pointed out.[86] He says, "Revitalization is a renewal of a structure."[87] The

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[82] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 11-15.

[83] Ibid., 12-16.

[84] Ibid., 12.

[85] Ibid., 18.

[86] Barrett records revival movements that took place in the 1990s. The Pentecostal/charismatic renewal as a whole continued to spread rapidly across most older churches and numbered over 33,530,000

process of revitalization gives people with an uncertain past a new identity through a biblical theology of human origin and redemption. In other words, the "disenfranchised" community of people can "re-narrate their origins" from a new biblical perspective.[88] Hedlund emphasizes:

> Among Independent Indian Churches of Indigenous Origins some at least are to be seen as revitalization movements. Others represent revival and renewal movements, still others comprise break-away operations and apparent personality cults, some are the outgrowth of persistent communication of the Christian message on new ground. The solidarity of Indian Christians with Original Groups is not to be questioned. All are of indigenous origins. As Hollenweger states, Churches of Indigenous Origins "represent a return of Christianity to its roots."[89]

V. Devasahayam underscores that the *Dalit* movement, both Christward and secular, is a growing movement both within and outside the church, working for the liberation of *Dalits* from caste oppression—stigma and discrimination—political, economic, social, and religious. These liberating factors invite such people to embrace Christianity.[90]

It is also important to note here one of the significant differences between the thoughts and perceptions of subaltern people of little traditions and people of great traditions. The former are all people of oral cultures where there is little or no writing. Jardine opines that "people in oral cultures, non-literates experience the world primarily through sound, which is, through the spoken word, and therefore tend to think in

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adherents (of whom 4% were Pentecostals, 15% charismatics, and 81% independents). David Barrett, ed., *World Christian Encyclopedia* Vol. 1 (Oxford University Press, 1982),376.

[87] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 18.

[88] Ibid.

[89] Ibid., 20.

[90] V. Devasahayam, *Doing Dalit Theology in Biblical Key* (Chennai, India: ISPCK/Gurukul, 1997), 4.

personal, concrete, and poetic terms, while people in literate cultures experience the world primarily through vision, and therefore tend to think in impersonal, abstract, and analytical terms."[91] People of oral cultures are also more conscious of the spiritual dimension whereas those of the greater traditions and literate cultures tend to reject what is not seen. Therefore, little traditions include more folk tales, songs, dances, art, and other contextual cultural productions. By their very nature, they are fluid and flexible, since they are not restricted to the written and are also not always originating in the written word.[92]

Innumerable factors other than the liberating factors described above contribute to the conversion process of the subaltern people to the Christian faith in such large numbers. A few important ones are spelled out here:

The Bible—An Icon and Liberator

Clarke makes this significant observation: "The advent of the Bible engendered a complex set of changes in the Subaltern world."[93] The Bible enters into a subaltern world that already has a long history of iconizing material objects, one which preserves and manifests magical and mysterious sacred power. The Bible is also an important symbol in the process of conversion and discipleship as it is used in expounding and expanding the Christian faith. So it is seen by the subaltern as "the book with power to transform" and is

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[91] Murray Jardine, *The Making and Unmaking of Technological Society: How Christianity Can Save Modernity from Itself* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2004), 236.

[92] Monica Jyotsna Melanchthon, "Dalits, Bible, And Method," *SBL Forum*, October 2005, accessed April 2, 2014, http://sbl-site.org/Article.aspx?ArticleID=459.

[93] Sathyanathan Clarke, "Viewing the Bible Through Eyes and Ears of Subalterns in India," Religion Online, accessed April 2, 2014, http://www.religion-online.org/showarticle.asp?title=2450.

somewhat comparable to a "talisman"[94] for the subaltern. Access to and possession of the Bible is also a mark of liberation to these people for whom any access of the Hindu Vedas is forbidden.[95]

Biblical Narrative—A Liberation Theology for the Dalits

The biblical narrative is filled with accounts related to miracles, casting out of demons, healing of disease and the like that appeal to the subaltern and little traditions. Such spiritual experiences are a part of the belief system and lifestyle of these people. It is one of the primary reasons for its undeniable appeal. This truth in a large measure answers the question why certain categories of people respond well and other people don't. Examples follow.

Creation story and humanity created in the image of God. A servant-bonded slave-menial worker-untouchable is certainly not a culture of pride. Nevertheless, that is the burden of cultural history that has been forced upon the subaltern. It is therefore not surprising that a *Dalit* group in search of a better heritage often create for themselves mythologies of their origins.[96] Fr. Stephen Fuchs, explaining the search for identity and quest for emancipation from an oppressive history, observes:

> For people with an uncertain past a Biblical theology of human origins and redemption provides the possibility for a new beginning—one world, one race, one Gospel—an egalitarian understanding of all humanity created in the image of God, a body of people redeemed by Christ through faith now in process of re-creation as the People of God for worship of God and service of humankind. "But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, God's own people, that

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[94] Ibid.

[95] Ibid.

[96] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 18.

> you may declare the wonderful deeds of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light."[97]

Redefining their origins and history in a manner which places them on an equal platform with those considered of higher status brings a sense of dignity and self-worth. Especially considering the existing narratives of the origin of the castes denoting various parts of the body of Brahma and the outcastes not belonging to the body, the idea of being God's own children and being created in the image of God himself is very appealing.

The Exodus Account. The Exodus story is another important narrative with which subalterns closely identify and appreciate. The emancipation from slavery and suppression and the children of God (*Harijans*) being led through the desert into the Promised Land are visual images that have a deep impact upon the hearts of those who for centuries have been marginalized and socially ostracized.

Jesus the Suffering Servant and Savior. The subaltern people easily identify with Jesus as one among them. In society, Jesus found no place except before God. Born in a stable, under questionable circumstances, hailing from a little town belonging to a family of artisans, the son of a carpenter and without a permanent home—what else could he be other than subaltern? So were his disciples for the most part. Jesus is betrayed by one of his own and deserted by all. He dies an ignominious death and is buried in a borrowed tomb. Yet Jesus is ever faithful. Jesus rises from the dead. Thus the gospel stories about Jesus point to the fact that even through the ashes of defeat can come

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[97] Ibid., 19.

absolute victory.[98] This is what the subaltern need and this is exactly what they want. The best news, therefore, for the subaltern is the Good News.

The miracles of the New Testament. The gospel narratives about miracles play an important role in appealing to the hearts of the subaltern and little tradition people as well. The supernatural element provides immediate solutions to problems and needs that may not be otherwise easily solved. For example, fear of evil spirits and the belief in the aid of good spirits have a significant influence not only on the religious beliefs but also on the everyday practices of these people. "Power encounters"[99] through healing and exorcisms are common practices among these people.[100]

The church as a close-knit community. To those seeking and longing for community, a new, indigenous church provides a sense of belonging and community. The sense of equality and the care-giving fellowship of other humans lacking in the outside world is provided by the church community—the *'oikos'* household of God. In contrast to a world where they are generally rejected or looked down upon, the church provides subalterns an embracing experience and equality.[101] As Pandeystates, "Dalit conversion aims to inaugurate a new community, and a new politics and culture."[102]

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[98] Murray Jardine, *The Making and Unmaking of Technological Society: How Christianity Can Save Modernity from Itself* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2004), 194.

[99] A term used by missiologists to describe the manifested power of the Holy Spirit through healings and miracles encountered in the process of evangelism and missions among people hearing the gospel for the first time.

[100] Kevin Springer, *Power Encounters among Christians in the Western World* (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1988), 17.

[101] Paul G. Hiebert, *The Gospel in Human Contexts: Anthropological Explorations for Contemporary Missions* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2009), 193.

[102] Gyanendra Pandey, *Subaltern Citizens and Their Histories: Investigations from India and the USA* (London: Routledge, 2010), 209.

Christian eschatology. Christian eschatology always has immense appeal for the suffering and the subaltern. It provides hope in the midst of despair, the promise of victory in conflict, and a better life to come. The persecuted throughout history have found both strength and consolation in the "imaginaries" of a glorious future that Christian eschatology creates for them.

To the subaltern of India who believed breaking free from the bondage and suppression of caste is an impossibility in this lifetime and perhaps never possible in afterlife either, according to local belief, standing equal in status among people of all nations and tribes and tongues before God is a great vision of liberation. The book of Revelation speaks of a great multitude that no one could count, from every nation, tribe, people, and language, standing before the throne and in front of the Lamb. They wear white robes and hold palm branches in their hands. This eschatological glimpse of ultimate victory, justice, and freedom from pain, grief, and need; community; and the possession of a place to live for eternity in heaven stands out as an overwhelming appeal.

Although subaltern movements have been quite common in history, they are different from that which is occurring at the present time. Previous movements, unlike the present, may trace their origins to foreign missions and missionary movements. The present, however, finds its origin in the Indian soil. It is distinct. The churches established as a result are indigenous in origin and in cultural expression, having imbibed much from cultural context and worldview. This is explained further in the ensuing paragraphs.

The Third Wave

The current narrative about Christward movements in India does not find its origins in Western missions or Western Christianity. It is no longer about Western

Christianity seeking out "unreached" and "untouched" "heathens" in indigenous communities. The churches that grew out of the early missionary era may be classified as the "first wave" churches. India and most of the world is believed to be well past that era. The indigenous churches in India are growing and multiplying now on account of indigenous people finding within their cultural context a living faith and passionately responding to it. This unfolding story is one of people who have been in bondage, eagerly responding to the liberating invitation of a Christ in the Indian garb and walking the Indian road. People who for ages have endured the suppression imposed by the darker side of Indian culture and religions are liberated, transformed, and emancipated as the gospel takes root.[103] Their lives are also being revitalized through repetition of new narratives of their history, new beliefs, and new practices that have been imbibed through their new faith in Jesus Christ.

The "second wave" of indigenized churches were birthed both from the need felt by foreign Protestant missionaries to make their mission fields self-sustaining, as well as Indians with a nationalistic fervor seeking to present Christianity in a more culturally acceptable and contextual form. Governance structures, denominational hierarchy, liturgy and expressions of worship in these churches were retained from past Western traditions.

Elucidating on the present global expansion of Christianity, Donald Lewis opines:

> All along, globalization has been a process with two faces – one benign and one malignant. The benign face of the gospel in India has always been perceived as "Hindu." Notwithstanding the universality of its message, where the Word has been made flesh in India, this flesh and clothing have been "Hindu" ("Native") in culture. That being granted, the gospel's expression in indigenous motifs, styles, and terms can be seen as especially manifest in four spheres: (1) in the contributions of noteworthy individual "Hindu Christians"; (2) in the rise of the

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[103] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 8-15.

> indigenous church movement; (3) in the remarkable increase and numbers of churchless believers; (4) and in the indigenizing character of Indian Pentecostalism, the largest single movement of Christian awakening and conversion.[104]

Lewis' second point is in harmony with the enormous indigenous Christward movement taking center stage presently in Indian church history. One objective of this study is to identify this groundswell of what Frykenberg describes among "churchless believers" as a unique "third wave" of autochthonous Christianity that is spreading in India and elsewhere.[105] Also, there is more to the general claim as asserted by Frykenberg and many others of "Pentecostalism being the largest single movement of Christian awakening and conversion" in recent years.[106] Deeper study seems to reveal unique characteristics to this third wave of autochthonous Christianity. The nature of the present indigenous Christward movement demands further research and finer articulation. It is believed to be the largest[107] that India has ever experienced;[108] however, it is one that is less known and one that has received very little academic attention.[109] Hedlund describes one of the challenges that is faced in the research of movements of this nature: "Statistics

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[104] Donald M. Lewis, *Christianity Reborn: The Global Expansion of Evangelicalism in the Twentieth Century* (Grand Rapids, MI: W.B. Eerdmans Pub., 2004), 123.

[105] Ibid.

[106] Ibid.

[107] David Barrett describes them as Crypto-Christians since they are not included in Government census records and published statistics. David Barrett, ed. *World Christian Encyclopedia,* Vol. 1 (Oxford University Press, 1983), 371.

[108] It is estimated that the total number of these small congregations could be as high as 500,000, with as many as 25 million individual followers of Christ in the last 20 years. This is not reflected in the census that the government publishes as they will continue to be under the category of scheduled castes and scheduled tribes. Secondly, even though these are large numbers of people who have turned to the Christian faith, on account of the rapid growth of the general population, the percentage of Christians remains the same.

[109] Personal discussion with Dr. Atul Aghamkar, PhD, and Dr. Prabhu Singh, PhD. South Asia Institute for Advance Christian Studies, Bangalore, India.

are notoriously difficult to obtain for these independent church bodies, but they represent a vigorous and rapidly expanding section of Christianity in India today. They are true indigenous church movements."[110] They are not the same as indigenized churches that may be categorized as those of the "second wave."

The distinction is important and needs clarification. The nature of the second wave is succinctly put forth by Hedlund in these words: "Indianization, contextualization, and indigenization are expressions of the effort towards change/relevance made by a non-indigenous church (one of alien origin and pattern) in an attempt to give it an Indian face."[111] In other words, they are second-wave churches belonging to the established foreign denominations and foreign missions. Their organizational and administrative structures follow Western denominational traditions attempting a more culturally relevant and contextual expression of their Christian faith. Hedlund further posits that "none of the mainstream denominations (the Great Tradition) is indigenous except for the ancient St. Thomas Christian community which, however, became Syrianized at an early stage in its history."[112]

According to the Church Growth Research Center statistics, an estimated 30 million people, mostly from among the Dalit and tribal communities, have embraced the Christian faith within the last decade at the rate of an estimated 8,000 baptisms every single day.[113] Also, an estimated 250,000 small house churches have been planted among

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[110] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 2.

[111] Ibid.

[112] Ibid., 3.

[113] Letter dated August 17,2014 from Rev. Vasantharaj Albert, Executive Director, and documentation with Church Growth Research Center of India, Chennai, India.

these people in the rural villages of India totaling 4,000,000 members.[114] Statistics provided by a single organization in South India (India Gospel League, which has initiated a strategic and aggressive church planting movement in India since 1992) illustrate this rapid growth. An aggressive indigenous church planting movement called Vision 2000 was initiated in 1992 by this organization. Its data reveal that during the last two decades, over 50,000 small churches[115] have been planted. Approximately 4,000 full-time, indigenous, and independent church planters are included in this network.[116] The numbers continue to grow. Several other indigenous organizations and mission agencies such as The Friends Missionary Prayer Band, Indian Evangelical Mission, Indian Missionary Society, National Missionary Society, and indigenous denominations such as The Pentecostal Mission (earlier Ceylon Pentecostal Mission), Evangelical Church of India, Indian Pentecostal Church, Pentecostal Church of India, Apostolic Christian Assembly, and a host of others are actively involved in church planting efforts with similar results in rural areas and well as with the urban poor.[117]

This massive movement has not received its due recognition and remains unaccepted by the mainline Church (mostly greater tradition) because it fails to conform to accepted norms and standards. This movement falls outside traditional forms and historical patterns and, according to Hedlund, remains undocumented.[118] It must be noted

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[114] Ibid.

[115] A church is defined as a congregation of 20 baptized adults.

[116] India Gospel League, "About IGL-Overview," accessed November 17, 2016, https://iglworld.org/about/overview/.

[117] Urban church growth is not included.

[118] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 16.

that the movement is predominantly among the *Dalits* and indigenous tribal populations who are people of the subaltern and little traditions. This Christward movement, however, has great significance at the present time since it relates to a very large segment of the population of rural India. According to the 2001 census of India, the numbers of this segment are estimated at close to 300 million.[119] The highest level of response to the gospel has come from these two groups of people in the past and still continues to be so, with more conversions from the tribals than the *Dalits*.[120] James Massey points out that Christianity continues to bring a new dimension into the life of the tribes, which is evident in the believing community through socio-economic development and transformation[121] even though it is largely undocumented.

The origin of this third wave movement is quite recent. Post-1980 seems to be the beginning of this new era of missions in India, a country that has for nearly three centuries been familiar with colonial rule. The new era started with the Indian government imposing tighter restrictions on expatriate missionaries and workers.[122] Indigenous leadership began to emerge. Indigenous missionary organizations mushroomed. Indigenous missionaries were raised, trained, and deployed. The 1990s also witnessed the rise of the Pentecostal and charismatic movements in India.[123] Through

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[119] Government of India, Census of India, 2011, accessed July 8, 2016, http://censusindia.gov.in/Census_And_You/scheduled_castes_and_sceduled_tribes.aspx.

[120] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 16.

[121] Ibid., 8.

[122] James M. Phillips and Robert T. Coote, eds. *Toward the 21st Century in Christian Mission* (Grand Rapids, MI: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1995).

[123] David Barrett, ed. *World Christian Encyclopedia,* Vol. 1(Oxford University Press, 1983), 842.

these movements, the face, voice, and flavor of the Indian church have been changed by its own people.

The "third wave indigenous church" may be described as an outcome of the presence of the indigenous church since its earliest times but especially now, with its missional outreach. It also could be described as "the second-generation indigenous church" experiencing total indigeneity from its very inception without interaction with anything foreign to the native soil, including social, linguistic, or other foreign milieu. It is indigenous in origin, indigenous in structure, indigenous in resources, indigenous in theology, indigenous in expression, and indigenous in mission. According to Germa Bekele, it has moved beyond Rolland Allen's requirements of an indigenous church, which are "self-supporting, self-governing, and self-extending," to the two additional characteristics stipulated by Peter Wagner of "self-theologizing and self-missionizing."[124] The nature of this third-wave indigenous church will be elaborated on in chapter four.

A significant movement of this nature first and foremost needs recognition. Recognition necessitates immediate, urgent, and exhaustive research to identify essential elements and the forces that drive the movement. The church at large can then find ways and means to empower indigenous catalysts and change agents who are instrumental and ensure the movement's effectiveness and sustainability. It needs to be approached with sensitivity and creativity to discover new ways whereby God is building His kingdom.

The discussion in the following chapter will be more specific to the *Kurukh* people of Jharkhand and the Christward movement related to this people group living in the eastern regions of India. A detailed study of the origin of Christianity among these

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[124] Girma Bekele, *The In-between People: A Reading of David Bosch through the Lens of Mission History and Contemporary Challenges in Ethiopia* (Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2011), 84.

people, the growth of the church over the last century, and factors leading to the current response of the people to the gospel are the contents of the next chapter.

CHAPTER THREE

This chapter deals with the specific people group known as the *Kurukhar,* who are the main subject of the study. This study of the *Kurukh* people in Jharkhand, among whom a growing Christward movement is taking place, intends to identify ways to build health and vitality within the churches established among these people. Generally, these people are called the *Oraon tribals*. Brief descriptions of the geography of the regions where they dwell are highlighted since geography seems to determine their lifestyle and economic conditions. The definition of the term *tribal,* the history and theories of migration, and a few other culturally distinctive features specific to the *Kurukhar* are included, with a view of identifying socio-cultural elements that may have factored in the *Kurukhar* conversion to Christianity.

Several socio-political revival movements have taken place among tribal people groups in India, including the *Kurukhar,* and a few of these movements are briefly mentioned in this chapter. Particular reference is made to the *Thana Bhagat* movement among the *Oraons*, which has relevance for this study as it throws light on the dynamics of people movements, particularly among the *Kurukhar*. This chapter also focuses on the religious faith, beliefs, practices, and moral code of conduct of the people group in Jharkhand being examined. The advent of Christianity in the Chotanagpur[1] region and its early impact upon the local people is included. The cause and motivation for the

[1] Chotanagpur is a division of the former state of Bihar, India, which has been the home of the Munda and Oraon tribes for over three centuries. During the British East India Company's rule of Bengal, this region went by the name of the "Lohardugga District," of which the town of Lohardugga was the administrative center. The administrative center was later moved to Kishenpur, around which the present city of Ranchi developed. Therefore, currently Chota Nagpur is also known as Ranchi District. However, when reference is made to the Chota Nagpur Division or region, the present five districts of Ranchi, Hazaribagh, Palamau, Singhbhum, and Manbhum districts are included (maps included in Appendix D, Plate 6).

conversion of *Adivasis* to Christianity during the early period of Protestant and Catholic missions and the present-day Christward movement are examined for their relevance to the subject of this study. This chapter then closes with an outline of essential elements that are expected to make the *Kurukhar* church healthy and robust.

The *Kurukhar* of Jharkhand

An examination of the word *tribal* and what it rightly denotes is in order here since the term is used often in this study and in India and also because the *Kurukhar* so categorized are the focus of this study. Worldwide, the words *tribes* and *aborigines* have been, in general, used interchangeably to label indigenous people. The terms are used to identify the first settlers in the continents of Africa, America, Asia, and Australia. The advance of modern civilization has pushed these early settlers out of their original habitations into more remote, isolated, and sometimes hilly regions for protection and shelter.[2] In India, they are referred to as *Adivasis,* literally translated as ancient dwellers or early dwellers. Following India's independence from the British, the Indian government began to use the term *scheduled tribes*[3] to denote these people since they were selected for protection and uplift by the government. Anthropologist Stephen Fuchs notes that while all aboriginal tribes may not be considered as scheduled tribes, all scheduled tribes are included in the category of aboriginal tribes.[4]

Mahli L. Tirkey, a *Kurukh* research scholar and writer, points to a definition that emerged from a consultation held at Sagrada in the Philippines stating that a tribal

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[2] Mahli Livins Tirkey, *Tribal Origins and Culture* (Delhi: L. Tirkey, 2013), 9.

[3] Ibid.

[4] Ibid.

community is formed by "a group of people generally constituting a homogeneous unit speaking a common language, claiming a common ancestry, living in a particular geographical area, generally lacking in scientific knowledge and modern technology and having a social structure based on kinship."[5] According to the International Labor Organization (ILO) Convention 169 of 1989, tribals are people whose social, cultural, and economic conditions distinguish them from other sections of the national community and whose status is regulated wholly or partly by their social customs and traditions.[6] Tirkey further elaborates:

> The people are regarded as tribes and indigenous on account of their descent from populations which inhabited the country or a geographical region of a state or country and who irrespective of their legal status retained some or all of their own economic, cultural and political institutions. Although the Indian government denied in the UN conference in Geneva in 1989 that there are any indigenous and tribal people in India and that only the scheduled tribes exist for whom constitutional provisions are made, it is well known that out of the very large tribal population only some are given government benefits. Such tribals are called the "scheduled tribes."[7]

Certain other common characteristics are found among tribal people. T.B. Naik points out seven of these characteristics of a tribe: (1) within a larger community, it enjoys at least a minimal level of functional independence; (2) it is marked by economic backwardness; (3) it has geographic isolation from other peoples; (4) it is united by a common dialect that may have regional variations; (5) it is politically a unit under a common tribal authority; (6) it is slower and less inclined to change compared to the general populace;

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[5] Ibid.

[6] Ibid.

[7] Ibid., 10.

and (7) it is governed by its own laws (*customary laws*) that are distinct from those of the majority communities.[8]

The latest (2011) census indicates that India's population has reached 1.21 billion, and out of the total population of India, there are 104.3 million listed as scheduled tribes (ST).[9] This number amounts to 8.6 percent of the national population. These scheduled tribes are divided into 705 different ethnic groups, and it is important to note here that it is estimated that more than three million aboriginal tribes have not been listed as scheduled tribes.[10] In other words, the government has not recognized a vast number of tribes,[11] which means it has not allowed them the privileges they are entitled to.[12] This situation exists because the decision to categorize tribals is left to each state government, resulting in a complex situation. Even if a particular tribe may be recognized in the state of its origin, the diaspora may not be recognized as a tribe in another state to which some of its members have migrated. For example, several tribes such as the *Oraons, Mundas,* and *Santals* in Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Orissa, West Bengal, and Madhya Pradesh are listed as scheduled tribes in those states; however, they are not listed as scheduled tribes in Assam, Uttar Pradesh, and Maharashtra although they live there in considerable numbers. The resulting implications are quite serious for those affected by this complex

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[8] Ibid.

[9] Government of India, Census of India, 2011, accessed July 16, 2016, http://censusindia.gov.in/Census_And_You/scheduled_castes_and_sceduled_tribes.aspx.

[10] Ibid.

[11] Mahli Livins Tirkey, *Tribal Origins and Culture* (Delhi: L. Tirkey, 2013), 10.

[12] Ibid.

categorization of people by the Indian Government.[13] This problem is highlighted here to point out the fact that tribal people living under such conditions can face further deprivation as subalterns.

The six major tribes under the ST category, with populations of more than one million as per the Census 2011, are listed hereunder:

S.No	Name of Tribes	Number in Millions	States Where Located
1	Bhil	17.07	Gujarat, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Tripura
2	Gond	13.25	Bihar, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Orissa, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Gujarat
3	Santal	6.57	Bihar, Tripura, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Orissa
4	Oraon	3.68	West Bengal, Bihar, Maharashtra, Orissa, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh
5	Meena	4.34	Rajasthan
6	Munda	2.20	West Bengal, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Tripura, Orissa, Bihar, Jharkhand[14]

Origin and Migration of the *Kurukhar*

Moving from a broader definition of tribe, this study now focuses on the major *Adivasis* of the Chotanagpur region, namely the *Santals, Oraons, Mundas, Kharias, Hos, Korwas,* and *Asurs*. A brief review of the origins of these peoples, particularly the

[13] Ibid.

[14] Government of India, "Demographic Status of Scheduled Tribe Population of India, 2011," Ministry of Tribal Affairs, 2011, accessed June 11, 2016, http://tribal.nic.in/WriteReadData/userfiles/file/Demographic.pdf.

Kurukhar (Oraons), is in order. Christopher Lakra makes the following observation in his discussion about the non-availability of documented information regarding the tribals of Chotanagpur prior to the nineteenth century:

> The whole body of literature on Chotanagpur tribals may be classified basically under two main groups: the school of British anthropologists and of the Indian anthropologists. The first consists of the British administrators, who lead the long list of researchers of both the past and the present, in the field of studying various aspects of tribal society, life and culture. Their important works were ethnographic, party historical and documentary in nature (Dalton, 1872; Hunter, 1891; Bradley-Birt, 1903; O'Malley, 1925). Besides these, prolific volumes were also produced by them in forms of geographical and land surveys, gazetteers, statistical accounts, reports and censuses. These sets of early literature paved the way for later scholars. The Indian anthropologists took up the line and developed along ethnographic studies of different tribes. They came from the beginning of this century.[15]

Linguistic scholars divide the *Adivasis* of this region into two categories: the *Kolarian*[16] and the Dravidian tribes. The *Santals, Mundas, Kharias, Hos, Korwars* and the *Asurs* belong to the *Kolarian* category, with identified linguistic affinity and an austric[17] accent in their pronunciations. The *Oraons* of Chotanagpur are placed by scholars in the Dravidian category since their language, which is *Kurukh* or *Kurux,* has closer affinity to the traditionally Dravidian languages of South India such as Tamil, Telugu, or Kannada.[18] Historians, however, prefer to use the term *Munda race* to describe all the tribals in the Chotanagpur region since the term is found used in ancient Vedic

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[15] Christopher Lakra, *The New Home of Tribals* (Faridabad, India: OM Publications, 1999), 2.

[16] The early Europeans who first came in contact with these aboriginals used them as Coles or Coolee (laborer), and from this association of terms George Campbell appears to have coined the name *Kolarian,* which we normally do not find in the history books of ancient India.

[17] A family of languages, proposed by certain linguists to combine the Austroasiatic languages.

[18] Mahli Livins Tirkey, *Tribal Origins and Culture* (Delhi: L. Tirkey, 2013), 12.

literature dating to c.1500 BC-1400BC.[19] Various theories exist of the origin of the *Oraons* and their migration to their present location.[20] The migration and history of the *Oraons* before they settled in Chotanagpur is mostly obtained from legends and traditional sources.[21]

Among the tribals of the Ranchi District of Jharkhand, the *Oraons* are the most numerous. Their primary dwelling is in the West, Northwest, and center of the district. Their concentration is in the old Ranchi District, which is presently divided in the Ranchi, Gumla, Simdega, and Lohardaga districts.[22] They also live in Palamau and the former states of Jashpur and Sirguja. Large numbers of *Oraons* have migrated to the tea gardens of Assam and Duars in the mountainous Himalayan foothills.[23]

Scholars hold three prominent views regarding the origin of the *Oraon* tribals of Chotanagpur. First is the view that the *Oraons* came from Northwest India and settled around the river Narmada near Baruch in Gujarat, later moving via Ujjain to Rohtasgarh.[24] The second view attributes their origin to the Indus Valley civilization in the *Harappa and Mohenjodaro* culture and later by migration to Rohtasgarh and the Chotanagpur region.[25] The third view, and one which holds more credence according to

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[19] Ibid., 13.

[20] See Appendix D Plates 2 and 3.

[21] Jai Prakash Gupta, *The Customary Laws of the Munda & the Oraon* (Ranchi, India: Jharkhand Tribal Welfare Research Institute, 2002), 20.

[22] Ibid.

[23] Mahli Livins Tirkey, *Tribal Origins and Culture* (Delhi: L. Tirkey, 2013), 13.

[24] Ibid., 20.

[25] Ibid., 21.

Ranjit Toppo, seeks to establish that the *Oraon* origins are in Southern India.[26] He notes that the traditions of the people point to the Deccan in South India as their original home. Further, philologists trace a connection between *Kurukh* and the South Indian Dravidian[27] languages, particularly Tamil. Although linguistic affinity alone does not establish the identity of race, in the case of the *Oraons,* according to scholars, both race and language appear to coincide. At any rate, it is established that the *Oraons* are both linguistically and ethnologically a Dravidian tribe.[28]

The predominant tribal population in Chotanagpur is the *Mundas* and the *Oraons.* The *Mundas* are considered to be the earliest known settlers of this region, followed by the *Oraons* sometime during the beginning of the Christian era. These early settlers then cleared the thick forests to cultivate and dwell and became the owners of the land. They are known to have set up their villages and established their *Parhas* (village federations), which were administered by their own headmen and council of elders. Then followed the system of election of common leaders who were not settlers and owners of the land but what Ekka describes as "primus inter pares" among the *Parha* headmen:

> Eventually, they elected a common leader. He was not the owner of the land but a primus inter pares among the *Parha* headmen. The descendants of this elected chief became Hinduised and surrounded themselves with Hindu courtiers, mercenaries and usurious creditors, to whom they made grants of the Munda and Oraon villages. These immigrants introduced the payment of land rent in Chotanagpur and ousted the Mundas and Oraons from their freeholds when they were reluctant to pay rents or to render unlimited amount of *begar* (forced labour). In 1765 Chotanagpur passed into British hands when the *Dewan;* of

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[26] Ranjit Toppo, *Dynamics of Tribal Migration in India* (Ranchi, India: Dept. of Research and Publications, Xavier Institute of Social Service, 2007), 178-179.

[27] Sarat Chandra Roy, *Bishop Caldwell's Definition of Dravidian Languages* (Ranchi, India: Crown Publications, 2004),18.

[28] Sarat Chandra Roy and Alfred C. Haddon, *The Oraons of Chota Nagpur: Their History, Economic Life, and Social Organization* (Ranchi, India: Crown Publications, 1984), 18.

> Bengal was ceded to the East India Company. Effective British administration was, however, not established in Chotanagpur before 1834. The Hindu landlords took advantage of the introduction of Hindu police officers in Chotanagpur and the opening of distant British courts in Hazaribagh district to obtain ex I *parte* decrees to legalize their proprietary agrarian rights over the alienated Munda and Oraon ancestral lands.[29]

Civilizations evolve over time. Delving into the origins of the *Oraon* people not only provides a glimpse of their history, it also brings better understanding of their culture, religious beliefs, practices, and social life that they are believed to have picked up and incorporated into their way of life during their migrations. The manner in which their worldview has been shaped is particularly significant to this study. As pointed out in an earlier section, the subaltern tend to re-narrate their origins to emphasize their equal status with those considered above them and by whom they have been subject to oppression.

Tribals and Their Land

Much of the tribal populations of the former state of Bihar (bifurcated into Bihar and Jharkhand since 2001), and particularly within the Chotanagpur region, were traditionally closely associated with forests. A significant number of the *Kurukhar* in Jharkhand throughout their history until the present time have spent the greater part of their lives in the forests. It is for this reason that these indigenous people were often referred to as *jangali*, today a derogatory term standing for "uncouth" or "uncivilized" but literally meaning "forest dweller."[30] Presently, the term *vanvasi* (jungle or forest dwellers) is used; however, it still carries with it a disparaging flavor. The *Kurukh*

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[29] Philip S. J. Ekka, *Tribal Movements: A Study in Social Change* (Chhattisgarh, India: Tribal Research and Documentation Centre, 2003), 6.

[30] Christoph Von Furer-Haimendorf, *Tribes of India: The Struggle for Survival* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1982), 79.

themselves prefer to be addressed as *Adivasi,* which translates as "pioneer settlers" or "ancient people."[31]

While describing the intimate attachment of the tribal communities to their lands, Von Haimendorf observes the following:

> Tribal communities living in settlements surrounded by forests have always regarded these woods as much their own as old style pastoralists considered the grass lands over which their herds were ranging as their own preserves, to be defended if necessary against the inroads of neighboring tribes. In Northeast India there are to this day tribes among whom specific forest tracts with clearly defined boundaries are claimed as clan or village property, where only members of the clan or village in question are allowed to hunt or cut firewood. Ownership over forests is there clearly defined and generally recognized.[32]

Later in this chapter, it will be seen how this attachment to land also factored in the early movement to Christianity and other social, religious, and "millenarian"[33] movements among the *Oraons* and *Mundas* of Chotanagpur.

To an *Oraon* man, who is the provider and caretaker of his family, the land is not an economic asset alone but a source that provides for sustenance and care of the man's family. The land becomes the arena where his worth as a man is proved. It is then with great pride bequeathed as the most valuable possession to the next generation provider. The bride price, paid by the father of his son to the bride and her family, is paid with the produce of the land. The possession of land has intrinsic social implication for the individual and his family. Domestic servants are employed in proportion to the extent of cultivated and possessed land that needs care. The crops from the land enable the owner

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[31] Philip S. J. Ekka, *Tribal Movements: A Study in Social Change* (Chhattisgarh, India: Tribal Research and Documentation Centre, 2003), 23.

[32] Christoph Von Furer-Haimendorf, *Tribes of India: The Struggle for Survival* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1982), 79.

[33] Described more in detail later.

to acquire other specialized services and material that are needed from the artisans, the handworkers, the musicians, and the herdsmen. Ownership of land is a symbol of stability, and the lack of it makes an *Oraon* a wandering and disrepute laborer.[34]

Millenarian Movements in Chotanagpur

When external forces weaken an established social order, and disrupt existing patterns of life, the results are loss of power and social unrest, particularly among the subaltern. Such unrest then leads to movements that aim to re-establish social structures or push toward religious and social change. *Millenarian movements,*[35] which are movements stirred by the urge for liberation from oppression and the hope of a better future, spring from the belief in the emergence of a new world in part through supernatural action. Frustration with existing oppression, loss, despair, and bewilderment are factors that trigger such movements. The hope is to break out of hopeless situations with the promise of liberty, equality, good governance, prosperity, and happiness. This hope can be compared to the biblical millennial reign of God. Millenarists (participant leaders of millenarian movements) demand complete change;[36] their underlying call is for moral regeneration and a new personhood, most often articulated, symbolized, and led by a hero/leader/prophet.[37]

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[34] Philip S. J. Ekka, *Tribal Movements: A Study in Social Change* (Chhattisgarh, India: Tribal Research and Documentation Centre, 2003), 21.

[35] People movements birthed out of frustration on account of social inequality, oppression, and loss of power with a built-in hope of a peaceful age of prosperity, happiness, equality, and good government comparable to the Biblical Millennial reign of Christ are called Millenarian movements. These movements also include a religious element to political and social changes that are envisaged.

[36] Sarat Chandra Roy and Alfred C. Haddon, *The Oraons of Chota Nagpur: Their History, Economic Life, and Social Organization* (Ranchi, India: Crown Publications, 1984), 167-209.

[37] Ibid.

Historians and sociologists identify several millenarian movements that had varying levels of intensity and duration among the tribal people of India. Such movements that took place in the Chotanagpur region are highlighted in this study, along with a summary of the *Tana Bhagat* movement among the *Oraons,* which has more relevance for this thesis. Noteworthy among the millenarian movements among the tribals of India are the *Kherwar* movement among the *Santals* from 1871 to 1895, the *Birsa* rising among the *Mundas* between the years 1895 and 1900, and the present *Thana Bhagat* movement among the *Oraons*.[38] All are manifestations of the same aspirations of the tribal people in the face of radical changes forced upon their social structures.[39] Historically, these movements have been birthed as a result of incoming Hindu landlords, British rulers, and Christian missionaries.[40]

The *Tana Bhagat* Movement among the *Oraons*

The *Tana Bhagat,* otherwise called the *Kurukh Dharam* movement, was initiated in 1914 by a young *Oraon* man hailing from Ghumla village named Jatra Kacchua Oraon. He elicited an enthusiastic following by declaring that in a dream, Dharmes (the supreme god of the *Oraons*) had appeared to him and asked him to abandon *matia* (ghost-finding and exorcism) and the belief in spirits and follow a life of *Bhakti* (devotion) and purity. Dharmes called him to renounce all animal sacrifices, meat, and liquor and also to give up plowing his fields since it entailed cruelty to cows and oxen. He claimed that Dharmes had commanded him that the *Oraons* should no longer work as coolies

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[38] Ibid.

[39] Ibid.

[40] Asha Mishra and Chaibasa College, *Tribal Movements in Jharkhand, 1857-2007*(New Delhi, India: Concept Pub. Co., 2010), 130-132.

(laborers) under people of other castes and tribes. Jatra proclaimed the dawn of a new era he termed the *Oraon Raj,* and anyone who refused to join would be destroyed. Jatra also claimed to have received special incantations and songs directly from Dharmes that had powers to cure diseases and afflictions.

An important component of the *Tana Bhagat* religion was the reaffirmation of one god, Bhagwan (the one above all) and Mahadev (the great god). Followers not only gave up the worship of the *bhuts* (ghosts and spirits), but through incantations and mass exorcism, expelled them out of the land. On account of their relentless repetition of "tana baba tana" ("pull father pull") in their exorcism hymns, they came to be known as *Tana Bhagats* by the outsiders.[41]

The belief in a "coming deliverer" became at one time quite strong in the *Tana Bhagat* community. Philip Ekka describes the happenings related to those convictions:

> In 1916, it was said that very soon, either God Himself or one of His envoys, gurus, such as Birsa Munda of the victorious Kaiser, would come and set the Oraons free. In Palamau this belief became so strong that several of the Tana Bhagats took off rows of tiles from their roofs in order to facilitate the coming of the Messiah, and killed their dogs in order to prevent them from barking and disturbing his advent. Some Tana Bhagats called at the Mahuadanr police station and demanded from the police the bahi (copy books) or legal documents sent to the Oraons by the Kaiser authorizing the hand-over of the Oraon country to the Oraons. Other Tana Bhagats believed that the Kaiser was already in Chota Nagpur with a cart load of gold for the Oraons. Peace was finally restored in the Ranchi district by the end of the year 1917, but the movement had reached the Oraons working in the tea estates of Assam, and a rising was feared there. In 1918, a rebellion in the native state of Sirguja by the Tana Bhagats had to be suppressed by a military force.[42]

The period between 1917 and 1920 saw the formulation of the creed and new rules of conduct of the *Tana Bhagats.* They became convinced monotheists and gave up

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[41] Philip S. J. Ekka, *Tribal Movements: A Study in Social Change* (Chhattisgarh, India: Tribal Research and Documentation Centre, 2003), 6-11.

[42] Ibid., 9.

the worship of the old spirits. An austere and ascetic lifestyle was prescribed for the followers, with Thursday set aside as a Sabbath day of prayer. The consumption of meat and liquor, dancing in the village square, and the display of showy clothes and ornaments were tabooed. Brahminic style daily ritual baths became a feature among the *Tana Bhagats*. Similarly, in Brahminic tradition, eating alongside non-*Bhagats* and intermarriage among non-*Bhagats* was banned.[43]

What constituted the initial strength of the new faith and contributed to its phenomenal success in the beginning was the combination of a strong desire for delivery from the bondage of capricious and blood-thirsty tribal spirits with perhaps a still stronger desire for delivery from the burden of what the people regarded as an oppressive and inequitable land system and land laws.[44] Indeed what appeared to be most appealing to the people was the promise held out by the originators of the movement that through *Bhakti* to Bhagwan (Hindu god), they would be able to raise the present degraded social position of their community to the higher level occupied by the Hindus and Christian converts among them and obtain relief from their long-standing agrarian grievances and present wretchedness of their economic position.[45]

The *Tana Bhagats* became actively involved with the Congress party and its independence and non-co-operation movement against the British rule.[46] They became closely associated with Mahatma Gandhi and other Congress leaders of that time. It may also be mentioned that the *Tana Bhagat* movement emphasized active rebellion of its

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[43] Ibid., 6-11.

[44] Ibid.

[45] Ibid.

[46] Ibid.

members. Many of them were jailed for this reason.[47] The *Tana Bhagats* even to this day maintain that a new day will dawn and that the day of the *Oraon Raj* (Kingdom) would eventually come.[48]

A glimpse into the history of the Chotanagpur region reveals that the *Tana Bhagat* movement is no isolated or accidental incident. It may be considered a phase in the general effort of the indigenous people of Chotanagpur to rid themselves of the external oppression and injustices they had been subjugated to and to regain their agrarian rights and tribal autonomy. While describing the formation of and religious transformations that resulted through the *Tana Bhagat* movement, Philip Ekka underscores that

> The inter linkages of the various institutions in a given society are now almost taken for granted by sociologists. It is then not surprising to see drastic political and economic changes in Munda and Oraon society to be accompanied by changes in their ritual institutions, which had centered round their agricultural economy. With the loss of ownership of land, the institution of reserving service lands for the village headman and the village priest fell into disuse. It is not surprising then that the minor spirits who were publicly worshiped by the village priest on behalf of the village community were now abandoned. The Oraons even expelled them by exorcism from the land. The Christian Munda and Oraon converts seemed to flourish under mission protection in spite of abandoning the spirits worshiped by their forefathers. There was no reason then why the Tana Bhagats too should not abandon them as impotent beings.[49]

Ekka quotes K.O.L. Burridge, saying that "the most significant theme in the Cargo seems to be moral regeneration: the creation of a new man, the creation of new unities, and the

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[47] Ibid.

[48] Ibid.

[49] Philip S. J. Ekka, *Tribal Movements: A Study in Social Change* (Chhattisgarh, India: Tribal Research and Documentation Centre, 2003), 21.

creation of a new society."[50] This observation applies with equal force for the *Tana Bhagat* movement and other similar movements of Chotanagpur. Ekka further explains:

> The wholesale adoption of very exacting Hindu rules of ritual purity which entailed the foregoing of meat and drink, tribal feasts and dances, commonality and inter-marriage with their brethren, seems to be an attempt towards climbing higher in Hindu caste hierarchy. The adoption of the Tana Bhagats of monotheism and a Sabbath day spent in congregational prayer and hymn singing is a sign of their attempt to catch up with their progressive Christian brethren. In effect, this is an attempt towards creating a new society for the non-Christian Oraons that would have the same standing as the dominant Hindu and Christian societies. The whole Tana Bhagat ritual enactment gives one an impression of a performance of a vast communal rite of passage during which the millenarian community ritually enacts its break with the past and then tries to integrate itself into a novel and regenerated society with integrity and standing in a new social environment.[51]

The *Kurukhar* of Jharkhand—Land and the People

The forests and the hills of the states of Bihar, Jharkhand, Orissa, Chhattisgarh, and Madhya Pradesh in India are mostly inhabited by tribal peoples.[52] The tribal people living in this region constitute about ten percent of the population of these states and nearly a quarter of the total tribal population of India.[53] The region in the state known as Chotanagpur[54] is home to the *Mundas, Kharias, Hos, Santals,* and *Birhors* (who speak an

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[50] Ibid.

[51] Ibid., 22.

[52] Krishna Gopal Banerjee, *Jharkhand an Outline (Jharkhand the 28th State of the Union of India)* (Jharkhand, India: K. G. Banerjee, 2009), 2.

[53] Appendix D, Plates 7 and 8.

[54] Appendix D, Plate 3.

Austro-Asiatic language) and the *Oraons* and *Paharias* (who speak a Dravidian tongue).[55]

Further, although the *Kurukhar* are settled in several regions of eastern and north eastern India[56] (see Appendix D, Plate5), this study is limited to those currently living in the state of Jharkhand. The *Kurukh* people have a long history and a rich tribal cultural heritage. A few of their distinct cultural traits and worldviews stimulate positive Christward response. This study will underscore such traits with ways to sustain the growth of the church among the Kurukh people. The tribal culture of the *Kurukhar* is very rich and ancient, and there is much that can be written in description of the *Kurukh* culture, its social and economic life, and its religious practices; a few of those pertinent aspects to the present study are discussed.

Village Organization, Economic Life, Government, and Kinship of the *Kurukhar*

The Kurukhar, as most other tribal people, are a close-knit people with strong familial and communal ties. The geography and landscape (forests and mountainous regions) in which they have deliberately chosen to accommodate themselves, the manner in which they have located their houses and living spaces, and several other elements of life as pointed out in the following paragraphs, are an integral part of their lives, defining their occupation, work, culture, beliefs, and religion.[57]

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[55] Krishna Gopal Banerjee, *Jharkhand an Outline (Jharkhand the 28th State of the Union of India)* (Jharkhand, India: K. G. Banerjee, 2009), 3.

[56] Ranjit Toppo, *Dynamics of Tribal Migration in India* (Ranchi, India: Dept. of Research and Publications, Xavier Institute of Social Service, 2007), 123-124.

[57] Mahli Livins Tirkey, *Tribal Origins and Culture* (Delhi, India: L. Tirkey, 2013), 9-10.

The Village (Basti)

A cluster of mud huts grouped together with no specific plan or arrangement comprises a *Kurukh basti*. To the outsider, the huts seem unorganized, but such a design is intended to strengthen community and family ties. Agriculture is the economic mainstay of the *Kurukhar*. Each family has possession of their own ancestral land.[58]

The *Kurukhar* have their own two-tier self-governing system that is made up of a village council now called *Gram Panchayat* and an inter-village council or *Parha Panchayat* comprising up to twelve villages. The elders who inherit their positions of leadership assume judiciary, legislative, and executive powers to resolve any disputes or social issues within the village and between the villages.[59] This system has altered since the British rule and political shifts during the last century.

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[58] Sarat Chandra Roy and Alfred C. Haddon, *The Oraons of Chota Nagpur: Their History, Economic Life, and Social Organization* (Ranchi, India: Crown Publications, 1984), 104.

[59] Sudhira Karan, *Social and Cultural Life of Jharkhand: Tales* (New Delhi, India: Mittal Publications, 2011), 107.



Figure 3 Kurukh Village Life

1974 Tribal Musaeum, Ranchi, Jharkland

(Photo source: Samuel D. Stephens





(Photo source: Samuel D. Stephens)

Kinship Relationship

The tribes have a detailed classification of kinship terminology, including the extended family, which involves most of the community in which they live. Specific terms used for defining relationships are not restricted to immediate family members. Every relationship on the maternal and paternal side—from great-grandparents, cousins, uncles, aunts, nieces, nephews, and in-laws of siblings—is addressed by different words and with differing levels of respect. Sometimes these relations may be "classificatory," indicating a certain level of affection or respect.[60] For example, the individuals' actual names are seldom used except in the case of equals or an elder addressing a young person or child. This classification system indicates how they rely on each other for support and live an interdependent way of life.[61] It also implies expectations of one another in terms of protection, respect, care, honor, and division of work within the community.

The *Kurukh* Social Environment

The social practices of the Kurukhar are not too different from that of most other tribal communities in India. Similarities may be noticed in the practices of courtship, marriage, childbirth, and rearing of children. Although a patriarchal society, *Kurukh* women enjoy equal status with men and seem to have more influence on the family than men. Father Fidelis de Sa observes that while women in other cultures would wake up much earlier than men and children, denoting a heavier load of responsibilities placed

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[60] John Lakra, *Tribal Culture: Selected Features* (Gumla, India: Florence Kujur, 2007), 6.

[61] Ajit Kumar Pandey, "Kinship and Power Structure: A Comparative Study of Mundas and Oraons in Bihar," (PhD diss., Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi, India, 1985), 151,152. In Shodhganga: a reservoir of Indian theses at INFLIBNET, accessed April 21, 2015, http://hdl.handle.net/10603/14628.

upon them, *Kurukh* women start the day at the same time as men do.[62] Such an equal status is given from childhood and further endorsed through life in community houses as young men and women.[63]

The Dhumkuria: The Bachelors'/Community House

The *Dhumkuria* is an indigenous social institution for the upbringing and empowerment of the youth in *Kurukh* villages and is one that has evolved and remained with them from time immemorial. S.C. Roy points out that the institution of the *Dhumkuria* appears to be a genuine and unadulterated product of 'primitive' Kurukh culture.[64] Adjoining the *Dhumkuria* is the *akhra* or dancing-ground of the village because song and dance are a very important and integral part of *Kurukh* life. Roy further points out that the *Dhumkuria* is like a useful seminary for the training of the youth, by the youth, in social and religious duties. Karma Oraon opines, "The Dhumkuria among the Oraons is the youth dormitory which provides its members the opportunity of learning socio-cultural values of the society."[65] S.C. Roy further explains that the *Dhumkuria* has two parts—one which has membership for unmarried boys and is known as *Jonkherpa* (male youth house) and another is *Pelo-erpa,* which has the membership for unmarried

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[62] Fidelis de Sa, Alvino Noronha, and Achilles Meersman, *Crisis in Chota Nagpur: With Special Reference to the Judicial Conflict between Jesuit Missionaries and British Government Officials, November 1889-March 1890* (Bangalore: Redemptorist Publications, 1975), 26-27.

[63] Sarat Chandra Roy and Alfred C. Haddon, *The Oraons of Chota Nagpur: Their History, Economic Life, and Social Organization* (Ranchi, India: Crown Publications, 1984), 128.

[64] Ibid., 129.

[65] Karma Oraon, *The Spectrum of Tribal Religion in Bihar: A Study of Continuity & Change Among the Oraon of Chotanagpur* (Varanasi, India: Kishor Vidya Niketan, 1988), 67.

girls. The boys and girls are housed separately and divided in groups according to their ages as follows:[66]

1. *Puna Johkhar* (ages 9-13)
2. *Majthuria* (between 13-18)
3. *Konha Jonkhar* (ages 18 and above)

Membership in *Dhumkuria* is more or less essential for *Oraon* boys and girls. In the absence of an academic institution in a community, the *Dhumkuria* provides the *Oraons* a formal education in the *Oraon* way of life.[67]

The outgoing *jonkhmahto* (youth leader) gives the following instruction to the newly elected *mahto (leader)*: "Take care that no one may find fault with you or with your boys. When an offence is committed with any of your boys, deal out even justice to all parties concerned."[68] Unfortunately, the *Kurukh Dhumkuria* (and its equivalent in other tribal cultures) has been looked upon negatively by non-tribal observers as a place promoting promiscuity. A closer study, however, reveals that the underlying purpose of establishing the youth dormitory was for the training of the young people of the community in the cultural expressions of song, dance, use of musical instruments, etiquette, and socio-religious responsibilities. It provides a safe and conducive public environment for unreserved interaction between young boys and girls within the cultural norms. The practice also builds strong community and mutual support during the

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[66] Ibid.

[67] Ibid., 68.

[68] Ibid., 133.

individuals' formative years. The institution of the *Dhumkuria* also provides a structure of individual and group accountability within the community.[69]

Work Taboo

Although no major distinction is held between the work done by men and women in the *Kurukh* society, there are taboos against women doing certain kinds of labor. A close study again shows that these taboos are not gender-biased but held more in respect of women.[70] For example, the *Kurukhar* hold plowing and roofing as exclusive work for men. They religiously believe that if these tasks were to be performed by women, the earth would be deprived of rain and the harvest would not be as plentiful. The real reason behind this taboo is the respect and civility shown towards women. The use of primitive equipment for manual plowing makes the work tough, and a woman may lack the strength to till the soil deep enough for the seeds to take root and provide a good harvest. Also, the traditional attire (sari) worn by women would render the work both inconvenient for the woman and indecent for the onlooker.

The *Kurukhar,* as several other tribals do, hold their women in equal esteem as men. The *dali-dhiba* (bride money) is an indicator that a bride is valuable in *Kurukh* culture as opposed to the *dowry* (bridegroom money) paid by the bride's family in other non-tribal cultures in India. The *dali-dhiba* is fixed by the elders of the village and not by the parents of the bride. If the groom is unable to pay the price, he is expected to work in the bride's house for a set period until the amount is considered paid.

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[69] Ibid., 129.

[70] Edmund Campion, *My Oraon Culture* (Ranchi, India: E. Campion, 1980), 191.

Rice Beer

Rice beer(*haria/hadia*) is the favorite drink of the *Kurukhar*,[71] as is true of other *Adivasis* of Jharkhand. The *Kurukh* has no celebration or ceremony, be it religious or social, without a generous supply of *haria*. The tribals of Chotanagpur attribute the knowledge of making rice beer to Dharmes himself. Tribal creation mythology says that God taught the progenitors of the tribe the art of making rice beer in the context of offering sacrifice. *Hadia* is at first prepared for a special ritual sacrifice. Following the ritual, it is then continued to be used normally every day and formally during special occasions.[72] In the life of a *Kurukh*, the use of *hadia* is integral to planting and harvesting, festivals marking the seasons, births and deaths, marriages, performance of various rites of initiation, and a host of other occasions when it is used both ceremoniously and for celebration. The following narrative from Roy illustrates the point:

> The Oraon cultivator who wants to begin the transplantation of paddy-seedlings on his fields before any other villager has commenced transplanting his, has to invite the village-priest (Baiga or Pahan) to perform the ceremony known as 'ban-gari'. The ceremony is briefly this: the cultivator takes a pot of rice beer to the field selected where bundles of paddy seedlings have already been taken. The pahan accompanies the cultivator to the field. Arrived there, the Pahan pours a little of the rice beer on the ground as 'tapaon' (libation) to Mother Earth who is thus invoked: "O mother Earth! May we have plenty of rain, and a bumper crop. Here is tapaon for thee." The Pahan now plants with his own hands five paddy seedlings on the spot where the rice beer has been poured. This done, women commence transplanting the rest of the paddy seedlings on the fields. The rice beer left in the pot becomes the Pahan's perquisite. The Pahan is then taken to the house of the cultivator and treated to a dinner with plenty of rice beer.[73]

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[71] John Lakra, *Tribal Culture: Selected Features* (Gumla, India: Florence Kujur, 2007), 65.

[72] Francis Pereira, *The Faith Tradition of the Kurukhar (Uraons)* (Delhi: Indian Society for Promoting Christian Knowledge, 2007), 323.

[73] Sarat Chandra Roy and Alfred C. Haddon, *The Oraons of Chota Nagpur: Their History, Economic Life, and Social Organization* (Ranchi, India: Crown Publications, 2010), 89-90.

Then again, Roy points out that the use of rice beer is essential during harvest, saying: "No Oraon cultivator may thresh his paddy or celebrate his *Khalihani* (threshing floor or harvest festival) before the village priest has performed his own *Khalihani.* The *Pahan*, when celebrating his own *Khalihani*, brings out a few jars of rice beer and entertains with food and drink such of his fellow villagers as assemble at his house on the occasion."[74]

Rice beer also plays a vital role in *Kurukh* hospitality. Although everyone is free to drink, *Kurukh* custom stipulates that only the elderly and those who hold the responsibility of managing the household are expected to drink for mere pleasure. Although drunkenness is tolerated, it is not approved.

The *Kurukh* Religion and Religious Practices

It is said that the *Kurukhar* are followers of the Sarna religion.[75] The place where the *Kurukhar* gather during special times (usually once a year) to perform religious rites is called Sarna.[76] The literal translation of Sarna is "sacred grove."[77] The traditional tribal religions of the region are collectively called Sarna religion. Sarna religion has therefore become synonymous with *Adivasi* religions in this sense throughout Jharkhand.[78] Tirkey explains the "sarnadharam":

> According to the tribal belief, God (Dharmes) is specially pleased to bestow upon them his blessings of fertility and prosperity through the Sarai flower in the Sarhul festival. The Sal tree is therefore very significant in tribal life and culture. Their worship place is the holy grove of Sal trees. This holy grove is called "saran," as derived from the words "sarai" and "sarjom," and from there comes

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[74] Ibid., 91.

[75] Mahli Livins Tirkey, *Tribal Origins and Culture* (Delhi, India: L. Tirkey, 2013), 62.

[76] Appendix D, Plate 13.

[77] Ibid.

[78] Ibid.

> the name "sarnadharam" or Sarna religion of the tribes of Chotanagpur. Sarna Dharam is monotheism, the ancestral religion of the Oraons, Mundas, Kharias, who have no idols, no temples, no multiplicity of gods or goddesses. In the Sarna, their holy place, they worship God, the invisible Supreme Being. They also venerate benevolent spirits deputed by their God (Dharmes or Singh Bonga). To ward off the evil spirits they also set aside some little offerings [sic] as and when the need arises. The Oraons call the Sal tree as "makka" and its flower as "naurpoonp." They too, as many other fellow tribes, have the Sarna for their worship place.[79]

A religion cannot be rightly named after its place of worship. If so, Christianity would be called the "church religion," Judaism the "synagogue religion," and so on. A religion is named after the God who is worshiped, by the name of the founder, by the religion's belief/practice, or by people's ethnicity. Therefore, the religion of the *Kurukhar* cannot rightly be called *Sarna* as attributed to them by non-tribals. John Lakra suggests a more appropriate tribal term, *Addi,* meaning patrimonial or original, to describe the *Kurukh* beliefs and religion.

Generally, the *Kurukhar* have been described as animistic in their beliefs and practices. However, a closer examination and study of the *Kurukh* religious belief indicates that they may not be classified as animists in the strict sense. The *Kurukhar* are neither animists nor polytheists. The term *Nad* is used to denote or describe supernatural forces, which in the English language has often been translated using the word *spirit*. The term *Khunt Nad* (family spirit), belonging to ancestors, is considered good and is venerated, but not worshiped. In the same way, *Asin Nad* (evil spirit), that takes away life (causing death) and harms life in various ways, is feared. The *Nad* are invisible supernatural forces that are believed to exert influence on people. The good forces prevent harm on people, cattle, and land, bringing prosperity, happiness, and well-being.

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[79] Ibid.

They need to be kept happy and satisfied through regular sacrifices, while on the other hand the evil forces cause harm and require propitiation. It is believed that the dwelling place of the *Nad,* whether good or evil, is not in the heavens but among the people in various places in nature. *Kurukhar* consider deceased members of the family (*Pachbalar*) who have died a natural death as still existing but invisible and always willing to help the living.[80]

The *Kurukhar* recognize and worship one Supreme Being as God, known to them as Dharmes.[81] The word Dharmes is used for none other than the supreme invisible being. The *Kurukhs* offer special worship to Dharmes, who is regarded as superior to all benevolent spirits and capable of controlling the evil ones. Dharmes is appealed to in cases of extreme distress when the other spirits fail. A better insight into the attitude of the *Kurukhs* toward Dharmes can be obtained by the study of some of the *Kurukh* festivals, the *Sarhul* or spring festival being the most important.[82] Deosharan Bhagat, one of the advocates and defenders of the *Kurukh* religion, and Father John Lakhra, a *Kurukh* Catholic priest, conclusively opine that the *Kurukh* religion is monotheistic.[83] Lakhra explains:

> In spite of placating spirits, the Kurukhar are very strongly monotheistic because they believe in one Supreme Being whom they call Dharmes. It is Him they

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[80] John Lakra, *Tribal Culture: Selected Features* (Gumla, India: Florence Kujur, 2007), 14.

[81] According to Lakra, the God of the Kurukhar is Dharmes, and not Dharmesh. The word *Dharmes* is the nominative form of the masculine noun *Dharme*. In the Kurukh language, a masculine noun takes 's' at the end of the word, e.g., al-alas, pachgi –pachgis. Thus, the word *Dharmes* is the combination of Dharme plus s, meaning the Supreme God, the most honored One. It is genuine *Kurukh* word and it should not be forced into a sanscritized Dharmesh, which then translates as the God of Dharma (way of religion).

[82] Francis Pereira, *The Faith Tradition of the Kurukhar (Uraons)* (Delhi: Indian Society for Promoting Christian Knowledge, 2007), 526-527.

[83] John Lakra, *Tribal Culture: Selected Features* (Gumla, India: Florence Kujur, 2007), 18.

> worship and adore, not the spirits. They worship Dharmes alone, they merely appease, propitiate and pacify the spirits. Even the benevolent spirits, like the ancestor spirits, are just venerated, not worshipped. For these tribals, Dharmes is the Supreme Being, Creator, Protector, Preserver, Providence, Controller of all creatures: spirits and human beings, Punisher of the wicked and Forgiver of sinners. He is eternal, without beginning and end, omnipotent and omniscient. He is their God, Lord and Master. When all else fails them, Dharmes is the last resort, to whom they finally turn for help, saying, "Ak kugan inimr'aday" (Finally Thou art our only refuge).[84]

Dharmes, who is regarded as the originator of humanity and of the benevolent spirits, is given pre-eminence over all other spiritual beings.[85] John Lakra opines: "Thus the word Dharmes is the combination of Dharm-es meaning the Supreme God, the most Honoured one."[86] Following Dharmes in the hierarchy are two principals: the principal of good and the principal of evil, also symbolized by the evil eye and the evil tongue. Dharmes is believed to be superior to the principal of evil and to have taught humankind how to break the power of the evil eye and of the evil tongue.[87] *Palkansna,* the highest form of sacrifices, is offered to Dharmes alone during significant occasions and milestones in family and community life such as births, marriages, deaths, and while hunting, sowing, harvesting, and transplanting. Dharmes alone is offered sacrifices in white color (white fowl, white goat) and clear water, while offerings to other spirits are not white and rice beer is offered in the place of clear water.[88] The transcendence and supremacy of Dharmes over all other supernatural spirits and powers is thus established.

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[84] Ibid., 20.

[85] Appendix D, Plate 14.

[86] Ibid., 21.

[87] Karma Oraon, *The Spectrum of Tribal Religion in Bihar: A Study of Continuity & Change Among the Oraon of Chotanagpur* (Varanasi, India: Kishor Vidya Niketan, 1988), 69.

[88] John Lakra, *Tribal Culture: Selected Features* (Gumla, India: Florence Kujur, 2007), 68.

Further, it is noteworthy especially for this study that Dharmes is not remembered and revered at certain times during special occasions and times of need alone, but the *Kurukhar* live in the awareness of Dharmes' constant presence always and in all activities. Lakra observes, "He is not otiose, or distant as anthropologists say. Even in their daily life, in meetings, *panchayats,* and oath taking ceremonies they invoke God to be their witness saying, '*Maiyan Dharmes, Kiyya Panchar'* (God above, panches below)."[89]

The *Oraon* never address the supreme being as Father or Lord except during the *Danda Katta* ceremony. Dharmes is otherwise always called grandfather. The relationship between a grandparent and a grandchild is quite significant in the *Oraon* culture. It entails a closer relationship than that of a child and a parent. It includes what anthropologists call a "joking relationship" exuding greater friendship and intimacy.[90] For example, an *Oraon* man would jokingly refer to his female grandchild as his wife and helper.[91]

Lakra says, "The idea of God or the supreme Spirit is to all intents and purposes separated in the mind of the Oraon from the great luminary of the day, the Sun. And it would appear more reasonable to hold that Dharmes is not the personification of an element of nature. The Oraon regards Him anterior to all."[92] According to the creation myth, it is Dharmes who creates the sun, the moon, spirits, and everything. Thus he cannot be identified with any element of nature.

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[89] Ibid., 20-21.

[90] Ibid., 7.

[91] Ibid.

[92] Ibid., 22.

The *Oraon* also believe in a hierarchy of good and evil spirits and potentially benevolent ancestor spirits. These are not revered and worshiped as gods and goddesses as one may perceive; on the other hand, obeisance is preferred toward these spirits, either seeking blessing from the beneficent or to ward off the malevolent. The beneficent spirits are objects of worship and religion, whereas the malevolent and evil spirits are objects of *Kurukh* magic.[93] The *Kurukhar,* unlike other tribal people, have no images of the deities and spirits. Tirkey sums up their reasoning as follows:

> Adivasis worship only one Supreme God whom the Oraons call "Dharmes" and the Mundas and others call "Sing Bonga" symbolically "The Sun God." Thus the religion of the Adivasis is monotheism contrary to polytheism where several gods and goddesses are worshipped. "Dharmes" / "Sing Bonga", the Supreme God of the Adivasis (Oraon / and Munda tribes) is omnipotent, omniscient and omnipresent, yet invisible in the Nature. In the simple concept of the tribals, making an image of their God is unimaginable. To make a material structure for an immense Being is unthinkable. Hence for their Dharmes / Sing Bonga, there is no statue, no image, no temple either in their ancestral religion—the Addi Dharma. "Sarna", an open sacred grove of sal trees, is the normal place where they worship their Supreme God. Here lies their spiritual ideology, and here speak their philosophy and theology, which many a modern writer sadly misses to understand the tribal ethos.[94]

As was mentioned earlier, the *Kurukhar* also have an overwhelming sense of fear of the evil eye and the evil mouth of hostile persons.[95] It is such fear that drives them to the belief in and practice of witchcraft; their belief in sickness leading to death as a result of the work and influence of evil spirits (*pugri-bhuts*) compels them to seek the help of witch doctors and exorcism.

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[93] Fidelis de Sa, *Crisis in Chota Nagpur* (Bangalore, India: A Redemptoris Publication, 1975), 31.

[94] Mahli Livins Tirkey, *Tribal Origins and Culture* (Delhi, India: L. Tirkey, 2013), 84.

[95] Ibid.

Religious Ideals and Morals

Kurukh custom and tradition direct and set the moral standards for the individual and the community, with the elders considered custodians. To always live in harmony with fellow tribals and remain on good terms with Dharmes and the spirits is the ideal life a *Kurukh* would desire. Along with it, the *Kurukhar* like to be debt free, have enough to eat and drink, be generous with hospitality, and spend their leisure in singing, dancing, and drinking rice beer.[96]

The traditional tribal code recognizes a divine sanction for moral conduct. Dharmes, the supreme omniscient and omnipotent being and one who commits no evil, as the guardian of morality, is believed to punish all wrongdoing against customary morality with sickness, death, or other calamities. Along with adequate reparation to the wronged tribe-fellow, tribal custom prescribes the sacrifice of a white cock or a white goat to Dharmes for the recompense of certain offences against social laws.[97]

Ostracism and excommunication from the village are the sanctions for practicing witchcraft and other forms of magic. It is believed that even if a person who harmed others or their cattle goes undetected and prospers in life for a time, eventually punishment will befall through spirits one has invoked or from Dharmes. The *Kurukh* believe that penalty for wrongdoing will be suffered while living and not after death, or that one's sons may suffer for the sins of their parents.[98] S.C. Roy adds, "The Oraon's religion, which is essentially communal or tribal, has helped to strengthen social unity

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[96] Sarat Chandra Roy, *Oraon Religion &Customs* (Calcutta: Editions Indian, 1972), 9-10.

[97] Ibid.

[98] Ibid.

and quickened the sense of social responsibility, and his concept of rightness is bound up with his social or tribal consciousness."[99]

Kurukh Festivals, Song, and Dance

The elaborate celebration of festivals, song, and dance are an intricate part of the fabric of *Kurukh* culture and life; therefore, they call for special mention.[100] All festivals, and the *Kurukhar* celebrate a host of them through the year, are related to agriculture and include song and dance. Every season and every occasion calls for a song with a unique tune, drums played to a unique beat, and dance to a unique step. The songs are reflective of the seasons and in harmony with nature, and most of them are sung accompanied to drums and dance. It is often said in the Kurux language, "Ekna dim tokna, Baa'na dim parna," meaning, "Walking is dancing and talking is singing." The songs can be heard over the mountains while the people are gathering firewood or fruit in groups. The heaviness of difficult labor while transplanting paddy during the monsoons is lifted by the songs they sing in unison. The joy of marriage and childbirth and festivals is shared as a community accompanied by special songs, dances, and drum beats for each occasion, strengthening community ties. M.L. Tirkey sums up the *Kurukhar* approach: "They work together, sing and dance together and live together despite unprecedented struggles to survive under the threat of modernization, globalization and industrial development that threatens their wellbeing."[101] Two of the main tribal festivals deserve attention on account of the tribal ethos they signify.

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[99] Ibid., 10.

[100] See Appendix D, Plate 11.

[101] Mahli Livins Tirkey, *Tribal Origins and Culture* (Delhi, India: L. Tirkey, 2013), 83.

The Sarhul Spring Festival and the "Lady of the Environment"

The Sarhul festival, also called Xaddi by the *Kurukhar,* is the most important festival celebrated during spring. It celebrates the blossoming of plants and trees and edible leaves and tubers. The festival is held in the *sarna* (sacred grove) where the Sal[102] tree blossoms.[103] No one is allowed to gather, pick, or eat any of the blossoms, leaves, flowers, or fruit until Sarhul is celebrated and the community has feasted together.[104] The Sarhul festival unfolds not only the *Oraons*' cultural beauty but also their deep philosophical concept of their god Dharmes, the creator, mother earth, and the "Lady of the Environment," whom they call Chala Paccho/Mata.[105]

With the celebration of this festival begins the spring farming work on the fields. This is celebrated honoring Dharmes the supreme god through whose benevolence timely rains are expected, and crops and people are protected from disease and pestilence. The sarhul grove within which spirits dwell is also the provider of building material for the *Kurukh's* house and it needs to be protected from harm.

The Karam Festival and Tribal Honor of Women

The *Karam* festival is a major festival celebrated by the *Kurukhar* along with other *Adivasis* of the region.[106] The festival is celebrated with great gusto and grandeur in the month of Kuwar (August - September) every year. *Karam* festivals are related to

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[102] Commonly found all over the Chotanagpur plateau—are loaded with luxurious, cream-colored Sarai blossoms. From the word *Sal* or *sarjom* in Mundari, and its flower, *sarai,* comes the name Sarhul.

[103] See Appendix D, Plate 13.

[104] Sarat Chandra Roy, *Oraon Religion &Customs* (Calcutta: Edition Indian, 1972), 142.

[105] Mahli Livins Tirkey, *Tribal Origins and Culture* (Delhi, India: L. Tirkey, 2013), 61.

[106] Reetu Raj Ekka, "The Karam Festival of the Oraons: An Ethno-linguistic and Semiotic Analysis" (PhD diss., Jawharlal Nehru University, New Delhi, India, 2005), 62. In Shodhganga: a reservoir of Indian theses at INFLIBNET, accessed April 21, 2015, http://hdl.handle.net/10603/23684.

agriculture and celebrated in honor of women.[107] Following the transplantation of rice, people are left without work for a month or two. It is then that they celebrate the annual visit of their *Karam Raja* god Dharmes, symbolically present in the Karambranch (*Nauclea Parvifolia*) that is ceremoniously cut and carried to the village by young men. Karam invokes Dharmes' blessing and protection on the crops in the field and pleads for good rainfall that will result in a good harvest. According to Kurukh belief, it is through Dharmes' benevolence that the Sun arises, gives light for a good harvest.[108] Karam is also celebrated for the well-being of the entire community, particularly for the young maidens of marriageable age.[109]

The Karam is essentially a festival of women and particularly of maidens. Even married daughters and sisters of the *Oraons* of a village come to their parents' or brothers' houses to take part in the Karam festivities of their village.[110] The story is repeated during the Karam festival of Dharmes of two women named Parbatiya and Sinagi who saved the *Kurukh* people at the time of need. Parbatiya is the mother goddess who protected two human kids from Sira-Sita Nale (an evil spirit) and thereby protected the human race, and the tribal princess Sinagi of Rohtasgarh fought the enemies and finally led the king and the people to a safer place through a secret tunnel of the fort. Dharmes had chosen these two great women as his instruments to save the tribal race

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[107] See Appendix D, Plate 12.

[108] Reetu Raj Ekka, "The Karam Festival of the Oraons: An Ethno-linguistic and Semiotic Analysis" (PhD diss., Jawharlal Nehru University, New Delhi, India, 2005), 62. In Shodhganga: a reservoir of Indian theses at INFLIBNET, accessed April 21, 2015, http://hdl.handle.net/10603/23684.

[109] Ibid., 71-77.

[110] Ibid.

when it was in danger of extinction.[111] Tirkey points out that "it is the occasion for the Tribal maidens to pray to God asking his blessings to emulate the achievements of Parbatiya and Sinagi and play their role as future mothers in a befitting manner to continue the tribal generation and protect it."[112]

The primary religious belief of the *Kurukhar* in Dharmes as a supreme being and important festivals commemorating certain mythological and legendary events related to Dharmes have been discussed so far. The Karam festival celebrating *Kurukh* maidens is highlighted not only because it is one of the most important festivals but also to point out that their women are held in equal esteem by the *Kurukhar*. This is of significance for this study, as women's critical role in discipleship will be pointed out in chapter five.

Any current study of cultural change of the tribals of Chotanagpur must include the impact of Christian mission. Sahay Keshari posits:

> The Christian Missionaries in Chotanagpur may be credited for having created a landmark in the socio-economic life of the people of this area since their advent ushered in definite era in the history of the so far background people and opened up altogether a new chapter in which subsequent activities of the Missionaries started having profound effect on the socio-economic and cultural life of the people in number of significant ways.[113]

Among the Christian missions most widespread is that of the Roman Catholics, who worked in the fields of education, health, and sanitation.[114] Early Catholic missionaries

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[111] Ibid.

[112] Ibid.

[113] Keshari N. Sahay, *Christianity and Culture Change in India* (New Delhi, India: Inter-India Publications, 1986), 81.

[114] Karma Oraon, *The Spectrum of Tribal Religion in Bihar: A Study of Continuity & Change Among the Oraon of Chotanagpur* (Varanasi, India: Kishor Vidya Niketan, 1988), 110.

also helped the tribals reclaim their lands. This served as a catalyst for a significant people movement in the mid-nineteenth century.[115]

The Advent of Christianity into Chotanagpur

The advent of Christianity into Chotanagpur[116] beginning in the mid-nineteenth century created an enormous change in the socio-economic life of the *Kurukh* people. It was a time of unbearable oppression of the *Adivasis* by the landlords (*Zamindars*), who were taking their land by force, and by the attempts by the British forces to quell any rebellion. It is significant to note that in the face of such exploitations of these indigenous people, the gospel presented by the missionaries, along with their moral support and legal assistance to regain rights over their land, prepared a fertile ground for mass conversions to Christianity.[117] Until the 1970s, only the Lutherans, Anglicans, and the Roman Catholics had their presence established in Jharkhand.[118]

The German Evangelical Lutheran Mission

The work of the German Lutheran Mission started with the arrival of four European missionaries sent by Pastor Gossner: E. Schats, F. Batsch, A. Brant, and H. Sanke from Calcutta. The first gothic-style church building was constructed and

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[115] Keshari N. Sahay, *Christianity and Culture Change in India* (New Delhi: Inter-India Publications, 1986), 86-89.

[116] Appendix D, Plate 4 showing Chotanagpur.

[117] Keshari N. Sahay, *Christianity and Culture Change in India* (New Delhi: Inter-India Publications, 1986).

[118] Philip S. J. Ekka, *Tribal Movements: A Study in Social Change* (Chhattisgarh, India: Tribal Research and Documentation Centre, 2003), 150-153.

dedicated on Christmas Eve of 1855. Thus, the first mission station in Ranchi was established.[119]

New converts gained zeal and courage to stand boldly against their oppressors and defend themselves against the encroachment of their land by the *Zamindars* as a result of their relationship with European missionaries, whom they found friendly and helpful. The new converts further benefitted through Western education, introduced for the first time in the region by the Lutheran mission.[120] By 1872, there were five schools, three of them in Ranchi and two in neighboring villages; a seminary for the training of native pastors; and a boarding school for the training of catechists and other vocations. The schools continued to grow in proportion to the increasing numbers of new converts. Education to this day has been a significant contribution of the Lutheran Mission to Chotanagpur.[121]

The Church of England Mission

The missionary work of the Church of England, though claimed to have started off well, was not without controversy and a sense of competition, which brought division among the people. It is reported that in 1869, a few of the senior missionaries of the Lutheran mission severed their relations with their church.[122] They, along with 5,000 of their converts, came under the umbrella of the Church of England with the support of Bishop Milman, stationed in Calcutta.

New converts were being made, and educational and vocational institutions were started. Ekka points out that "a striking feature of the Anglican missionary undertaking

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[119] Ibid., 132.

[120] See Appendix D, Plate 15.

[121] Ibid., 134-140.

[122] Ibid., 120-132.

was the solicitude to found a viable local church."[123] This event marked a shift from the mission compound strategy to the formation of local churches. Schools and church buildings were built, and the work continued to grow both in Ranchi and surrounding villages.

The Catholic Mission

The Catholic mission entered Jharkhand in 1860. Between 1885 and 1889, more than 70,000 people were converted.[124] This phenomenal growth is attributed to the legal support received by the *Adivasis* from the Catholic missionaries, particularly Father Lievens, to reclaim their lands.[125] The Catholic mission has made a remarkable contribution to the people of the land through its initiatives in education and health. Philip Ekka says, "Next to the state, the Catholic mission has the largest network of schools in Chotanagpur. Since 1908, the mission has persistently followed the policy of equipping every village with an infant and lower primary school, every station with a middle vernacular school, and the centre with a high school."[126] Apart from the ministries of health and education, one of the unique contributions of the Catholic mission to the region was the formation of the Chotanagpur Catholic Co-operative Credit Society. The normal methodology of early mission work required new converts to totally break away from culture and community ("break caste") and required the development of the mission

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[123] Ibid., 130.

[124] Ibid., 134.

[125] Peter S.J. Tete and Constant Lievens, *Constant Lievens and the History of the Catholic Church in Chotanagpur* (Ranchi, India: Archbishop's House, 1993).

[126] Philip S. J. Ekka, *Tribal Movements: A Study in Social Change* (Chhattisgarh, India: Tribal Research and Documentation Centre, 2003), 147-151.

compounds. The focus was not on any particular people group; converts were from *Adivasi* groups such as the *Munda*, the *Ho,* and others.[127]

The Present Time

Coming to the present time, it is observed that the outreach of these mainline missions is significantly low in comparison to the new Indigenous missions;[128] having become stagnant, they have lost their pioneering spirit.[129] New converts were initially drawn into the city of Ranchi and supported there. It was not until the late 1970s that indigenous missions such as the Indian Pentecostal Church, The Indian Apostolic Mission, Indian Evangelical Mission, Gospel Echoing Missionary Society, the Friends Missionary Prayer Band, and several smaller missions found their way into Jharkhand by sending cross-cultural missionaries into these unreached regions. Their missionary and evangelistic efforts, however, were geared toward unreached *Adivasis* in general without any particular plan or strategy to reach the *Kurukh* or any other specific tribe.

A few *Kurukh* Christians from the Lutheran and Anglican churches, having received theological training in South India and having come under the influence of the Pentecostal movement, returned to Jharkhand with an evangelistic fervor. They started planting churches and forming small house fellowships of converts in the neighboring villages of Ranchi.[130] The entry of the Assemblies of God denominational effort from Calcutta in the early 1980s is another milestone in the history of recent mission work.

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[127] Ibid.

[128] Ibid., 150.

[129] Ibid.

[130] Information gleaned through personal interviews during field research.

The *Jesus Film* in the local *Adivasi* dialects, reaching into the remote villages and *bastis* (*hamlets*)of Jharkhand, must receive special mention. For the first time, *Adivasi* people were seeing a movie, and one in their own language (*Kurukh* and *Sadhri*), with a story of miracles and teachings that greatly appealed to them. Even though churches were not formed as an immediate result, the effort brought an awareness of the transforming power of the gospel among masses of people.

By inference, some of the above are factors that have triggered the present "third wave" response to the gospel and the growth of the indigenous church. The advent of Christianity initially brought an awareness of equality and human dignity. Education introduced by early missions paved the way for the development and empowerment of the tribal populations. Millenarian secular movements have set precedence as a way of liberating themselves from oppression and suppression. The *Kurukh* religious beliefs and worldview in themselves contain elements that make the gospel readily acceptable.

Distinct Cultural Traits and Pre-existent Worldview Inducing Positive Response to Christ's Invitation

Several studies have indicated that the *Adivasis* of India, along with several groups of *Dalits,* have been more responsive to the gospel than others from the time of early missions. This conclusion has been found to be true of the *Kurukhar* as well. What is the reason or reasons? What is it about the gospel that is more attractive to these people than to others in India? According to F. Hrangkuma, such a response could fall under two

categories: first, the contributory factors, and second, the immediate reasons for conversion.[131]

Contributory Factors

The contributory factors are economic, social, and political change; the socio-cultural context and worldview of the *Kurukhar*; and the personality of the people that includes their attitude to outsiders, their outlook, and their response to change. Hrangkuma, quoting Paul Pierson, calls this phenomenon "the contextual climatic condition"—factors that contribute to the openness and receptivity of people for new things and innovative changes.[132]

A quick overview of the history of movements among the *Kurukhar* reveals several factors for the conversion. First, it cannot be denied that there is a divine work of God that continues among his people in some unique way. In the case of the *Kurukhar*, they were waiting for a liberator to be sent by Dharmes, their supreme god, to free them from oppression and exploitation. Second, the combination of the poor living conditions that led to land alienation, indebtedness, and subsequent slavery to the landlords and the oppression and exploitation of the *Adivasis* definitely contributed to their favorable response to Christianity.[133] Even though this response is not the immediate reason for the conversions of the *Kurukhar* in Chotanagpur, it was indeed a contributing factor, especially in the large movement toward Catholicism. Third, perhaps a much more important factor, is that the pre-existent worldview of the people is close to the Christian

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[131] Hrangkhuma and Joy Thomas, *Christ Among the Tribals* (Bangalore, India: Published for Fellowship of Indian Missiologists by SAIACS Press, 2007), 31.

[132] Ibid., 33.

[133] Keshari N. Sahay, *Christianity and Culture Change in India* (New Delhi: Inter-India Publications, 1986), 43.

worldview. In other words, Christianity finds a smooth entry into their world and daily life.[134]

The following are a few important characteristics of the *Kurukhar* worldview that may be considered as contributing factors to their receptivity to the gospel and their conversion to Christianity in significant numbers:

1. The belief of the *Kurukhar* in Dharmes, the unseen supreme being and creator, makes it easier for them to understand and accept God the Father of the Judeo-Christian faith.
2. The belief in good and evil spirits leads them to believe in the indwelling presence and power of the Holy Spirit.
3. The absence of images representing god and spirits is helpful in leading them to believe in the unseen, triune God.
4. Belief in restless spirits of ancestors needing to be put to rest[135] provides an inroad into and understanding of eternal torment in hell and the peace of heaven and eternal life.
5. The self-governing village administrative system and community life helps them understand the church as "koinonia"—the care-giving fellowship of believers—and the need for self-governance within this fellowship.
6. *Sarna*, which is the practice of *Kurukh* religious rituals, is open to every *Kurukh,* male and female.[136] Even though priests (*pahar*) are available to help and guide,

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[134] Philip S.J. Ekka, *Tribal Movements: A Study in Social Change* (Chhattisgarh, India: Tribal Research and Documentation Centre, 2003), 132-151.

[135] Karma Oraon, *The Spectrum of Tribal Religion in Bihar: A Study of Continuity & Change Among the Oraon of Chotanagpur* (Varanasi, India: Kishor Vidya Niketan, 1988), 35-50.

priestly duties are not claimed as the sole right and responsibility of the priests. Such a belief is helpful in conveying the Christian responsibility (the priesthood of every believer) of the new converts to witness and serve.

Immediate Factors

Current research on the field through personal experience and interviews concluded that the immediate causes of conversion of the *Kurukhar* have most often been a mixture of social and spiritual elements.[137] Most were converted as a result of a "power encounter"—exorcism and healing, the fear of going to hell, a desire to go to heaven, and similar factors. Several became Christians from being attracted to a better socio-economic condition. It is recorded that people were also desirous of ridding themselves of the fear of evil spirits.[138] The protection Christ offers against evil, the fellowship of other believers, and the human dignity that Christianity offers also were found to attract the *Kurukhar* to the Christian faith. New believers have indicated that they were captured by the love of Jesus and in response to the lessening appeal of their old religion and practices. Answered prayer for healing and to escape from oppression of sorts was one of the common reported causes for conversion as well.[139]

Writing about the conversion of *Adivasis* in India in general, Hrangkuma summarizes and affirms that

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[136] Ibid., 27-28.

[137] Documents and records of *Kurukh* conversions available with the Church Growth Research Center and the India Gospel League substantiate this hypothesis.

[138] Hrangkhuma and Joy Thomas, *Christ Among the Tribals* (Bangalore, India: Published for Fellowship of Indian Missiologists by SAIACS Press, 2007), 26.

[139] Ibid., 24-26.

> A combination of social, economic, political oppression and exploitation of the Kurukh, the disruption of the traditional cultures of the Adivasis especially by the British imposition of rule and administration, the possibility of cultural continuity in Christianity albeit in modified ones, the appeal of the gospel, especially the power of healing, over evil spirits, promise of heaven and eternal life, peace and a change to a better life and the like together have made Christianity the best option for the tribals for their betterment both here and hereafter.[140]

The above statement holds true for the *Kurukhar* as well in their response to the gospel.

Toward a "Third Wave" Healthy *Kurukh* Church

Current research findings indicate that present church growth among the *Kurukhar* is not necessarily the result of a mass movement as in the past. Group conversions are occasional and limited to smaller communities and extended families of twenty-five to thirty individuals. Primary growth occurs through individual conversions, which are quite extensive. Although arriving at exact numbers is difficult because of the diversity of ministries, individuals, and small indigenous organizations involved, the Church Growth Research Center estimates between 25,000 and30,000*Kurukh* individuals alone are part of the growing "third wave" indigenous church.[141] More exhaustive research would reveal exact facts and figures.

A few essential characteristics of these third wave churches[142] need to be highlighted in order to illustrate the distinction between the mainline denominational churches that have been discussed earlier and to call attention to the dynamic overlap of pre-existent *Kurukh* worldviews on the developing new Christian worldview.

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[140] Ibid., 28.

[141] Information acquired through a personal interview with The Director of the Church Growth Association of India, Chennai.

[142] Information gleaned through personal interviews with church planters, believers, and leaders during field research and in the course of ministry and reading.

1. These new churches are birthed through indigenous witness.
2. They are led by (mostly) untrained, uneducated converts who are supported by the offerings of the believers and from the produce of their own lands.
3. They exist without external organizational/denominational support, assistance, or affiliation.
4. New believers are instrumental in the ongoing numerical growth through personal witness and sharing of their conversion experience.
5. People are converted primarily through the prayer ministry of the leader and believers for healings, deliverance from witchcraft, and exorcism from possession of evil spirits.
6. Motivation to convert in the present context is usually spiritual rather than socio-economic or political in comparison to the previous missions era.
7. New converts are rarely deterred by persecution.
8. Believers enjoy and look forward to the mutual fellowship, gatherings, and ecstatic worship. Believers desire to be prayed for and blessed by the pastor/leader.
9. Bible teaching and Christian education is minimal, if present at all, and believers have very limited biblical knowledge.

Although the third wave is experiencing quantitative growth, obvious deficiencies pertaining to spiritual health, leadership, theology, and discipleship may be identified. Hence, adequate measures to infuse spiritual health into the *Kurukh* churches need to be urgently considered. Christian Schwartz, following extensive research and study of one thousand churches from a cross-section of traditions and denominations globally, outlines

certain hallmarks of healthy churches[143] that can be applied to the present *Kurukh* churches. Donald Mac Nair's work in *Practices of a Healthy Church* complements and supports the work.[144] The following is an outline of the benchmarks for measuring church health:

1. Contagious and authentic spirituality of believers. Christians must demonstrate their spirituality through an authentic lifestyle witness that attracts others to the faith.
2. Contextual, credible, and dynamic witness and ministry of believers. Every Christian convert needs to be trained and equipped for ministry so that evangelism is not perceived as a program or event but becomes an integral part of the zealous life of the believer.
3. Care-giving fellowship among believers—true *koinonia* practiced and lived within the fellowship of believers and expressed in the community to which they belong. Compassionate outreach of community-conscious local congregations. The focus should shift back to the function of the local church in transforming the community, breaking free from the mentality that the church is meant to be a safe house, an asylum, and a haven of refuge for believers. The church is God's channel; therefore, ties with the community must remain strong and must be preserved.
4. Compelling, inspiring, and stimulating worship. Humankind was created to worship its maker. Life's fulfillment is found in true worship of God. Worship is

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[143] Christian A. Schwarz, *Natural Church Development: A Guide to Eight Essential Qualities of Healthy Churches* (Carol Stream, IL: Church Smart Resources, 1996).

[144] Donald J. MacNair and Esther L. Meek, *The Practices of a Healthy Church: Biblical Strategies for Vibrant Church Life and Ministry* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R Pub., 1999).

human response to a gracious God, and it needs to be placed in this context if it is to be properly understood.

5. Continuous and robust Christian education. Theological education, sound doctrines, and a profound knowledge and understanding of God's Word is the birthright of every believer. It is the responsibility of leadership to ensure that it is made available.
6. Consistent, convicting, motivating, and balanced preaching.
7. Collaborative leadership.
8. Constant and compelling global vision; believers are taught to live in awareness as citizens of God's kingdom and are educated on their role in the fulfillment of the Great Commission.

Considering the above essential elements for church health, Christian education, discipleship, and leadership development become the three pillars on which all the others rest. Discipleship essentially is the grounding of new Christians, giving them basic orientation to the Christian life, including the ability to access their own spiritual food from Scripture. McCallum states, "Discipleship and church planting movements are intimately linked. Discipleship is a means of leadership development that permits multiplication, because it doesn't require feeding leaders through a central hub, like a seminary or Bible school."[145] Spiritual growth is a natural outcome when believers in a local church are motivated and equipped for evangelism and to disciple others. The competency required for effective leadership develops naturally as a result.[146]

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[145] Dennis McCallumand Jessica Lowery, *Organic Disciple Making: Mentoring Others into Spiritual Maturity and Leadership* (Houston, TX: Touch Publications, 2006), 81.

[146] Ibid., 11.

Alan Hirsh points out: "A renewed focus on leadership is absolutely essential to the renewal and growth of the church."[147] In a non-hierarchical *Adivasi* culture, where leadership is related more to function than position, the five foundational leadership functions and ministries that we read in Ephesians 4:11 are appropriate. Hirsh elucidates further, providing the following definitions of "the five foundational leadership functions" without ascribing them to any office:

> *Apostolic function*, usually conducted translocally, pioneers new missional works and oversees their development; *prophetic function* discerns the spiritual realities in a given situation and communicates them in a timely and appropriate way to further the mission of God's people; *evangelistic function* communicates the gospel in such a way that people respond in faith and discipleship; *pastoral function* shepherds the people of God by leading, nurturing, protecting and caring for them; and *teaching function* communicates the revealed wisdom of God so that the people of God learn how to obey all that Christ has commended them.[148]

The need for ongoing Christian education stands out prominently, posing a greater challenge since a majority of the people in review are low- or non-literates. They are of the oral tradition. Much deliberate and strategic effort is to be taken to construct material and methods for approaching such an oral culture with Christian education.

A cursory glance may give the perception that progress is slow; nevertheless, a steady and constant indigenous theologizing and inculturation is going on among these tribal Christians. It has happened among the totally Christianized tribes such as the Mizo and Naga in the North East. Hrangkuma affirms that "in older indigenous churches such as among the Kurukhs, the Mundas and the Kharias in central India, and the Garos and Khasis in Meghalaya, where the entire members of such tribes have not embraced Christianity, the same progress in terms of contextualization of theology and inculturation

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[147] Michael Frost and Alan Hirsch, *The Shaping of Things to Come: Innovation and Mission for the 21st-Century Church* (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson Publishers, 2003), 167.

[148] Ibid., 169.

of the church have been taking place."[149] Even in the midst of such positive progress, fallback to old practices, syncretism, and even total abandonment and reconversion are occasionally seen. In considering the present situation with the *Kurukhar* in Jharkhand, the challenge is to find ways to prevent such degeneration and regression and equip the *Kurukh* church through Christian education, to support leadership development for sustainability, and to disciple *Kurukh* believers effectively for vibrant witness and community impact.

A close analysis of the present condition reveals that inculturation, contextualization, effective discipleship, leadership development, and Christian education are primary needs. Of all these, Christian religious education (CRE) is indeed the centerpiece that requires the church's immediate attention. For the *Kurukh* who is an *Adivasi* for whom life is integrated and interconnected, CRE must be understood as a lifelong process of teaching and learning about life—God, self, family, the church, the society, and the world at large from a Christian standpoint and not just learning about Christianity.[150] Viewed in a narrow sense, CRE could be understood as an exclusive activity of the church for the preservation of religious beliefs and Judeo-Christian practices. From a broader perspective, CRE would promote education, equipping, and empowerment for transformation and the ushering in of the values of God's reign. Such an understanding of, approach to, and implementation of Christian education in the present context would undoubtedly bring about a total spiritual and social transformation from which the meeting of other needs would become a natural overflow.

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[149] Hrangkhuma and Joy Thomas, *Christ Among the Tribals* (Bangalore, India: Published for Fellowship of Indian Missiologists by SAIACS Press, 2007), 31.

[150] Akheto Sema, *Understanding the Nature and Purpose of Christian Religious Education*, Rev. ed. (Delhi: Indian Society for Promoting Christian Knowledge, 2011).

Following the observations that have been made in this chapter on the social, cultural, and religious background of the *Kurukhar*, the next chapter will deal with issues related to the health of the growing churches among these people. An overview of their customs, traditions, beliefs, and practices that are relevant to this study has already been laid out. Related questions will be addressed, seeking methods to sustain present Christward movements and positive responses. Concurrently, external inputs needed to infuse spiritual health into the growing number of churches among these people will be identified.

CHAPTER FOUR

This chapter draws from the essential background information covered in previous chapters such as the advent of Christianity in India and the beginnings of the indigenous church, particularly among the *Kurukhar* of Jharkhand. Following the definitions of key terms and concepts in chapter one, the study moved on to an overview of Christian people movements and the growth patterns of the indigenous churches in Latin America, Africa, and Asia. The theory that such significant growth is among the subaltern people of little traditions and that it is a unique third wave of church growth is then highlighted. The next chapter provides in-depth information of the life and social environment of the *Kurukh* people and their religious beliefs and practices, which are conducive to the growth of the churches among them.

The discussion on indigeneity during the nineteenth century (referred in the first chapter of this study) was in reference to the three widely known indigenous mission principles of self-governance, self-support, and self-propagation. It is crucial now for a more robust definition of the autochthonous church to include culture and context as well. Roger E. Hedlund opines:

> Indigeneity has to do with rootedness in the culture of a people in contrast to that which is alien, imported, or foreign. Indigenous Christianity affirms the validity of local culture and the integrity and selfhood of autonomous non-western churches. This is not to be confused with the so-called indigenous principles (self-governing, self-supporting, self-propagating) of Rufus Anderson, Henry Venn, John Nevius, and Melvin Hodges of the modern missionary movement. 'Indigenous Christianity' is a relatively new field for academic research in South Asia.[1]

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[1] Roger E. Hedlund, ed., *The Oxford Encyclopaedia of South Asian Christianity* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2012), 336.

Hedlund further posits: "Indigenous Christianity is an authentic signature of faith wherever the gospel has taken root. The phenomenon was true of what are now the established Christian traditions of America and Europe, and is equally true of the emerging Christianity of Asia, Africa, and the Pacific region."[2]

The discussion in this chapter seeks to further elucidate the two additional concepts of self-missionizing and self-theologizing as being fundamental to strengthening and retaining the indigeneity of the *Kurukh* church and sustaining the current movement as well. Having presented and discussed the definitions of *contextualization* and *inculturation* early on, this study now turns to an examination of biblical and historical models of contextualization and inculturation. The rationale and need for structuring a theology that is relevant to the context of the *Kurukhar* is proposed. This chapter closes with the submission of a few ideas that may be considered for such a venture.

From Indigenization to Contextualization and Inculturation

It is imperative, especially in a world that is rapidly globalizing, that those involved in an attempt to communicate the transforming message of the gospel and implant faith in Christ give adequate thought to human contexts and how they mold people.[3] The contexts in which humans live clearly shape what is seen, felt, experienced, and valued; they often determine what is believed without question to be the truth, rightful and proper and, in due course, are assumed by people within these contexts to be

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[2] Ibid., 337.

[3] Paul G. Hiebert, *The Gospel in Human Contexts: Anthropological Explorations or Contemporary Missions* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2009), 18.

universal.[4] From its very inception, the church has had to grapple with how the gospel of Jesus Christ relates to cultures.[5] It has been a critical issue in the life, health, and sustainability of the church from the day of Pentecost that sparked the progression of the Christian faith as it penetrated into multiple languages and cultures, accepting those languages and cultures as vehicles for people to both experience and effectively communicate the powerful message of God's love revealed through his son Jesus.[6] Scott Sunquist underscores the criticality of the intrinsic relation of the gospel and cultures thus:

> While the "Jesus story" becomes the "good news" only as it speaks to a particular people and connects with their symbols, addresses their needs, and awakens their creative energies, as the story of "God's love" it can never be identified with any particular expression of it. There is then a double dimension to the relation between the Gospel and cultures, namely, the inaccessibility of the Gospel story apart from its necessary embodiment in a particular culture and yet its transcendence and inexhaustibility over all cultures. The heart of the Christian story, expressed in the words, "the Word became flesh" implies such an intrinsic and double relation.[7]

As it has been observed previously, many efforts have been made, beginning with St. Thomas' visit, to bring the gospel to the diverse population and people groups of India. European missionaries, including those during the time of the British rule in India, made significant attempts to share the gospel. Unfortunately, many efforts did not bring lasting impact while others introduced harm rather than help into the spiritual status of the peoples of India.

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[4] Ibid.

[5] Scott W. Sunquist, *A Dictionary of Asian Christianity* (Grand Rapids, MI: W.B. Eerdmans, 2001), 313-315.

[6] Ibid.

[7] Ibid., 313.

Western colonialism in particular established the mostly unchallenged perception that Western religion and culture is superior to that of others. Beginning from the late sixteenth century in India, European culture became the standard by which all other cultures were measured; in the same vein, theology birthed in the West became the standard and norm for teaching the Christian faith and practicing it in India. A review of mission history repeatedly shows that the message of salvation and the manner in which it has been expressed in a particular culture have been most often mistakenly considered one and the same—by both the communicators and the receivers.[8]

It has become an all-too-common practice since early Western missions to make certain that new Christians conform to cultural norms and patterns introduced to them by those communicating the gospel. In most cases, these norms are imposed upon receptors, particularly in primitive and tribal contexts, condescendingly and without question, under the assumption that those cultures lack maturity or need advancement. Studies among the *Kurukh* people of Jharkhand on the Christian work that has taken place among them and their response to the Christian faith have revealed deficiencies from this approach that have resulted in a lack of adequate understanding of the faith, rejection of new believers by their kinsfolk on account of superimposed cultural practices that lack relevance, and believers' lack of biblical knowledge and spiritual disciplines.[9]

Culture is an integral part of indigeneity. The following statements, endorsed by theologians, call for due consideration here.

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[8] John Corrie, "Indigenous Peoples," in *Dictionary of Mission Theology: Evangelical Foundations,* ed. R. Paredes (Nottingham, England: Inter Varsity, 2007), 189.

[9] Information gleaned through the author's personal interviews and research also endorsed by Rev. Christ Sumit Abhay Kerketta in his book *Adivasi Theology* (Ranchi, India: Dept. of Adivasi Theology & Cultural Research, 2009).

A church, deeply rooted in God through Jesus Christ, an integral part of the Church Universal, may be said to be living and indigenous:

1. When its interpretation of Christ and its expression in worship and service, in customs and in art and architecture, incorporate the worthy characteristics of the people, while conserving at the same time the heritage of the Church in all lands and in all ages.[10]
2. When through it the spirit of Jesus Christ influences all phases of life, bringing to His service all the potentialities of both men and women.[11]
3. When it actively shares its life with its own community in which it finds itself.[12]
4. When it is alert to the problems of the times and, as a spiritual force in the community, courageously and sympathetically makes its contribution to their solution.[13]
5. When it is kindled with missionary ardor and the pioneering spirit.[14]

At the heart of this discussion lies the deep desire of the author, following in Paul G. Hiebert's footsteps, to embody in human contexts among the *Kurukh* people the divine revelation that has been given through Scripture in such manner that it will attract more

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[10] B.V. Subbamma, *Christ Confronts India: Indigenous Expression of Christianity in India* (Madras, India: Diocesan Press, 1973), 22.

[11] Ibid.

[12] Ibid.

[13] Ibid.

[14] Ibid.

of them to Christ and create a deep longing within to follow him in faith and belief, leading to the transformation of societies.[15]

A fuller understanding of Christianity among the *Kurukh* people will not emerge unless local culture is given due consideration. In the present context, foreignness identified in the church is bound to become a barrier for people of other faiths to consider following Christ and an obstacle for the expansion of the autochthonous church. It is obvious that the *Kurukh* people do not find any objectionable element in the person of Christ or reasons to accept him as Lord. But there is resistance to traditional forms of evangelism and the proclamation of the gospel. The acceptance of certain forms of worship, liturgy, and music is low because these forms of worship are alien to the local culture. Denominational divisions, understandable to many cultures, disrupt the sense of solidarity among an otherwise homogenous people group. Martin Alphonse suggests:

> Eventually, the error of cultural-absenteeism on the part of the Indian Church may possibly be corrected to a large extent by the maintenance of the dual characteristic of the Christians as both "Indian" and "Christian" at the same time. Evangelism in India can be most effective if and when the Gospel is contextualized at the point of a dynamic interaction between the culture and the *kerygma* of the Gospel.[16]

Currently the voices within India are getting louder against Christians for cultural insensitivity and intolerance toward other faiths. Unfortunately, this resistance and push-back seem to be justifiable when it is noticed that Christianity is being pushed as a faith accompanied by alien culture.[17] The reality that each society is tied to its own culture and

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[15] Paul G. Hiebert, *The Gospel in Human Contexts: Anthropological Explorations or Contemporary Missions* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2009), 17.

[16] M. Alphonse, *The Gospel For The Hindus* (Chennai, India: Mission Educational Books, 2001), 19.

[17] Dayanand Bharathi, *Living Water and Indian Bowl* (Delhi, India: ISPCK, 2004), 19.

every individual is part of the society in which he or she lives is undeniable.[18] Particularly in tribal cultures that are governed by customary law, people breaching cultural norms are perceived as breaking law. In anthropology, the word *custom* refers to the totality of socially acquired behavior patterns that are supported by tradition and generally exhibited by members of society.[19] To create a clearer definition, the more current expressions also used are "culture" and "tradition."[20] Gupta says that in a tribal society such as the *Kurukh*, the concepts of custom and tribe seem to go together. Custom is to such a society what law is to the state.[21] "Each is the expression and realization, to the measure of men's insight and ability, of the principles of right and justice."[22] *Tribe* and *tribal* are convenient terms, although sometimes considered derogatory, for indicating that a people still follow custom rather than law.

It is essential to find ways to minimize social and cultural dislocation in the process of *Kurukhar* moving to Christ. Their society is dominated and driven by its culture, and every individual of that society is subject to its dominance. Eugene Nida observes from biblical sources that God recognizes the distinctives and values of every culture; therefore, the relativism of the Bible to a culture is based on three principal factors:[23]

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[18] Eugene A. Nida, *Message and Mission: The Communication of the Christian Faith* (Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1990), 50.

[19] Jai Prakash Gupta, *The Customary Laws of the Munda & the Oraon* (Ranchi, India: Jharkhand Tribal Welfare Research Institute, 2002), 4.

[20] Ibid.

[21] Ibid., 4-5.

[22] Ibid., 4.

[23] B.V. Subbamma, *Christ Confronts India: Indigenous Expression of Christianity in India* (Madras, India: Diocesan, 1973), 13.

1. The endowment and opportunities of people[24]
2. The extent of revelation[25]
3. The cultural patterns of the society that are under consideration[26]

The Bible contains illustrations of God's desire to reveal Himself to all people within their own cultural framework and on its terms. An examination of a few of these biblical illustrations is in order. The narrative of Paul preaching to the Athenians (Acts 17) may be rightly highlighted as a good example.

In India and other Asian countries, from the beginning of the era of Christian missions, the church was molded in foreign forms of institution, liturgy, and theology;[27] however, it has been pointed out that from the early period, people have desired to turn to Christ without renouncing all of their culture.[28] To become Christian must be a religious and spiritual decision rather than racial, social, or cultural. It must be seen as a move to make Jesus Christ supreme in one's life and not as merely a move from one social, racial, or cultural cluster to another.[29]

The movement of a group of people to Christ is the work of the Holy Spirit. The people must see themselves and be perceived by others as a "new creation in Christ" rather than as an extension of a present form of the existing church elsewhere. As Nida

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[24] Ibid.

[25] Ibid.

[26] Ibid.

[27] Ibid., 5.

[28] Ibid.

[29] Ibid.

says, "The new converts should, therefore, be recognizable as the first fruit for Christ of the society to which they belong, bringing their specific gifts into the fellowship."[30]

Biblical relativism is not a matter of inconsistency with Christian theology but recognition of the different cultural factors that influence standards and praxes.[31] As an example, while the Koran attempts to fix for all time the behavior of Muslims, the Bible clearly establishes the principle of "relative relativism,"[32] which permits growth, adoption, and freedom under the Lordship of Jesus Christ. The apostle Paul addresses this issue as he writes to the Corinthian Christians.

> Though I am free and belong to no man, I make myself a slave to everyone, to win as many as possible. To the Jews I became like a Jew, to win the Jews. To those under the law I became like one under the law (though I myself am not under the law), so as to win those under the law. To those not having the law I became like one not having the law (though I am not free from God's law but am under Christ's law), so as to win those not having the law. To the weak I became weak, to win the weak. I have become all things to all men so that by all possible means I might save some. I do all this for the sake of the gospel that I may share in its blessings. (1 Cor. 19:19-23 NIV)

The Bible presents realistically the facts of culture and the plan of God by which He continues to work in the hearts of people. The Bible says in Ephesians 4:13, "Till we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ,"[33] which means the ultimate goal of communicating the message of the gospel is clear knowledge and understanding of Christ and the attainment of His fullness within every cultural context.

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[30] Ibid.

[31] Ibid.

[32] Relative to both time and socio-cultural contexts.

[33] B.V. Subbamma, *Christ Confronts India: Indigenous Expression of Christianity in India* (Madras, India: Diocesan, 1973), 25.

The Christian position, therefore, is not one of static conformity to dead rules but of dynamic obedience to a living God.[34]

The question that naturally arises is: If cultures are relative, what, then, is absolute? The only absolute in Christianity, according to Nida, is "the Triune God,"[35] and to that it may be added, God's desire to reveal Himself to people and draw people of every culture, language, and race to Himself to worship Him. The gospel explicitly states, "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life. For God did not send his Son into the world to condemn the world, but to save the world through him" (John 3:16-17 NIV) and "After this I looked and there before me was a great multitude that no one could count, from every nation, tribe, people and language, standing before the throne and in front of the Lamb" (Rev.7:9 NIV). Another way to articulate Jesus' assertive claim to Peter as seen in Matthew 16:18, "I will build my Church," would be that God intends to build His universal church on a local cultural foundation wherever the gospel is preached. Takkaki Haraguchi lists five types of Christian attitudes towards culture: Christ against culture, Christ of culture, Christ above culture, Christ and culture in paradox, and Christ the transformer of culture.[36] In addressing the needs of the *Kurukh* churches, "Christ of culture" and "Christ the transformer of culture" are considered favorable.

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[34] Ibid.

[35] Ibid.,32.

[36] Takaaki Haraguchi, "Reflections on H. Richard Niebuhr's Theoretical Model Concerning the Relationship between Christianity and Culture: Its Applicability to the Japanese Context, *"Asia Journal of Theology*2no. 21 (October 2007): 228.

Biblical Models of Contextualization and Inculturation

This study moves forward with a basic assumption that God does not reveal Himself in a cultural void but incarnates in every culture and transforms it from within. Yahweh, the God of the Old Testament, was revealed to the people within the context of the Hebrew culture. Christ appeared and was incarnated within the Jewish world and its culture. Later the gospel penetrated the world starting within the Greco-Roman realm and its culture. It has continued to spread to other parts embedded in that same principle. The same principle is to be applied as every new culture is approached with the goal of presenting the message of Jesus Christ. In other words, the message of the gospel must be born and become deeply rooted in every culture without an alien form. A brief study of biblical models of God within culture is in order.

Old Testament Models

It was in the Hebrew language and the Hebrew culture that Yahweh, as we read in the Old Testament, revealed Himself to the Hebrew people. Father Mario Saturnine Dias makes a rather unusual observation of a very early case of inculturation, in the proper sense of the term, in the Old Testament, if the commonly accepted story of Exodus is taken at its face value.[37] It assumes an invasion of Israelite tribes coming from Egypt via the Sinai Desert and Transjordan to conquer the land of Canaan in a swift campaign. Since this had happened, Dias concludes that the interaction would have been two-pronged:

> On the one hand, Israel would have rejected the Canaanite culture, killing the people, destroying their cities and making a bonfire of all its artifacts (the sack of Jericho in Jos 6 and the prescriptions recorded in Deut. 13:16-19; 20:16-18). Yet,

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[37] Mario Saturnino Dias, *Rooting Faith in Asia: Source Book for Inculturation* (Quezon City, Philippines: Claretian, 2005), 209.

> paradoxically, this total rejection would have been accompanied by a deep infiltration of Canaanite culture at all the levels of human life. The invaders would have left their tents and encampment to settle in houses and cities, and have given up the short light skirts of Egypt to don the long heavy robes of Canaan, would have given up their traditional Egyptian dishes and taken such Canaanite victuals as olive oil instead of butter, ovine rather than bovine meat, figs and grapes rather than dates, wine rather than beer.[38]

Such a deep identification can hardly be explained in terms of deliberate inculturation, of an effort made by foreign tribes coming from outside to adjust to the way of life and thought of the people of the land. Dias opines, "It seems to be rather a case of common origin, of 'connaturality' at all the levels of culture from the most elementary aspects of daily life to the highest religious expressions. From the outset, Israelites seem to share in the life style of their Canaanite neighbours. Theirs is the social culture of rural East Mediterranean civilizations."[39] Much like their neighbors, they too settled in villages or small cities, cultivating their fields of wheat or barley and growing their olive orchards or their vineyards. They seemed to have shared the same aspiration for a "secure life under one's vine or one's fig tree" (1 Kings 4:25). Closer study reveals that their laws also had much to do with those of other West Asian civilizations. They dealt with the same concerns of rural life—problems of land boundary (Deut. 19:14), of cattle lost (Deut. 2:1) or stolen (Ex. 22:10), grazing in others' land (Ex. 22:4), or injuring passers-by (Ex. 21:28-32).[40]

This common cultural background extended to religious life as well. The Israelites followed the calendar of Canaan with its yearly rhythm of New Year, harvest, and

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[38] Ibid.

[39] Ibid.

[40] Ibid., 209-211.

vintage feasts.[41] The structure of the Jerusalem Temple was similar to that of Canaanite temples excavated.[42] The Temple furniture was the work of Tyrian artisans from the Phoenician city of Tyre (1 Kings 7:13-51).[43] Music, hymns, and instruments owed much, if not almost everything, to Canaan. Psalm 29, with its description of the "Lord of storms," is widely thought to have originated as a hymn to the Canaanite god Baal.[44]

According to scholars, the Hebrew vernacular betrays an almost total cultural Canaanite identity, since it is a "Judahite" dialect of the Canaanite language combined with other variants.[45] Considering that language is the deepest substratum of a culture, it may be deduced that a common language reflects a common worldview as well.[46] These biblical worldviews could have surfaced in the creation narrative in describing the "tree of life" (Gen. 2:9) or the primordial watery and dark abyss (Gen. 1:2), curbed by the Creator (Gen. 1:3-8) but always ready to engulf the earth (Gen. 7). Common language entailed also a sense of God: the name of God in Hebrew (El) is also that of the supreme god of the Canaanite pantheon. By making use of this word, Israel shared in the fundamental religious experience of the Semitic world.[47]

The prophet Daniel and his friends with their Babylonian names Shadrack, Meshak, and Abed Nego were fully immersed in the culture, yet uncompromising in their beliefs (Dan. 1-2). Being accommodating of the culture, they gained access to the

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[41] Ibid.

[42] Ibid.

[43] Ibid.

[44] Ibid.

[45] Ibid.

[46] Ibid.

[47] Ibid., 210.

Babylonian king while at the same time remaining uncompromising. Eventually they led the king himself to acknowledge their God and His power (Dan. 4).

New Testament Models

The same unchanging Yahweh ("I Am That I Am"),[48] through His Son Jesus, as we read in the New Testament, revealed Himself within the Greco-Roman culture and language. Contextualization is further evidenced in the ministry of Jesus. There was no expectation on His part while preaching to the Samaritans and the Gentiles to conform to the practices and lifestyle of the Jews. It is obvious that Jesus' attitude toward the surrounding cultures invited consideration first. Father Dias observes:

> Actually the case of Jesus of Nazareth helps to put our concepts in a proper perspective. Firstly, if we give culture the superficial meaning of high culture, of refinement acquired by training and schooling, the term does not apply to Jesus who did not frequent any institute of higher learning, did not write any book and did not leave any work of art. But culture has the deeper anthropological meaning of mental set-up deriving from geographical, ethnic, linguistic, socio-economic and religious environment. In this sense, any human being belongs to a certain culture and Jesus belonged very much to the Jewish culture of the first century. It can even be said that, to a good extent, he was the product of this culture.[49]

Second, Dias makes a further important observation in the case of Jesus, saying, "There was no 'in-culturation' in the sense that he had to enter a foreign world with a ready-made ideology and adapt to it. It was rather a case of 'incarnation'."[50] Jesus was born a Galilean Jew in a Galilean Jewish culture. This does not make the case of Jesus irrelevant as regards inculturation. Rather, it invites us to see inculturation in a wider and deeper context. Archaeology, new sociological and anthropological models, a better

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[48] Exodus 3:14.

[49] Mario Saturnino Dias, *Rooting Faith in Asia: Source Book for Inculturation* (Quezon City, Philippines: Claretian, 2005), 215.

[50] Ibid.

knowledge of Judaism in the first century, and recent scholarship now shed more light on the cultural milieu in which Jesus of Nazareth lived.[51]

The narrative of Acts chapter 10 describing the meeting of Peter and Cornelius gives much clarity on this topic. God's revelation to Peter and his response in turn was in the context of Hebrew culture. Peter was drawn to bring the gospel to the household of Cornelius as a result of an arresting vision that tempered his heart and changed his attitude toward Gentile culture. Then Peter was made responsible to carry the revelation to Cornelius, a Roman and a member of the Latin culture. Peter had assumed that only the Hebrew culture was a suitable vehicle of God's communication and only a Hebrew response would be acceptable to God. "To Peter, Roman culture and Roman people were alike unacceptable to God."[52] But in a vision, God asked Peter to kill and eat animals that Peter profoundly believed were unclean and thus made him understand that at least one Roman person, Cornelius, was acceptable to God. Peter's decisive statement following the experience is remarkable and noteworthy: "I can now see that God is no respecter of persons, but that in every nation the man who reverences Him and does what is right is acceptable to Him" (Acts 10:34, Phillips' translation). The New International Version reads: "Then Peter began to speak: 'I now realize how true it is that God does not show favoritism but accepts men from every nation who fear him and do what is right.'" B.V. Subbamma says, "The record goes on to indicate that a considerable number of Cornelius' relations and intimate friends responded to the message delivered by Peter and

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[51] Ibid.

[52] B.V. Subbamma, *Christ Confronts India: Indigenous Expression of Christianity in India*. (Madras, India: Diocesan, 1973), 24.

received from God the confirmation that they had been accepted by him, without the necessity of their first becoming Jews."[53]

The fruit of contextualization is then witnessed in the gospel penetrating Gentile culture. Paul's commitment to be "all things to all men" (1 Cor. 9:22 NIV) is a strong indication of contextualization. The most significant indicator is the picture that is portrayed by the apostle John of his vision of "people from every nation, every tribe and every tongue" (Rev. 5:9, 14:6 NIV) who have been redeemed and gathered around the throne of the Lamb. The Apostolic church of the first century was directed by the Holy Spirit to embrace the fact that Gentiles did not have to become Jews or follow Jewish customs and traditions to become Christians. During the past three centuries of Christian missions, however, the transmission of the gospel has involved the transmission of culture along with the message.

Paul and his fellow workers sought to avoid this linkage as much as possible. The narrative reads: "Then some men came down from Judea and began to teach the brothers, saying, 'unless you are circumcised according to the custom of Moses you cannot be saved'" (Acts 15:1 NIV). Paul firmly argued that the Gentiles should not be forced to observe the rite of circumcision or keep the ceremonial law of Moses. Paul circumcised Timothy because his mother was a Jewess and it was part of the Jewish culture to be circumcised (Acts 16:1). But he refused to permit Titus to be circumcised because he was a Greek (Gal.2:3). It is observed that much of present evangelistic efforts continue to be an indiscriminate promotion of an approach to Christianity much more like that of the first century Judaizers than of Paul or Peter, merely substituting foreign culture for

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[53] Ibid.

Hebrew culture as the "sine qua non" for inclusion into the family of God.[54] This promotion may be stated as the cause for rejection and resistance by the *Kurukhar* and others.

Historical Models of Inculturation and Contextualization

India has experienced several noteworthy models of inculturation and contextualization in the past that serve as models even today. One of the earliest models of inculturation in India is drawn from the life and work of Roberto de Nobili (1577-1656), an Italian Jesuit missionary to South India. He adopted a method of accommodating and including many customs of the local culture that from his perspective were not in conflict with the Christian doctrine and faith. He attired himself as a *Sanyasi* (Hindu holy man), shaving his head but leaving a tuft of hair, and wore a three-stringed thread in the line of a high caste *Brahmin*, attributing new Christian import to these aspects of his attire.[55] De Nobili mastered the Sanskrit, Telugu, and Tamil languages and their literature, and he expounded Christian doctrine in these languages, employing many vernacular words and concepts to convey Christian thought.

Another example is what happened in the nineteenth century, when India was experiencing a Hindu cultural renaissance. Leaders among the people became pioneers in initiating dialogue on an Indian interpretation of Christ and an indigenous Christianity. Although many Hindu leaders of that period were attracted to the person of Christ and His teachings that were unquestionably ethical, they found no reason to become a part of

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[54] Ibid.

[55] Vincent Cronin, *A Pearl to India; the Life of Roberto De Nobili* (New York: Dutton, 1959).

the church or accept other Christian doctrines[56] because missions during that period failed to take into account Indian realities such as the fact of plurality, Hindu religo-cultural traditions, and colonial and caste oppression, which later became crucial missiological responses forming Indian Christian theology.[57] Kirsteen Kim explains:

> Leaders like Ram Mohan Roy used Jesus' moral teaching to reform Hinduism but rejected the doctrines of incarnation and atonement. Keshub Chunder Sen, reacting against Roy by taking a mystical approach, described Jesus as the incarnation of the eternal *logos* and made the seminal suggestion that the Christian Trinity could be interpreted within Hinduism in terms of the *Vedantic* definition of *Brahman* (God) as *sat-chit-ananda* (truth-consciousness-bliss), Jesus Christ being the incarnation of chit. Hindu converts to Christianity tried from within to relate their new faith to their Hindu identity and sought to create an indigenous expression of church. Krishna Mohan Banerjee argued that Christianity should be regarded as the fulfillment of Hinduism and coined the term "Hindu-Christian" to express the indigenous Christianity he sought to lead.[58]

Vedantic definitions sought to explain Christ from the understanding of the *Vedas* (Hindu scriptures), from a philosophical platform of the learned. *Sat*[59](the Supreme Truth) was compared to God the father of the Old Testament. *Chit* and *Ananda* were compared to the Son Jesus and the Holy Spirit, respectively.

Later there were others such as Sadhu Sundar Singh, a Sikh convert, who took up the wandering life of a *Sadhu* (holy man) and interpreted the New Testament teaching in everyday language and symbols, offering Indians "the Water of Life in an Indian cup."[60] Bishop A.J. Appasamy, Chenchaiah, Abhishiktananda, Chakkarai, and, more recently, P.

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[56] John Parratt, *An Introduction to Third World Theologies* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 2004), 44-45.

[57] Ibid., 48.

[58] Ibid., 60.

[59] Pronounced as "suth" in Sanskrit.

[60] John Parratt, *An Introduction to Third World Theologies* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 2004), 50.

Devanandam and M.M. Thomas are a few noteworthy Indian theologians who also contributed immensely to the contextualization and inculturation of the Christian faith in India. However, Indian theology emanating from these leaders finds its roots in *Vedantic* interpretations. This study affirms the fact that attempts have been made over the last 200 years at rereading "Christology" and "pneumatology" from an Indian theological perspective. Nevertheless, such interpretations have been limited to philosophical Hinduism of greater traditions.[61] Attempts for constructing theology addressing tribal contexts and little traditions are very recent and remain an area requiring urgent and extensive exploration.

Structuring a Contextual Theology for Transformation of the *Kurukh* People

Although it is possible to find models from the limited array of tribal Christian theologies that have recently emerged, to structure one specifically for the *Kurukh* people, they cannot be replicated. A theology specific to the *Kurukh* context is to be framed based on the *Kurukh* worldview, history, culture, and social criteria if the gospel is to be willingly embraced and to become an integral part of life. Paul Hiebert points out: "The gospel is not simply a message to be affirmed as true, but a call to follow Christ throughout life in radical discipleship."[62] Martin Alphonse posits:

> The task of Christian theology in India is to effect an Indian expression of Christianity and not to work out an Indian Christian expression of Hinduism . . . The task is neither to Christianize Hinduism, nor Hinduize Christianity: it is to render the Christian gospel intelligible to India, making it relevant to our present

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[61] Ibid., 44.

[62] Paul G. Hiebert, *The Gospel in Human Contexts: Anthropological Explorations or Contemporary Missions* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2009), 31.

> needs, emphasizing its particular adequacy to meet our circumstances, speaking God's message to us in the language of India's everyday commerce.[63]

What Is Theology?

The word *theology* is derived from two Greek words, *theos* (God) and *logos* (word). *Thealogia* was a term extensively used by the Greeks for narratives relating to their gods or God. Through ages since that time, the term *theology* has evolved into a more generic meaning that includes expression of concepts related to God and a variety of religious beliefs and praxes. Expressions through liturgy, descriptive systematization, hermeneutical expressions, and the formation of doctrines have all come to be included in theology[64](see Figure 4, below). Examples of these expressions in the modern-day Indian church are God, the Godhead, or the Divinity, which can become both the source and object of theology. In the *Kurukh* context, it can be perceived as the study of God springing out of the people's worldview, leading to the truth; or it can be the interpretation of their life culturally as it relates to the true God. Israel Selvanayagam points out the declaration of Thomas Aquinas, the thirteenth-century scholastic theologian: "Theology is taught by God, teaches of God, and leads to God."

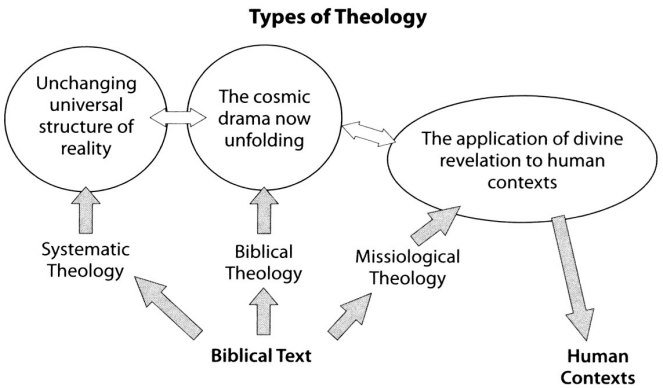


Figure 4 Types of Theology

(Hiebert, *The Gospel in Human Contexts, 38-40*

[63] M. Alphon tional Books, 2001), 21.

[64] Israel Selv *Contexts* (Delhi, India: ISPCK, 2002), 1.

The argument for the existence of God, or, as He is described in India, "the one true God," begins with the above perception. Questions relating to ways one would understand the relationship between God and the world, questions relating to the power of the spoken and written Word, and many more questions would surface from contexts where the gospel is heard for the first time.[65] Many Christian theologians would answer these questions with the simple explanation that these theology matters are to be accepted and understood by faith.[66] During the eleventh century, Anselm of Canterbury (Latin: *Anselmus Cantuariensis*; c. 1033 – 21 April 1109) defined theology as "faith seeking understanding [I believe in order that I may understand]." In the next century, Peter Abelard pronounced that the way to truth is through the path of doubt and questioning.[67] In the Christian theological tradition, the unsettled yet healthy debate between belief and doubt, faith and reason, and accepting answers and raising questions continues to persist. One of the twentieth century's widely renowned theologians, Paul Tillich, boldly claimed, "Existential doubt and faith are poles of the same reality, the state of ultimate concern."[68] However, the "ultimate concern" is Tillich's definition of religion. From Tillich's point of view, it applies to any religion. The distinctive characteristics of Christian theology, therefore, need further definition.

Among early Christian scholars, theology was thought to be a spiritual and intellectual exercise in order to defend the Christian message against critics and heretics.

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[65] Ibid.

[66] Ibid.

[67] Ibid.

[68] Ibid.

The Greeks understood theology as the mother of all philosophies. Therefore, they considered theology to be critical to understanding of one's self. "One understands who one is when one understands who God is."[69] In the Christian era beginning in the fourth century, theology became important to define the church's stance and its communication with the external world.[70] The limitations and the scope of this study prohibit a deeper look at definitions of theology, different kinds of theology, and its purposes. However, in order to specifically discuss theology in relation to the current study of the *Kurukh* church, the following working definition suggested by B.V. Subbamma is considered: "Christian theology is that discipline which arises within the Christian community which seeks in every age to express, preserve, and communicate faith in God as known in Jesus Christ."[71]

Christian theology today is rooted in the written Word and historically established principles of its interpretation. Christian theology expresses the relationship of God to humans and to all of God's creation as revealed in the Bible. Faith precedes theology. Christian theology is, therefore, the thoughtful human attempt to articulate this unique relationship.[72] This study takes the stance that "theology is faith seeking understanding." This standpoint underscores the criticality and significance of human effort in the process. In the words of Gordon Kaufman:

> It is men and women who do theology for human purposes. Theology is done by women and men for human purpose. Theological work is assessed by human

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[69] Ibid.

[70] Ibid., 9.

[71] B.V. Subbamma, *Christ Confronts India: Indigenous Expression of Christianity in India* (Madras, India: Diocesan, 1973), 51.

[72] Ibid.

> standards, and its judges are themselves always ordinary human beings. It is right and proper, therefore, that theologians and other thoughtful Christians be continually engaged in examining and reexamining received ideas of God, criticizing those ideas as sharply as they can in terms of the actual functions they perform in human life, and reconstructing them so that they will serve more adequately as vehicles of our fuller humanization.[73]

Theology is therefore a healthy combination of divine revelation through the written Word, contextual worldviews, and human effort. Kaufman gives more clarity to the understanding of the essential purpose of theology and human effort in these words:

> The task of Christian theology is to assess and criticize received ideas of God in terms of their adequacy in expressing God's absoluteness and God's humaneness, and to reconstruct the image/concept of God so that it will present these motifs as clearly and meaningfully as possible in the contemporary situation, that is, so that God's presence in contemporary life becomes intelligible.[74]

Further, the integral nature of the relationship between theology and missiology is emphasized in this study. In John Corey's words, "Theology is intrinsically missiological since it concerns the God of mission and the mission of God. This means that all theological categories are inherently missiological and all missionary categories are profoundly theological."[75]

The Need

A general notion has existed that a certain class of people oriented to philosophical thinking alone can develop theology; particularly when it comes to tribal traditions, it has been thought that the tribal people themselves are not philosophical and

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[73] Israel Selvanayagam, *Moving Forms of Theology: Faith Talk's Changing Contexts* (Delhi, India: ISPCK, 2002), 11.

[74] Ibid., 18.

[75] John Corrie, *Dictionary of Mission Theology: Evangelical Foundations,* ed. R. Paredes (Nottingham, England: InterVarsity, 2007), xv.

rational enough to attempt such a task.[76] This paradigm changed with the emergence of liberation theology in the 1900s, bringing forth the idea that "doing theology" is more than mere rational exercise. Liberation theology was birthed from the social turbulence of the 1960s in Latin America, and it promoted a fresh understanding of the message and mission of the church from within a Latin American context. Following the popularity of liberation theology, several other theologies surfaced, such as the Minjung theology of Korea, the Black theology of Africa, and the *Dalit* theology of India (see Figure 5). All of these theologies seriously took into account the oppression and struggles of the people and their socio-economic and political contexts, underscoring the reality, as C.S. Kerketta submits, that "the primary datum of doing theology is humanity and their liberation."[77]

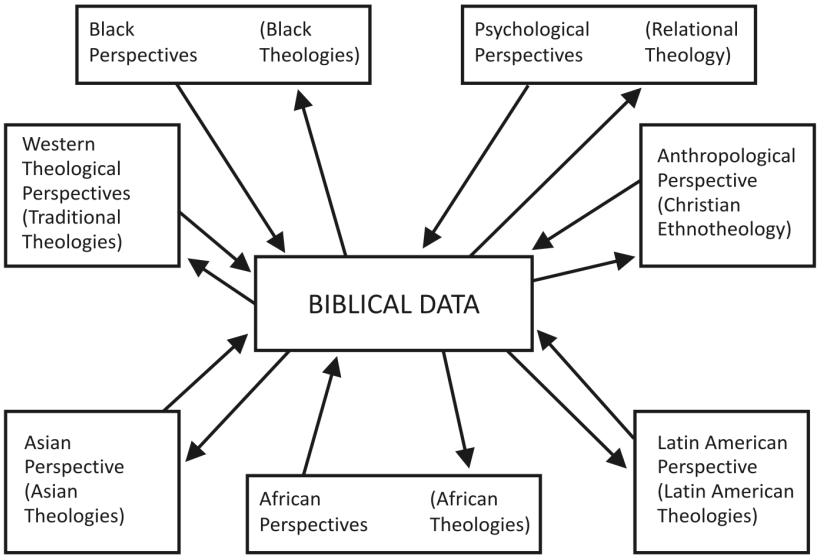


Figure 5. Contextualization of Theology

(Charles Kraft, *Christianity in Culture: A Study in Biblical Theologizing in Cross-Cultural Perspective)*

[76] C.S. Kerketta, *Adivasi Theology* (Ranchi, India: Dept. of Adivasi Theology & Cultural Research, 2009), 74.

[77] Ibid.

If theology is to communicate the Gospel intelligibly to the *Kurukh* people, then it needs to be contextualized. In the words of Alphonse: "No one theology may be equally good or relevant for all contexts and cultures. Consequently, a contextualized theology may not be able to transform a situation completely. Yet, it can certainly alter the situation to a great extent."[78] The need arises now to reconstruct or to structure a theology that is apropos to the *Adivasi* context and particularly to the *Kurukh* people. They are a unique people, with a unique history, and living in a unique context. Therefore, a theology structured for this context does not have to synchronize with other contexts, although those contexts may be similar. Theology constructed for the *Kurukh* needs to take into consideration their inseparable identity with their land; the level of marginalization and exploitation they have experienced; and their poverty, culture, and religion, all seen holistically.[79]

The purpose of structuring a theology for the *Adivasi* and specifically this people group is to empower the *Kurukh* people with a robust theological foundation that will lead to transformation within their own context. The starting point of transformation is where people are in their present condition and at their point of need, taking into account both individuals and communities.[80] The process of transformation then moves on, involving people in the evaluation of their own cultures from new experiences gained and from the perspective of new truths learned, helping them to delve deeper into issues

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[78] M. Alphonse, *The Gospel For The Hindus* (Chennai, India: Mission Educational Books, 2001), 22.

[79] Ibid.

[80] Paul G. Hiebert, *The Gospel in Human Contexts: Anthropological Explorations or Contemporary Missions* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2009), 31-32.

affecting their lives and their future. Therefore, a theology that aims to bring about transformation has its focus on mission that takes humans seriously in the context of their cultures, daily life, practices, and history. Hiebert explains that such an exercise

> integrates cognition, affectivity, and evaluation and its response to biblical truth and defines faith not simply as mental affirmations of truth, or a positive experience of God, but as beliefs, feelings, and morals that lead to obedience to the word of God. It rejects the division between pure and applied theology, and sees ministry both as a way of doing theology and as a form of worship.[81]

The Sources

If a theology that is relevant to the *Kurukh* people is to be considered, then the source of such theology, along with Scripture, will have to be derived from and contain elements from their own context (see Figure 6). A lengthy list of sources could be created for structuring or doing theology in this context; however, considering the limitations of this study and the reality that the *Kurukhar* are a people of oral tradition, the select sources that follow are listed and considered: history, culture and community, land and forest, religion and religiosity, song and dance, and scripture and stories.

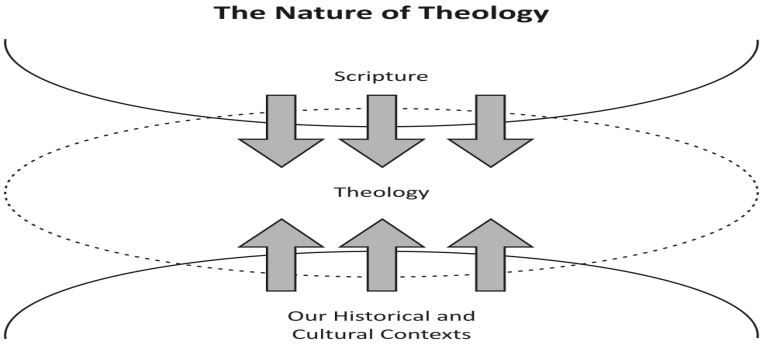


Figure 6. The Nature of Theology

(Paul G. Hiebert, *The Gospel in Human Contexts: Anthropological Explorations for Contemporary Missions)*

[81] Ibid., 32.

History. According to K.P. Aleaz, "Tribal theology in India is in the making."[82] The starting point of a *Kurukh* theology would be the history of the people. The *Kurukhar* do not consider history as just events from the past; instead, they live in a sense of historical consciousness that is revealed in their belief that the spirits of their ancestors still dwell with them and that these spirits need to be cared for. For example, the *Kurukh* home has a corner set apart for good ancestral spirits to dwell. The *sahural* festival described in the previous chapter is observed partly to pacify other spirits that find their dwelling in the forests. A historical Jesus, present among and within through the Holy Spirit, therefore, finds immediate acceptance and deep theological relevance.[83]

Kurukh Culture and Community. The *Kurukh* culture is deeply rooted in values related to fellow humans, their spirituality, and their environment. In the midst of their physical and material needs, struggles, oppression, marginalization, and poverty, such a culture along with its practices and bonds of community brings a sense of liberation—temporary as it may be—awakening within them their identity. The biblical concepts of the church as *koinonia* (fellowship of believers) and *oikos* (the household of God) have a strong theological appeal to such a cultural perspective and understanding.

Land and Forest. The *Kurukhar* are people of the land and live close to nature. The land on which they live and toil, including the forests that surround them and their produce, shape their lives. Any violation or exploitation of the land and forest is perceived as a violation and exploitation of their identity and existence. To live in

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[82] K.P. Aleaz, "A Tribal Christian Theology from India," *Asia Journal of Theology* 2, no. 19 (October 2005): 379.

[83] Sebastian Kappen, *Jesus and Culture* (New Delhi, India: ISPCK, 2002), xiii.

harmony with nature, the environment and their surroundings are not seen as means of survival alone but as fundamental requirements of their wholeness and well-being. Life for a *Kurukh* is lived in harmony with the land and the forest as well as with fellow humans. God the Father, the Supreme Being and Creator, and the interconnectedness of all of creation and humans created as caretakers, are theological concepts that resonate well. The practice of offering the first fruits of their harvest to the deity called *Sarna* and the invocation of the supreme god Dharmes during hunting and harvesting and even the ceremonial partaking of rice beer can be carefully chosen as sources for constructing a theology. Further, *Jamin* (land) and *jungle* (forest) are repeatedly mentioned in the Bible.[84] The creation story begins with a jungle called the "Garden of Eden" and there is a tree of life. The Kurukh people can easily identify with this analogical comparison. Hrangthan Chhungi observes: "The tribals in India have been resisting encroachments on their jungle and jamin."[85] Being deprived of their land is comparable to being cast out of Eden.

The Kurukh Religion and Religiosity. Unlike religions of greater traditions (described earlier in this study) that could be confined to written Scriptures, the *Kurukh* religion is an experience of everyday life. Kerketta, the *Adivasi* theologian, explains: "One could find their religion in terms of their religiosity which is found in their festivals, in their walk and talk, even in their silence. For *Adivasis*, religion is not a matter of abstract dogmas and intellectual belief but it is something that touches the very core of

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[84] G. B. Sural and Hrangthan Chhungi, *Towards a Tribal Theology* (Durgapur, India: Tribal Peace and Reconciliation Centre, 2014), 129.

[85] Ibid., 130.

their existence."[86] The secular-sacred dichotomy is seen less in *Kurukh* culture and religion than in many others. The divine is everywhere and in everything and is experienced constantly. This insight, considered carefully and with caution, provides a positive source for constructing theology.

Song and Dance. The *Kurukh* people are a people of folklore; they preserve a deep spirituality, like many other *Adivasis* of India, through their songs and dances. Songs and dances, the *akhra* (common dancing ground in every village), the *Dhumkuria* (community hall), and the formation of the *bastis* (hamlets) play a significant role in their culture. Their songs tell their story, and their history is passed down generationally. Expression of all emotions—joys, sorrow, disappointment, hopes, and aspirations—is shared in song.[87] Every season and occasion has unique songs and dances, and the dancing ground is a place for the community to gather, join hands, sing, and dance to the rhythm of drums. It is a place where, at the end of the day, animosity and anger between one another for any reason is forgiven openly and then forgotten. In these practices, one finds a rich treasure trove of resources for theology. Thanzauva affirms, "In the absence of written materials, myths, folklores, sermons, and songs become the primary resources for constructing tribal theology."[88]

Scripture and Stories. The Bible, in the absence of any written collection of stories describing the how and the why of the *Kurukh* lifestyle (a "scripture"), can easily become the unrivalled source of theology for the *Kurukh*. It must be kept in mind,

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[86] C.S. Kerketta, *Adivasi Theology* (Ranchi, India: Dept. of Adivasi Theology & Cultural Research, 2009), 90.

[87] K. Thanzauva, *Theology of Community: Tribal Theology in the Making* (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2004), 261.

[88] Ibid.

however, that as in the case of all theology, *Kurukh* theology will also be shaped by *Kurukh* culture and society. In this regard, it is helpful to take Hiebert's clue that

> we must [also]remember that there are great gulfs between biblical times and our times, between universal theories and the particulars of everyday life, and between synchronic theologies that examine unchanging structure of reality and diachronic theologies that study cosmic history. It is important in any theological reflection to work toward bridging these differences.[89]

Cultural life is extremely important for the *Kurukh*, and it needs to be interpreted in light of and with the help of the Bible. In the words of Carlos Mesters, "The people's main interest is not to interpret the Bible, but to interpret life with the help of the Bible."[90]

Stories play an important role in *Kurukh* life. This is not to be taken lightly since human beings are preeminently story tellers.[91] People live in the midst of their stories and the stories of others. They see everything taking place around them through the eyes of these stories and attempt to live life as if they are recounting these stories.[92] During the summer when work on the land is limited, communities sit together and narrate stories from the past. Repeated narration of these stories serves as a reminder of their heritage, along with being the medium of communicating and instilling spirituality, ethics, rules, and taboos within the community. Stories include creation, deluge, salvation from invaders, and others. The Bible, as a book of stories quite similar to these, becomes a natural fit. Both can easily run parallel in the construction of *Kurukh* theology.

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[89] Paul G. Hiebert, *The Gospel in Human Contexts: Anthropological Explorations for Contemporary Missions* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2009), 38.

[90] Carlos Mesters, *Defenseless Flower: A New Reading of the Bible* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1989), 9.

[91] A. Wati Longchar and Larry E. Davis, *Doing Theology with Tribal Resources: Context and Perspective* (Assam, India: Tribal Study Centre, Eastern Theological College, 1999), 91.

[92] Ibid.

Challenges

As the attempt is made to construct a theology relevant to the *Kurukh* context, certain challenges must be confronted. Two seminal questions emerge: the first question relates to integrity and the second to accountability. How can a theology developed for a particular people living in a particular context, resourced from local history and culture, maintain integrity of faith and belief and remain credible in the eyes of the larger community of believers? How can such a theology remain answerable and accountable to the church at large? After all, no matter where Christians live, they are a part of the family of God (*oikos*) and are accountable to one another.

The difference between revelation and theology needs tobe pointed out and recognized at this juncture. Whereas revelation is God-given truth, theology is the human understanding and articulation of that truth, which is shaped and formed within various contexts; it cannot be equated with the truth. The limitations of theology must be accepted, since human understanding of revelation is "always partial and perspective."[93] Therefore, a hermeneutic reflecting the collective thought of the community at a micro and macro level based on ongoing dialogue would serve to correct any individual bias. Hiebert provides a solution to this dilemma: "On the global scale, this calls for both local and global theologies. Local churches have the right to interpret and apply the gospel in their contexts, but also a responsibility to join the larger church community around the world in seeking to overcome the limited perspectives each brings, and the biases each has that might distort the gospel."[94]

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[93] Paul G. Hiebert, *The Gospel in Human Contexts: Anthropological Explorations for Contemporary Missions* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2009), 29.

[94] Ibid.

Towards a Healthy and Sustainable *Kurukh* Church

The emergence of a truly indigenous and authentic *Kurukh* church will be witnessed when there is a healthy merger of the *Kurukh* worldview, the *Kurukh* culture, the gospel, and a biblical vision of the kingdom of God. In moving forward with such a goal, it is critical that the assumptions of *Kurukh* as well as Christian traditions that have either helped or hindered the above process be critically examined and evaluated.

Christian education, leading toward discipleship and leadership development, is the most urgent need among the *Kurukh* Christians, and it requires immediate attention.[95] Considering their culture and worldview, doctrines pertaining to Christology, the Eucharist, eschatology, and pneumatology will be of particular relevance and interest to the *Kurukh* people. These doctrines need to be re-examined and articulated in the light of the present context; given the literacy levels and learning practices of the *Kurukh*, they may be communicated through the method of storytelling and songs that will capture the hearts of these people and become embedded in them.

The critical missing piece in instilling spiritual health and vitality into the third wave *Oraon* churches of Jharkhand seems to be effective communication of the gospel message using relevant communication methodologies in storytelling and song. Kraft provides a few valuable principles to consider (see Figure 7) while communicating within indigenous cultural contexts:

1. "Receptor-oriented communication" is essential, with a clear understanding that the primary purpose of communication is "to bring a receptor to understand a

[95] Conclusion from field research, written in Module Three essay.

message presented by a communicator in a way that substantially corresponds with the intent of the communicator."[96]

2. The ultimate formulation of what is understood must occur within the receptor's head, not within the communicator's.

   Meanings are shaped by hearers; a concept is communicated more effectively and gets closer to the message when the communicator uses relevant cultural forms and symbols.

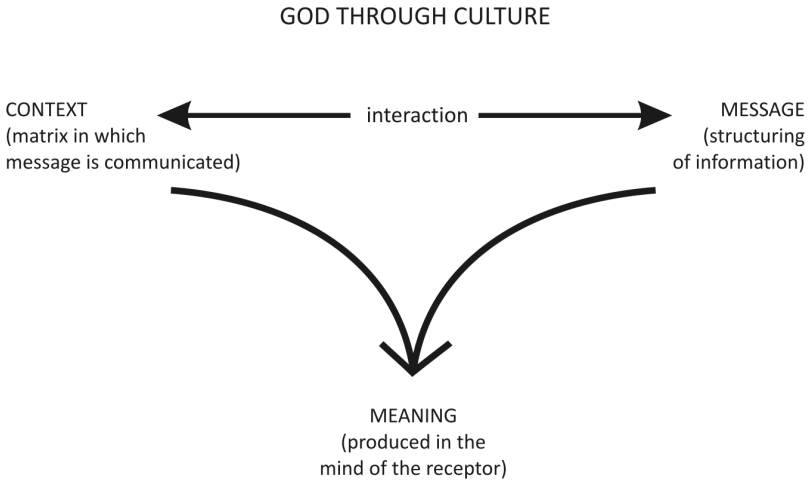


Figure 7. God Through Culture

(Charles Kraft, *Christianity in Culture: A Study in Biblical Theologizing in Cross-Cultural Perspective*, 106)

[96]Charles Kraft, *Christianity in Culture: A Study in Biblical Theologizing in Cross-Cultural Perspective* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2005), 115.

The following statement of Kraft sums up much of what has been mentioned thus far regarding contextualization and inculturation. If this simple yet profound reality receives the attention it demands, it is bound to bring rich dividends for God's kingdom in regions where God's third wave of receptivity and growth is experienced: "Meanings are not transmitted, only messages, for 'meanings are not in the message, they are in the message-users.'"[97] Stanislas Savarimuthu is worth mentioning here. He says: "Reader-centered approaches, reflecting the context of the reader, are becoming more and more popular in biblical studies."[98]

Summary

Chapter one defined key terms that are central to the study, and it also provided an overview of Christward movements around the world. The following chapter pointed out the significance of the third-wave growth of the indigenous churches and its distinction from the first two waves experienced in the history of missions. The third chapter brought the study closer to the central topic of the thesis, dealing with *Kurukh* people in Jharkhand and the third wave of growing churches among them. Contextualization and inculturation may be more recent terminology, but they have been an integral part of God's redemptive mission always, both in concept and principle. This truth was substantiated through this chapter with biblical and historical illustrations and further emphasizing the need for present application. The call for the *Kurukh* church to become

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[97] Ibid., 116.

[98] Stanislas Savarimuthu, *A Community in Search of Its Identity: Mt. 21:28-22:14 in a Subaltern Perspective* (Delhi, India: ISPCK, 2007), xix.

more aware of its culture and context in the development of its theology has been highlighted in this section of the study.

The final chapter will examine training of individuals in the *Kurukh* church in theology and leadership development within the framework of all that has been studied and suggested up to this point. Both training in theology and leadership development are considered as the two most significant contributors to the spiritual health and vitality of the indigenous *Kurukh* church of the future. The following chapter proposes a new pattern of leadership development and theological training, different from existing patterns and more appropriate for the *Kurukh* context. The concluding chapter also seeks to establish the need for specially trained *Kurukh* leaders. Their qualities will include a deep understanding and awareness of the third wave. The *Kurukh* leaders need to be equipped simultaneously with adequate theological instruction and appropriate communication methodologies to ensure effective discipleship of believers through Christian religious education. This training will be critical to building health and vitality within the *Kurukh* churches while retaining their autochthonous nature.

CHAPTER FIVE

This final chapter covers two primary areas of concern that are believed to be critical in addressing the present challenges faced by the indigenous *Kurukh* churches in Jharkhand as described in the earlier sections of this study:

a. The development of leaders

b. The discipleship of believers through Christian religious education (CRE)

The purpose of this study was to research the current Christward movement among the *Kurukhar* of Jharkhand with a goal of developing a contextual methodology to identify and train *Kurukh* Christian leaders who will lead spiritually mature and sustainable, autochthonous churches. A substantial growth in the number of churches among this people group has been observed, and the lack of spiritual nurturing of believers, resulting in stagnancy, syncretism, and unhealthy traditional practices, has been identified as the existing problem to be addressed.

The examination of the problem in the preceding chapters established several findings. These findings are briefly reviewed here. First, it was established that the Christward movement experienced at present among the subaltern people of little traditions in India is part of a global phenomenon. This phenomenon was illustrated through an overview of movements in Africa, Latin America, and other countries of Asia in a brief comparison with that of India. Second, this study has found that the present Christward movement in India is distinct from other conversion movements to Christianity or historical people movements that have resulted through foreign missions efforts in the past. This Christward movement is identified as a unique third wave. Third,

the study identified the churches of the third wave as not indigenized but indigenous and further described as “autochthonous” (birthed from the soil).

Taking a closer look at the specific people group being examined, the *Kurukhar*, has pointed out that they may be classified as subaltern and people of little tradition. As seen among *Dalits* and other tribals of India, a significant Christward movement is witnessed among the *Kurukhar Adivasis* in Jharkhand. A further observation has been made that the religion practiced by the *Kurukh* differs from those of neighboring tribal groups; therefore, a unique approach is required in any attempt to disciple them, introduce Christian religious education, structure a relevant theology, and develop Christian leaders among them.

The need currently exists for intensive discipleship through Christian religious education of believers using contextual models and methods. It is believed that doing so will net the following:

1. Maintain integrity of the Christian faith
2. Prevent syncretism within the Christian communities
3. Sustain the current Christward movement
4. Raise vibrant, autochthonous *Kurukh* churches

This study concludes that the need for health and vitality of the *Kurukh* churches in Jharkhand may be met through the raising of *Kurukh* leaders specifically trained and equipped for this context. Moving forward, the thesis identifies the general nature of discipleship that will be effected through Christian religious education structured to the *Kurukh* context and the development of *Kurukh* leaders perceptive and adept in disseminating such knowledge until it becomes a lifestyle practice of the community of

Christians. The terms *leadership development* and *Christian religious education* are used from the vantage point of the *Kurukh* culture and not in their traditional forms involving institutions, modular structures, and programs. In this context, they are perceived as part of an ongoing process that results in the change of attitude and patterns of behavior with positive outcomes in the praxes of *Kurukh* daily life.

The remainder of this chapter will highlight the fact that implications of the aforementioned elements for the *Kurukh* church are different from those of other people groups. The development of indigenous leaders rather than the implementation of traditionally understood "leadership development" and "Christian religious education" in the context of robust discipleship, replacing traditional "theological education," is prescribed. This approach is further addressed in this chapter. This concluding chapter also briefly highlights the unique role of women in the *Kurukh* churches as leaders and key players in discipleship and in bringing spiritual vitality into the churches.

The study recommends the consideration of "self-renewing and self-regenerating" as two additional components that are fundamentally essential to the indigeneity of movements and churches. True indigeneity requires the capacity to transform and bring about needed changes from within. The same may be said of renewal. The process, methodology, modalities, and outcomes of self-renewal and self-regeneration relating to different aspects of individual and community life are intricate, complex, and elaborate. Self-renewal and self-regeneration may be considered as subjects of future research as they relate to the study of indigeneity in their own capacities. They are not examined here. Nevertheless, the point is made that unless a church has developed within itself the innate capability for self-renewal and self-regeneration, it may not be considered totally

autochthonous, since it will depend on external sources for health, vitality, and survival. The words of the apostle Paul as he addresses the churches in Rome and Corinth, saying, "I myself am convinced, my brothers, that you yourselves are full of goodness, complete in knowledge and competent to instruct one another" (Rom. 15:14 NIV) and further, "but just as you excel in everything, in faith, in speech, in knowledge, in complete earnestness and in your love for us, see that you also excel in this grace of giving" (2 Cor. 8:7 NIV) seem to substantiate this position. The development of *Kurukh* leaders with a keen understanding of the above approach of intensive discipleship through Christian religious education becomes inevitable.

Structuring a *Kurukh* theology, leadership development, and theological education is a complex undertaking that requires further, in-depth research. This study establishes that they warrant due attention of the academic and theological community. Such research and study is not only recommended for the *Kurukhar* and similar people groups but also for the *Adivasi* population in general. These elements are beyond the scope of this research and are not explored further. The immediate need to do so, however, is affirmed.

Discipleship and Christian Religious Education

Discipleship finds its starting point in the Great Commission of Jesus, claiming authority[1] over everything and sending out disciples to make more disciples. Numerous theories and thousands of definitions address Jesus' meaning for the words *disciple* and

[1] "Then Jesus came to them and said, 'All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age'" (Matt. 28:18-20 NIV).

discipleship. They cover a wide spectrum of beliefs, understanding, and expectations of the subject. It is not within the scope of this study to dissect these theories and definitions, or to identify one that is best and right. The intent here is to substantiate the need for discipleship within the *Kurukh* churches and submit to readers the concepts of discipleship within the context of the *Kurukh* people. Discipleship defined in terms of a marked commitment followed by teaching, as seen in the Great Commission, is perceived to be a need among the *Kurukhar*. This need demands immediate attention. It is expected that such discipleship will be an outcome of effective Christian religious education.

To suggest a means to achieve discipleship through contextual methods is a reasonable goal for this study, considering its scope. In this context, discipleship is to be understood as spiritual formation of new believers, consistent growth in Christian disciplines, and knowledge and understanding of Scripture. Furthermore, it includes progress in skills to apply biblical teachings and principles in daily life in a manner that influences and impacts others, drawing them to Christ. Growing in knowledge and understanding of the truths and principles of the Bible, therefore, becomes crucial to discipleship.

Christian religious education is prescribed as a means to effective discipleship of *Kurukh* Christians. The roles of tradition, culture, and ways in which religious experiences have been passed on from one generation to another all demand due attention in the process. Discipleship through Christian religious education then becomes more effective and meaningful within the context. The general process of education is impacted by psychological as well as sociological factors. John Dewey calls it “the

funded capital of civilization."[2] Recognition and preservation of this "funded capital" and efficiently utilizing it are part of the tasks of Christian religious education.[3]

At present, as generally observed in India, the teaching ministry of the church's Christian education is limited to the imparting of Bible stories and Christian tradition.[4] Quite often, Christian education is understood as imparting a set of biblical content, stories, and creeds. It is used as a process of conditioning the mind, body, and spirit of learners according to the traditional norms and beliefs of the church. The Christian religious education being prescribed for the *Kurukh* churches through this study, however, is expected to involve much more than mere imparting of biblical knowledge. It includes developing the ability of believers to interpret principles and apply them contextually. This task is further explained hereunder.

The terms *Christian education* and *religious education* are often used interchangeably. There seems to be a greater preference for the term *Christian education* over *religious education*.[5] Christian education mostly points toward education restricted to the church and conveys the perception that it is restricted to the faith community. This view limits Bible teaching to the confines of the teaching of Christianity. On the other hand, use of the term *religious education* opens the doors to a broad spectrum of teaching of theology, philosophy, psychology, sociology, history, and a host of other fields of

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[2] W.S. Milton Jeganathan, *Mission Paradigm in the New Millennium* (Delhi, India: Published for the Dept. of Mission and Evangelism of Church of South India by ISPCK, 2000), 271.

[3] Ibid., 272.

[4] Ibid., 274.

[5] Akheto Sema, *Understanding the Nature and Purpose of Christian Religious Education*, Rev. ed. (Delhi, India: ISPCK, 2005), 3.

study.[6] Since the emphasis for the *Kurukhar* is on transformation of people rather than impartation of knowledge, this study proposes to broaden the scope of Christian education to include Christian religious education in the *Kurukh* context. The vision of Christian religious education cannot be confined to ministerial training programs of the churches alone but involves equipping the whole people of God for a life of witness and transformation of their communities.[7]

Discipleship through Christian religious education is a process in which the learner is facilitated to look at his or her faith in relation to Scripture, the practices of the church, and the cultural context, and to live that faith out practically in daily situations. In the *Kurukh* context, Christian religious education is to be understood as a process of teaching and learning about the whole of life from a Christian standpoint, starting from the very early stage of a person's faith in Jesus Christ as His disciple. It is to be perceived as a lifelong process of learning about God, self, family, the church, society, the world, and all things connected to a person's life. Such Christian religious education appropriate and meaningful to the *Kurukh* context is yet to be designed. Songs, storytelling, dance, and drama using stories and Bible narratives that parallel *Kurukh* mythologies are suggested as effective mediums of communication, along with the use of other *Kurukh* art forms and symbols. It is expected that such effective communication of the message will lead to a fuller understanding of biblical narratives, truths, and doctrines, further enabling the *Kurukh* people to practice Christian principles and values in their daily lives. The emergence of strong and healthy *Kurukh* churches, vibrant in faith and skilled in the

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[6] Ibid.

[7] A. Wati Longchar, *Returning to Mother Earth: Theology, Christian Witness and Theological Education: An Indigenous Perspective* (Tainan, India: PTCA/SCEPTRE, 2012), 180.

hearing, understanding, and interpretation of the Word, contextual in witness, equipped to multiply, and fully sustained and empowered to transform, will then be witnessed.

The challenge, then, is first to identify *Kurukh* Christians with leadership abilities and then to enlighten them to understand the present ethos in which the churches are rapidly growing among their people. Next comes the task of creating an awareness of the immediate need for spiritual health that the churches face. Following such awareness, acquisition of appropriate skills to become proficient in implementing discipleship through Christian religious education to the next lower level of believers becomes essential. This study, therefore, briefly takes a closer look at how leadership is understood within the *Kurukh* culture and seeks to redefine traditional forms of leadership to suit this specific context.

Understanding and Redefining Leadership in the *Kurukh* Cultural Context

Understanding the *Kurukh* culture, customs, and organization of community all precede the emergence of the term *leadership*. In her discussion of leadership as a physical and social process, Dr. MaryKate Morse points out,

> The terms *leader* and *leadership* are relatively new to the English language, coming into use only in the last few hundred years. Prior to that, role titles such as priest, king and captain conferred authority and power. Leadership came out of one's role in a social system. A person who had a position of authority was the leader—it was as simple as that. So using the term *leader* was unnecessary, and further thought about the concept of leadership was irrelevant.[8]

This notion still holds true in the traditional *Kurukh* culture; however, among the *Kurukh* people in the urban areas, Western forms of hierarchical leadership have been introduced and prevail within institutions, both Christian and secular.

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[8] MaryKate Morse, *Making Room for Leadership: Power, Space and Influence* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP, 2008), 23.

Leadership in the *Kurukh* social context needs to be considered from another perspective as well. The common human tendency in leadership thinking is to attribute outcomes of systems to individual leaders.[9] While this tendency may be true within organizations, it does not necessarily apply to social systems.[10] In order to develop models of leadership that are robust within social systems, one needs to move beyond such a mental framework. Also, there exists another common fallacy in leadership thought, one which claims that cause-effect models, producing positive results within organizations, can also be applied to social systems to achieve expected results.[11] Rakesh Khurana, talking about the process of analyzing leadership in various contexts, firmly asserts that such "cause-effect thinking is not merely inappropriate for the analysis of social system leadership but that it actually impedes progress in our field."[12] Alternatively, he suggests that in analyzing social systems, the focus should be on putting structural conditions in place to increase efficiency rather than trying to "identify the direct causes of what transpires in social systems."[13] In other words, in the analysis of an organization, one would question the causes for lack of progress and who will rectify it. In social systems, the question would be how structural conditions can be changed to attain results.

In fact, there seems to be no word in *Kurukh* that translates the term *leader* as understood through current definitions. As stated in chapter three, terms describing what

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[9] Nitin Nohria and Rakesh Khurana, eds., *Handbook of Leadership Theory and Practice: An HBS Centennial Colloquium on Advancing Leadership* (Boston, MA: Harvard Business Press, 2010),113.

[10] Ibid.

[11] Ibid.

[12] Ibid.

[13] Ibid.

may be classified for our convenience as leadership positions are understood differently by the *Kurukhar*. For example, *Mahto,* the secular head of the village (headman), cannot be described as the *village leader*. The closer description in present-day terms would somewhat resemble the term *chairman of a board*. The *Mahto* would, however, be considered the most influential person in the village. The *Pahan* (priest), *Kotwar* (guards), and *Serpanch* (members of the village council) are positions of responsibility and influence but not necessarily of leadership as it may be presently perceived. It is also important to note that *Kurukh* society does not perceive these positions as hierarchical.

Current Western definitions of leadership perceive the leader as one who leads followers towards a future destiny. In contrast, the *Kurukh* perception of the future is vague; even the dead are believed to be present with the family in the form of unseen spirits. Also, positions of responsibility are intended to protect and maintain the status quo rather than to change or alter. Dr. Manmasih Ekka, quoting Ajit Pandey, points out that in the *Kurukh* context, "Traditionalism is conceived as a continuity whereas 'modernity' implies break. Traditionalism conforms to timeless norms, those affirmed or justified by myth or dominant mythology and those handed down by tradition."[14]

In this context, a study of the process of conversion to Christianity among the *Kurukhar* comes with some startling findings. One study by an anthropologist concludes that Christianity has been a factor of conflict and tension among the *Oraons* in particular,

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[14] Manmasih Ekka, "Asur Myth of Oraons: A Resource for Human Liberative Spirituality" (PhD diss., Gospel & Plough School of Theology, Allahabad, U.P., India.) In Shodhganga: a reservoir of Indian theses at INFLIBNET, accessed April 21, 2015, http://hdl.handle.net/10603/38807.

and in tribal society in general.[15] Manmasih Ekka underscores the distressing reality of the past in saying,

> On one hand, the sphere of religious activities has widened from the limit of a village to the parish, diocese and also from intertribal to intra-tribal context; on the other, the Oraons (like other tribals) have been divided into denominations and through conversion a separation has come between converted Oraons and those remaining in the traditional form of Oraon religion. The rivalry between denominations with regard to their working area and their different ideologies has further weakened the existing social solidarity among the Oraons.[16]

As the gospel takes roots among the *Kurukhar*, conflicts are undoubtedly bound to arise. The concern at this stage is to be aware of causes triggering conflicts, ensuring that they are contained and kept minimal. Past experiences necessitate a review of administrative structures within the church. In so doing, concepts and definitions of leadership will have to be altered to fit within the *Kurukh* context. It then becomes essential to understand the nature, form, and function of these new concepts and definitions of leadership and how they will be perceived by the people. The ensuing section addresses these questions.

A Suggested Working Definition of Leadership in the *Kurukh* Context

Dr. Morse's easy yet comprehensive statement on leadership is taken here as a working definition for this thesis. She states, "Leadership is a mysterious and complex relational process between a leader (or leaders) and a group so that everyone pursues a redemptive present and a transformational future."[17] This definition provides a platform

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[15] Ibid.

[16] Ibid.

[17] MaryKate Morse, *Making Room for Leadership: Power, Space and Influence* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP, 2008), 24.

from which projections can be made to address how leadership positions and roles are perceived among the *Kurukhar.*

Within the *Kurukh* context, it is envisioned that effective discipleship of new believers will be realized through Christian individuals equipped to provide Christian religious education. When positions and roles of these individuals within the church are perceived as those generally accepted in the community, they will transfer naturally and be effective among believers as well. However, they must not be seen as competing for the position of the *Mahato, Pahan,* or *Kotwar* outside of the church but as substitutes for such roles within the church. Re-reading the following text from Ephesians 4:11-16 (NIV) within the *Kurukh* socio-cultural context throws light on what is currently required and gives good direction for the future:

> It was he who gave some to be apostles, some to be prophets, some to be evangelists, and some to be pastors and teachers, to prepare God's people for works of service, so that the body of Christ may be built up until we all reach unity in the faith and in the knowledge of the Son of God and become mature, attaining to the whole measure of the fullness of Christ. Then we will no longer be infants, tossed back and forth by the waves, and blown here and there by every wind of teaching and by the cunning and craftiness of men in their deceitful scheming. Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will in all things grow up into him who is the Head, that is, Christ. From him the whole body, joined and held together by every supporting ligament, grows and builds itself up in love, as each part does its work.

Various theological and doctrinal views are held and a variety of definitions have been provided over time for these leadership roles. They are beyond the scope of this study. As the gospel penetrates new cultures as it did during the first century, however, many similarities are observed in the patterns of the present "third wave" growth of the church to what it was then. The positions of responsibility assigned within the early Christian church (as seen in Ephesians chapter 4) are taken here as a model; they

compare well with those of the guiding and influencing positions within the *Kurukh* culture. This approach to identifying leadership is done with an overarching purpose of infusing health into the *Kurukh* churches, which is the objective of this study.

The Greek words describing the above-mentioned positions, now defined as leadership roles within the church, bear close resemblance to *Kurukh* socio-cultural interpretations. For example, the Greek word *poimenas,* translated into English as "pastor," sheds some light. A.T. Robinson defines and describes this term as follows: "This word ποιμην [*poimēn*] is from a root meaning to 'protect.'"[18] This definition of a pastor is comparable to the role of a *Kotwar* (guardian or protector) in *Kurukh*. In a similar way, the word *apostle* would compare to *Mahato* as "the one appointed" by the king as supreme caretaker of the village. *Pahan* (priest) also has a close resemblance to the role of the (Greek) *prophetas* (prophets) who, according to Marvin Vincent, are "preachers and expounders under the immediate influence of the Spirit, and thus distinguished from *teachers* (1 Cor. 12:10)."[19] In the *Kurukh* context, the *Pahan* recites the myths related to Dharmes during the performance of rituals at various festivals and functions. Other legendary stories are passed down by members of the older generation during storytelling times. The youth and women also share them through dances and songs. The *Sarpanch,* a member of the village council, compares to the evangelist since he is the official messenger who brings the good news of decisions made in the meetings of the elders, who would compare with the "teachers" mentioned in Ephesians chapter 4.

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[18] Marvin Richardson Vincent, *Word Studies in the New Testament* (Bellingham, WA: Logos Research Systems, Inc., 2002), S.3:389.

[19] Ibid.

The above explanation is not to suggest that these titles for roles be employed for leadership roles within the church. On the contrary, they are highlighted here only to redefine the contemporary understanding of leadership to suit the *Kurukh* context. This redefining of leadership, firstly, paves the way for believers to accept leadership roles within the church without conflict. Second, it enhances the ministry of those in leadership roles within the church. Finally, it serves to edify believers and infuse spiritual health into the church. Taken together, it creates a conducive ethos for effective discipleship.

The Role of Women

This study would be incomplete without a strong emphasis on the role of women in the emergence of a vibrant *Kurukh* church. In general, it is found that tribal women make a greater contribution to economic development than tribal men. Devendra Thakur substantiates:

> It is noteworthy that the tribal women who constitute 5.81 percent of the total female population of India contribute 28.34 percent of the female working population. On the other hand, scheduled caste and non-scheduled caste women who form 22 percent and 74 percent of the total female population constitute 24.60 percent and 47 percent of the women's working population respectively.[20]

The status of women and their influence in *Kurukh* culture has been explained in a previous chapter. At present, the number of Christian women is significantly higher than the number Christian men among the *Kurukhar*. It is not only true of the *Kurukh* church but of the present Indian Christian population in general. Yet women for the most part remain ill-equipped for the work of ministry in the churches.

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[20] Devendra Thakur and D. N. Thakur, *Tribal Women* (New Delhi: Deep & Deep Publications, 1995), 8.

Dasan Jeyaraj observes: "Women in India are very much a part of the socio-cultural practices, and this includes their commitment to the values and practices of immediate family and larger society (mostly this refers to caste and community)."[21] The involvement of women continues to be vital to ongoing missions in India. Mothers have an obvious and definite influence on future generations, and it is true particularly of the *Kurukhar*. They are more effective in reaching and teaching children. *Kurukh* women, through their songs and graceful dances, have passed on their unique cultural thoughts from one generation to another and kept it alive. In *Kurukh* society, women alone can effectively disciple women. Similarly, wives are in the best position to witness to their husbands and their families. Christian women are credited with a large number of such secondary converts to the Christian faith. It is impossible to envision a strong *Kurukh* church without women adequately equipped as disciples with the skills to disciple others. God's unique role for them in the fulfillment of the Great Commission among their own people needs due recognition. Further, they deserve to be identified, trained, and empowered as Christian religious leaders.

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[21] Dasan Jeyaraj, "On Conversion," *DHARMA DEEPIKA. A South Asian Journal of Missiological Research* 38, no.17 (December 1, 2013): 52.

CONCLUSION

Chapter one provides definitions of key terms and concepts that are essential to understanding the basis of this study, including models of contextualization and inculturation. On account of the parallels observed between the Christward movement in Jharkhand and those in other parts of the world, the chapter also features a brief overview of a few similar indigenous movements in Asia, Africa, and Latin America. Chapter two then describes the process of indigenization of Christianity and the emergence of the indigenous church in India. A brief description of subalterns in India who have been the predominant population among whom these movements have taken place provides the foundation for this study targeting the *Kurukh* people. The chapter concludes by identifying the distinctives of the current Christward movement more succinctly described as the "third wave." Chapter three is a detailed sketch of the history, culture, religion, and life in general of the *Kurukhar*. Their worldview and religious beliefs factoring positive responses to Christ are discussed, and finally suggestions are made for building a healthy *Kurukh* Christian church. The importance of considering contextualization and inculturation of the gospel as an indispensable need to building a healthy and sustainable *Kurukh* church is discussed in chapter four.

Chapter five, the final chapter, brings the study to a conclusion by resolving the identified problem by way of recommending the contextualizing of the Christian faith and the raising of appropriately trained *Kurukh* leaders equipped to disciple *Kurukh* believers through Christian religious education prepared and organized specifically for the *Kurukh* Christians.

The first set of three indigenous mission principles of self-administrating (self-governing); self-reliant (self-supporting); and self-reproducing (self-propagating) were set forth by Henry Venn and Rolland Allan in the early nineteenth century. They were to be applied by Western missionaries in foreign fields to indigenize local efforts. The concept of people movements, church-planting, and related modalities were not as developed as they currently are. More recently, Paul Hiebert has introduced the two additional principles of self-theologizing and self-missionizing as principles for authentic indigeneity.

This study further recommends the consideration of self-renewing[1] and self-regenerating[2] as two more fundamental elements for the indigeneity of churches. Self-renewal,[3] whether it is social, spiritual, or structural, is seen as an ongoing and indispensable process preventing decay and degeneration. A church will need to build within itself the capacity for self-renewal in order to transform itself and bring about

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[1] "Do not conform any longer to the pattern of this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what God's will is—his good, pleasing and perfect will" (Romans 12:2 NIV).

" . . . since you have taken off your old self with its practices and have put on the new self, which is being renewed in knowledge in the image of its Creator" (Colossians 3:10 NIV).

[2] "At one time we too were foolish, disobedient, deceived and enslaved by all kinds of passions and pleasures. We lived in malice and envy, being hated and hating one another. But when the goodness and loving kindness of God our Savior appeared, he saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit, whom he poured out on us richly through Jesus Christ our Savior, so that being justified by his grace we might become heirs according to the hope of eternal life" (Titus 3:3-7 NIV).

[3] The Greek term translating "renewal," *anakainizo,* in its different forms carries the basic meanings of either "to cause something to become new and different (i.e., better)"—Rom. 12:2; Col. 3:10. 2—or "to cause a change to a previous preferable state"—2 Cor. 4:16; Heb. 6:4-6 (taken from Louw and Nida's *Greek-English Lexicon,* vol. 1, pp. 157, 594). Moulton and Milligan, *The Vocabulary of the Greek Testament*, opine that this term (i.e., *anakkainōsis*) cannot be found in Greek literature earlier than Paul. Paul may have coined this term himself (p. 34).

timely changes, both within itself and its surroundings. Self-regenerating[4] differs from self-renewing in that it denotes re-creation or rebirth of something that has degenerated and died. Such regeneration[5] is essential when bodies of believers (churches) have lost their relevance in the community and are unable to carry out their mission and purpose for existence.

Both self-regeneration and self-renewal may be subjects for future research individually, requiring deeper thought and elaboration than this paper allows. The process, methodology, modalities, and outcomes of self-regeneration and self-renewal relating to each aspect of individual and community life are intricate, complex, and elaborate. They are not delved into here. Nevertheless, the point is stressed that unless any entity has the innate capability for self-renewal and self-regeneration, it may not be considered totally autochthonous, as it will continue to depend on external sources for health and vitality.

Lack of adequate spiritual nurture of Christians results in churches that are stagnant, deficient in growth, spiritually immature and unsustainable. Their lifeline for survival is forever dependent on external sources of support. This reality is observed as the existing problem among *Kurukh* Christians in Jharkhand and an attempt is made to address it. A sociological study of the *Kurukh* people brings to surface bridges and barriers to the Gospel. Viewing the *Kurukhar* through the lens of cultural anthropology

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[4] Hodge's *Systematic Theology* indicates that the word *regeneration* is used almost universally to refer to the instantaneous change from spiritual death to spiritual life. He says it is not used to designate "the whole work of sanctification, nor the first stages of that work comprehended in conversion, much less justification or any mere external change of state." In calling it a spiritual resurrection—the beginning of a new life, Hodge adds, "Sometimes the word expresses the *act* of God. God regenerates. Sometimes it designates the subjective *effect* of his act."

[5] Strong's Concordance defines *regeneration* (Greek: *paliggenesia*) as "new birth."

clarifies elements of the Gospel that translate naturally into the *Kurukh* culture without being imposed. A contextually relevant interpretation of theology without compromise to biblical absolutes is perceived to be essential for the Christian Faith to become deeply rooted among the *Kurukh* people. Crucial then to instilling health and vitality into the *Kurukh* churches is an appropriate methodology for identifying *Oraon* leaders suitably trained and equipped to realize this vision.

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GLOSSARY

Addai	A suggested name for *Kurukh* religious beliefs and practices
Akhra	Stage, Playground, a leveled area found in the center of most tribal villages in Chotanagpur. It is used for public prayers, meetings, and for singing and dancing
Asin Nad	Evil spirit
Baiga	Religious specialist
Bhaiā-Bahin	Brother and sister, the only humans saved by Dharmes from great conflagration
Bhajans	Prayers sung to the gods
Bhakta	Devotee
Bhakti	Devotion
Bheluaphari	A mode of divination using twigs
Bhelua	Semicarpisanacardium
Bhuinhar	Land owner. The later settlers like the *Oraons* who did not have the *khuntkatti* rights but settled on *Munda* lands
Chala Pachho	The goddess of the sacred *sal* grove/*Sarnamata*
Chhathi	The sixth day (after birth)
Chotanagpur	Pre-independent Chotanagpur Division consisting of seven tributary states. Present Chotanagpur, a hilly and forest-covered region, is an administrative division of the federal state of Jharkhand
Dali-Dhiba	Bride money
Danda-Kattā	Principal religious rite to worship Dharmes and to ward off evil
Dhangar	Laborer; another name for the *Oraon*

Dharmes	*Oraon* name for God
Dhumkuria	Male Youth house for unmarried boys in a *Oraon* community
Dharti	Earth
Diku	Outsider/non-tribal
Dowry	Bridegroom money
Handiā, Hadia	Rice beer or *Jhara* in *Kuṛukh*. Handiā has both deep religious and cultural significance.
Harijans	Children of God—a name given by Mahatma Gandhi to "untouchables" in India
Jangali	Forest dweller
JaniSikhar	A hunt by the *Oraon* tribal women conducted once in every twelve years, wearing male clothes. It includes a mythology where women had defended the fort of Rohtasgarh against Sher Shah Suri for three days
Jatra	A fair
Jharkhand	28thFederal state of India created on 15th November 2000 by Bifurcating Bihar
Johar	The word of Greetings: The body is bent with the arms folded to show respect. The word is spoken aloud
Jonkhmatho	Youth Leader
Jonkhar	Youth
Karam	Tree which is used at the *Karma* festival
Karma	A major festival among the *Oraons* (and others) which takes place just after the rains begin and the fields have been sown with new seeds in the months of September to November
Khalihani	Threshing flow or harvest festival

Khunt	Lineage; a stake stuck in the ground claiming ownership
Khunt Nad	Family or ancestral spirit
Khuntkatti	The traditional communal system of land ownership of the *Mundas*
Kohabenja	Great wedding
Kotwar/bhandari	A post held by a villager who protects the Karam god
Lohar	An iron-working caste group
Madait	A help where the members of the lineage or the village are invited by a household for a specific task for one or more days, e.g. ploughing fields, cutting crops or building a house
Mahto	The representative of the King in the village; now hereditary. He gets some land in return
Makka	Another name for the *Sal* tree
Mama	Mother's brothers
Mandar	Earthen drum; a long percussion hung around the neck and beaten on both sides by the hand
Nad	Spirit
Naurpoonp	Flower of the Sal tree
Pach-balar	Ancestor-spirits
Paddakamna	Pacification of the spirits
Pahan	Religious specialist
Pahanain	The wife of the pahan
Palkansna	The highest form of sacrifice to Dharmes
Panbhora	A post appointed for ritual purposes. The person appointed helps the *pahan* to fill up water for rituals and gets some land in return

Panchayat	An Indian system of local government at the village level where a small group of representatives decide on matters at village meetings
Pandita	Literal meaning—the learned one: a title bestowed upon people who have made significant contributions to society in the field of literature
Parampara	A person devoted to a lifelong learning and spiritual quest under a Teacher
Parha	Traditional system of local government in Chotanagpur
Pelo-Erpa	Youth house for girls
Raiyat	Tenant
Raja	King
Ranchi	Capital of the federal state of Jharkhand
Sadhu	An alternate term for Sanyasi
Sal	Sacred tree
Sangam	An association of people
Sanyasi	A person who has deprived himself of everything in his spiritual quest
Sanyasin	A woman Sanyasi
Sarhul	Festival occurring around March-April of every year in the Chotanagpur area involving elaborate rituals and celebrations at the end of the harvest period. Ritually it is the feast of the marriage of heaven and earth
Saraswat	A title bestowed upon people indicating that they are learned and of high descent
Sarna	A sacred grove. Also considered as the traditional religion of *Oraons*

Sohrai	A festival where domestic animals are honored. This occurs around the month of November every year among the people in the Chotanagpur region
Tanjore	A District of Tamilnadu in South India
Vellalar	A subcaste of Tamilians in South India

APPENDIX A

Definition of Key Terms and Concepts

Christward Movements

This phrase was introduced by Donald McGavran first in his book *The Bridges of God* to describe indigenous movements to Christ as opposed to movements to Christian tradition and practices introduced by foreign missions.[1] This term also differentiates between indigenous Christian movements and indigenous movements that may be of other religious or social, political, or cultural orientation. In McGavran's book, he discusses indigenous Christian movements in India that preceded, coincided with, and followed events that occurred during the time of the British rule.[2] In talking about the significance of these movements, McGavran writes, "Christward movements of peoples are the supreme goal of missionary effort."[3] In other words, Christward movements of peoples should never be brushed aside as social phenomena. A closer observation of such movements leads to the belief that they hold a certain element of mystery in that the divine power of God is at work. McGavran affirms that they are God's special gift to his body, the church.[4]

Certain common threads are observed between Christward movements in India and indigenous Christian movements in other parts of the world, particularly in Africa, Latin America, and Asia. They are worth a brief mention here because the emergence of

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[1] Donald A. McGavran, *The Bridges of God: A Study in the Strategy of Missions.* (New York: Friendship Press, 1955).

[2] Ibid., 11-15.

[3] Ibid.

[4] Ibid., 162.

these independent indigenous movements and churches planted through them are shifting the center of Christian influence[5] both theologically and numerically from the North to the South, turning the global church more non-Western than it has ever been.[6] As Paul Hiebert states, "The emergence of independent churches around the world expressing indigenous forms of Christianity is undermining the equation of Christianity with Western culture."[7]

Caste

The caste system divides Hindus into four major categories hierarchically, namely Brahmins, Kshtriyas, Vaishyas, and Shudras. It is generally believed that these categories of people originated from Brahma, the creator God. *Manusmriti,* which is regarded as the most authoritative book on Hindu law and dates back to 1500BC, endorses the caste system as the basis regulating the order of society. This system has continued.[8]

The *Brahmins*, who were mainly teachers and intellectuals and considered as the priestly community, were placed at the top of the hierarchy. They were believed to have been created from Brahma's head. The second place in the hierarchy was given to the *Kshatriyas*, or the warriors, supposedly created from Brahma's hands. In the third category were the *Vaishyas*, or the traders, believed to have been created from Brahma's thighs. At the bottom of the hierarchy were the *Shudras*, who came from Brahma's feet

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[5] David Barrett, ed., *World Christian Encyclopedia* (NY: Oxford University Press, 1982).

[6] W. Buhlmann, *The Coming of the Third Church* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1978).

[7] Paul G. Hiebert, "Missiological Education for a Global Era" in *Missiological Education for the 21st Century,* edited by J. Dudley Woodberry, Charles Van Engen and Edgar J. Elliston; (Maryknoll, Orbis, 1996), 36.

[8] Govind Chandra Pande, *Foundations of Indian Culture Volume II* (New Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass Publishers Private Limited, 1984),140.

and were created to do all the menial jobs.[9] There exists a clear separation between the first three referred to as the "twice born" and ritually pure and the *Shudras,* whose ritual purity is in question and who are referred to as "once born."[10]

The main castes were further divided into about 3,000 castes and 25,000 sub-castes, each based on their specific occupation. Also and outside of this Hindu caste system were the *achhoots*[11]—the *Dalits* or the untouchables.[12]

Dalit

Outside of the above-mentioned castes, the Indian society categorizes one more community as the fifth caste or outcaste. On account of their inclusion into Hinduism, they are perceived as a separate segment, sub-human or non-human. Although this category comprises about sixteen percent of the Indian populace, its people remain suppressed and "cast outside" the borders of Hindu society, thereby bearing the derogatory titles of "outcaste," "untouchable," "exterior caste," "depressed class," and "*Dalit.*" On the basis of caste distinctions, *Dalits* are forced to accept inhuman and mean functions in society and go through unbearable oppression.[13] James Massey, a leading *Dalit* Christian, says, "The Dalits' severest loss is the loss of their human identity. The basic task before them is to recover their human dignity which they have lost because of

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[9] Ibid., 141-240.

[10] Ibid., 136-139.

[11] Sanskrit word translated "dirt" or "refuse."

[12] Govind Chandra Pande, *Foundations of Indian Culture Volume II* (New Delhi: 1984), 240.

[13] Raj Irudaya, *Mission to the Marginalized: A Subaltern, Feminist, and Interreligious Reading of John 4:1-42* (Bangalore: Asian Trading, 2007), 35.

the centuries-old oppression which they have faced."[14] Among the subalterns in India, the *Dalits* are considered as extremely marginalized, facing atrocities and injustice.[15] It is important to note that according to Wati Longchar, a tribal theologian and Christian leader, both the Tribals and *Dalits* in India share a history of oppression.[16] Both the Tribals and *Dalits* have been so totally assimilated into the Hindu caste structure that they are now generally identified as Hindus.[17] However, they still remain discriminated against.

This segment of people has taken on this title *Dalit* as a self-expression in a positive way to denote their self-pride and, as Sathyanathan Clarke points out, as "a resistive surge for combating oppression."[18] Quoting a Human Rights Watch report, Clarke explains the current plight of the *Dalits* in the following words, underscoring the need and their own aspirations for liberation:

> More than one-sixth of India's population, some 160 million people, live a precarious existence, shunned by much of society because of their rank as untouchables or Dalits—literally meaning "broken" people—at the bottom of India's caste system. Dalits are discriminated against, denied access to land, forced to work in degrading conditions, and routinely abused at the hands of the police arid of higher-caste groups that enjoy the State's protection. In what has been called "hidden apartheid" entire villages in many Indian states remain completely segregated by caste.[19]

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[14] James Massey, *Dalits in India: Religion as a Source of Bondage or Liberation with Special Reference to Christians* (New Delhi: Manohar Publishers & Distributors and ISPCK, 1995), 130.

[15] Raj Irudaya, *Mission to the Marginalized: A Subaltern, Feminist, and Interreligious Reading of John 4:1-42* (Bangalore: Asian Trading, 2007), 35.

[16] A. Wati Longchar, *An Emerging Asian Theology: Tribal Theology: Issue, Method and Perspective* (Jorhat, Assam: Tribal Study Centre, Eastern Theological College, 2000), 6.

[17] Ibid., 7.

[18] Sathyanathan Clarke, **"**Viewing the Bible Through the Eyes and Ears of Subalterns in India," Religion Online, http://www.religion-online.org/showarticle.asp?title=2444 (accessed Month April 21, 2015)

[19] Ibid.

Great Tradition and Little Tradition

Information, beliefs, and customs are handed down from one generation to another by the spoken word, through everyday practice and examples. These inherited practices, opinions, belief systems, attitudes, patterns of interaction, and conventions in turn become tradition.[20]

Redfield describes great tradition as being "associated with the elites, literate, and reflective few who are capable of analyzing, interpreting, and reflecting cultural knowledge. Great tradition is a body of knowledge which functions as the beacon light of knowledge."[21] In contrast, "little tradition is comprised of the belief patterns, the institutions, knowledge, including proverbs, riddles, anecdotes, folk tales, legends, myths, and the whole body of folk-lore of the folk and/or the unlettered peasants who imbibe cultural knowledge from the great tradition."[22]

According to McKim Marriot, a student of Redfield, a great tradition owes its existence to two processes. The primary process is universalization, by which Marriot means "the carrying forward of the material which is already present in the little traditions in the villages to a body which 'universalized' the knowledge into that great tradition."[23] The second process is parochialization, or the "downward spread" to the village of the great tradition. "Both universalization and parochialization are

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[20] Ibid., 336.

[21] Ibid.

[22] Ibid.

[23] Oysteins La Bianca, "Great and Little Traditions: A Framework for Study," Academia.edu, http://www.academia.edu/744153/Great_and_Little_Traditions_A_Framework_for_Study (accessed July 11, 2013)

characterized by transformations, and there are gaps in communication which the communities fill at their own discretion."[24] In discussing the relationship and interaction between the two traditions, Raghukalafurther elucidates the following:

> The two traditions are interdependent. Great tradition and little tradition have long affected each other and continue to do so. Great epics have arisen out of elements of traditional tale-telling by many people, and epics have returned again to the peasantry for modification and incorporation into local culture. Great and little tradition can be thought of as two currents of thought and action, distinguishable, yet ever flowing into and out of each other. A picture of their relationships would be something like those "histo-maps" we sometimes see, those diagrams of the rise and change through the time of religions and civilizations. Teachings are invented and they are continually understood by peasants in ways not intended by the teachers. Therefore, great and little traditions can be thought of as two currents.[25]

Subaltern

"Subaltern groups are those assigned inferior rank by the dominant group."[26] When the term *subaltern* is used in post-colonial theory, it generally describes the lower classes and the social groups at the margins of a society. A person's social status in such cases deprives them of human agency.[27] The practice of untouchability in India is a classic example. In the Indian context, the *Dalits* fall under the subaltern category. Mahatma Gandhi named these people "Harijans," or "the people of God."[28] The Indian

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[24] Knut Odner, *Tradition and Transmission: Bantu, Indo-European, and Circumpolar Great Traditions*. (Bergen, Norway: Norse Publication, 2000), 34.

[25] Le Karnala Raghukala, *Gaurav* (Madhyapradesh, India: J.S.M. Prakasan, 1980), 21.

[26] Roger E.Hedlund, *The Quest for Identity – India's Churches of Indigenous Origin* (Delhi: ISPCK, 2000), 8.

[27] Ranajit Guha, and Gayatri Chakravorty. Spivak. *Selected Subaltern Studies*. (New York: Oxford University Press, 1988), 332.

[28] Roger E.Hedlund, *The Quest for Identity – India's Churches of Indigenous Origin* (Delhi: ISPCK, 2000), 9.

government refers to them as the "scheduled castes" and "scheduled tribes."[29] These well-intentioned terminologies, rather than helping these people break free from the classification, have driven them to internalize it and for the rest of society to categorize them. The term *subaltern* was first used in India by Ranajit Guha in the late 1970s.[30]

As it relates to Christian studies, Hedlund says, "A subaltern approach to Christian studies seeks the viewpoint of the non-elite. In terms of Christian institutions in India, perspectives arising 'from below' through local initiative may be classed as subaltern. They are not imposed; they are the expression of local people who are not so privileged, marginalized or oppressed."[31] It needs to be pointed out that subaltern perspectives or the view of subaltern people by outsiders and subaltern narratives of history are different from one another. Subalterneity tends to assume that popularly accepted narratives are deficient and therefore attempts to reconstruct them.[32] A difference also exists between subaltern religion and subaltern history.[33] Subaltern history is the history of a people oppressed and marginalized by the majority.[34] While subaltern religion may be considered as that of the minorities, in India it is the religion of the majority, not belonging to the so called 'great tradition' of philosophical Hinduism but to

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[29] The expression "Scheduled Castes" was first coined by the Simon Commission (appointed by the British Government) between 1929 and 1932 and was later incorporated in the Government of India Act of 1935.

[30] Roger E.Hedlund, *The Quest for Identity – India's Churches of Indigenous Origin* (Delhi: ISPCK, 2000), 8.

[31] Ibid., 8-9.

[32] Stanislas Savarimuthu, *A Community in Search of Its Identity: Mt. 21:28-22:14 in a Subaltern Perspective* (Delhi: Indian Society for Promoting Christian Knowledge [ISPCK], 2007),xx.

[33] V. Thomas, *Understanding Subaltern History: Theoretical Tools* (Bangalore: BTESSC / SATHRI, 2006), xv.

[34] Ibid., xiv.

folk religion.[35] So the concept of subaltern perspectives and the concept of subaltern narratives are considered significant in their usage for this study.

Adivasis

The third category of Indian society is comprised of people grouped by the government as Tribals or Scheduled Tribes (ST). Although they do not fall under the Hindu caste system, they are marginalized by caste communities. Wati Longchar posits:

> The Constitution of India does not give a clear definition of 'tribe'. It simply says that they must be a homogenous community who belong neither to the Hindus nor the Muslim communities and they must be economically poor and socially marginalized. Thus, the term is used to represent a community who has been oppressed, suppressed and exploited by the higher castes of Indian society. Those who are officially recognized as "tribal" are entitled to receive benefits and opportunities granted by the Indian government.[36]

Claiming to be the original people of the land and referencing their cultural and religious relatedness to things of the earth/land, they prefer to be known as *Adivasis* (ancient or original dwellers). Bishop Minz, an *Adivasi* Christian leader, says this of his people:

> The Adivasis generally have lived through exploitative, oppressive and suppressive social and political structures in India. Mostly, they have been alienated from their land both by 'greedy' caste communities and by overzealous governments, which takes away tribal land for mining and big industries. Thus, poverty and estrangement from the means of their livelihood (land) threaten Adivasi communities in India. Along with this there is a serious threat to their traditional culture and worldview from the forces of both modernization and Hinduization.[37]

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[35] Ibid., xv.

[36] A. Wati Longchar, *An Emerging Asian Theology: Tribal Theology: Issue, Method and Perspective* (Jorhat, Assam: Tribal Study Centre, Eastern Theological College, 2000), 3.

[37] Nirmal Minz, *Rise Up, My People, and Claim the Promise: The Gospel among the Tribes of India* (Delhi: ISPCK, 1997), 12.

Indigenous and Indigenize

William A. Smalley defines the nature of an indigenous church thus: "It is a group of believers who live out their life, including their socialized Christian activity, in the patterns of the local society, and for whom any transformations of that society come out of their felt needs under the guidance of the Holy Spirit and the Scriptures."[38]

Attempts at defining the concept have been wordy due to the complexity of issues that surround it. Defining *indigenous* and *indigeneity* also calls for the explanation of culture, intensive theological reflections, search for scriptural foundations, practical implications in various contexts, and several other factors. Most attempts have therefore been definitions of what the consequence of being indigenous should be rather than what it actually is.

Henry Venn (1796-1873) and Rufus Anderson (1796-1880) were the earliest proponents of the indigenous church. Alan Tippett's words about the indigenous church refer directly to Venn in the following:

> The idea of the indigenous church came to us in its original form from the greatest missionary theorist of the last century, Henry Venn. The idea was based on the concept of Selfhood, and was always accompanied by its sister doctrine of Euthanasia. Thus the emergence of the Church and the dying of the Mission in the foreign land were conceptualized as part of a single process.[39]

In order to appreciate and fully understand Venn's and Anderson's contributions to mission thought and practice relative to the concept of the term *indigenous*, a brief perspective on the period in which they lived is important. Both of them spent virtually

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[38] William A. Smalley, *Readings in Missionary Anthropology II* (South Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1978), 72-73.

[39] Alan R. Tippett, *Introduction to Missiology* (Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1987). 42

their entire lives in close association with the missionary movement.[40] Venn served as the Honorary Clerical Secretary of the Church Missionary Society (CMS) from 1841 to 1872. Anderson was appointed Assistant Secretary of the American Board of Commissioners for Foreign Missions, holding primary responsibility for interaction with overseas missionaries and later becoming its policy maker and administrator and traveling extensively in Latin America, the Mediterranean and Near East, India, Ceylon, Syria, Turkey, and Hawaii.[41] He was involved in the founding and governance of several educational, cultural, and philanthropic institutions. These two men's varied experiences had led them to form deep convictions over the need for the new churches established in the field to be given autonomy as early as possible.[42] It was Venn who developed the concept of the indigenous church by using the three "selfs," namely self-support, self-government, and self-propagation, and it was on his advice that the indigenous principle was put into practice in South India.

Around the same time as Venn, but independently, Anderson urged that the aim of missions should be nothing less than the establishment of self-supporting, self-governing, and self-propagating churches. He insisted that the mandate of missions is not the "civilizing" of heathen peoples but their conversion to the Christian faith and the establishment of missionary churches that should be accomplished through preaching the

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[40] Wilbert R. Shenk, "The Contribution of Henry Venn to Mission Thought," Biblicalstudies.org.uk, http://www.biblicalstudies.org.uk/pdf/anvil/02-1_025.pdf (accessed August 23, 2014)

[41] Ibid.

[42] Ibid.

gospel.[43] It seemed to be his belief that the desirable spread of "civilization" would be accomplished most effectively through the propagation of the gospel.[44]

It was still an early phase of Western missionary enterprise and the first stage of foreign missions, when concern was directed toward the structure and function of missionary bodies and the local church started by foreign missionaries within the setting of a "mission station." Three fundamental points need to be underscored. First, the discussion during this early period was not a plea for indigeneity, that is, the raising of the church by indigenous people themselves on their own native terms of structure and governance, but indigenization of the church established and governed by foreign missions gradually taking indigenous forms of expression—an important distinction. Second and more importantly, the discussion was among and addressed to Western missionaries and sending agencies. Such measures towards indigenization were in no way an expression of the native church's plea or aspiration to cut the umbilical cord. Third, the emphasis at that time was on proclamation of the Good News, individual conversions, and establishing mission stations. It was a phase in missions when the notion of establishing congregations with intentionality (planting churches) in contrast to winning individual converts had not fully evolved and been established.

During the 1920s and 1930s, many attempts were made to describe how a church should be indigenized. Two are of particular interest since one addresses the perception of community and the other describes what an indigenized Christian community would manifest. In 1926, Dr. John R. Mott, a later recipient of the Nobel Prize for his work in

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[43] Ibid.

[44] Gerald H. Anderson, *Biographical Dictionary of Christian Missions* (New York: Macmillan Reference USA, 1998).

international church and missionary movements, stated that "indigenous churches are those in which the natives find themselves at home and which even impress their non-Christian friends as national, homelike, and belonging to the country."[45] In 1925, an American Baptist group made an attempt to provide a technical definition of indigenization: "It follows that a truly indigenous church will not merely appropriate those values which have been brought to it by others, but will make use of any permanent values in its own heritage and will endeavor to make its own contribution to the world's knowledge of the riches available in Christ."[46]

Other efforts to describe an indigenous church ranged from one as simple as Dr. Diles', which is "a church that grows naturally in its particular cultural setting"[47] to a more complex description by Daniel C. Hardin as "a church in which God, Christ, and the Holy Spirit, in contact with people of a particular cultural setting, give rise to a Christian body that is outwardly and uniquely molded by that culture over a fixed framework of fundamental scriptural doctrine."[48] Melvin Hodges described an indigenous church as "a native church which shares the life of the country in which it is planted and finds itself ready to govern itself, support itself and reproduce itself."[49]

A more recent definition encapsulates both the present thinking as it has evolved in India and also illustrates the dilemma missiologists and scholars still face worldwide in striving to adequately define the terms *indigenous* and *indigenize*. "Indianization,

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[45] Gailyn Rheenen, *Missions: Biblical Foundations & Contemporary Strategies* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Pub. House, 1996), 184.

[46] Ibid.

[47] Ibid., 186.

[48] Ibid.

[49] Ibid.

contextualization and indigenization are expressions of the effort towards change/relevance made by a non-indigenous church (one of alien origin and pattern) in an attempt to give it an Indian face."[50] Fervent scholarly attempts are being made even now to adequately and meaningfully convey the essence of the words *indigenize*, *indigenous,* and *indigeneity* relating to the church and Christward movements. Unresolved discussion and essential debates continue, which are too vast and extensive to be included here.

The process of indigenization in and of itself is complex and amounts to reconstruction of much that has been established. In trying to explain its complexity, Tippet observes, "It is much easier to start a church on indigenous principles than it is to change over from a long established, paternalistic, enclosed, mission station congregation."[51] Quoting F.E. Williams, he further explains: "Reconstruction involves three things. The first, the scrapping of whatever is useless, having served its purpose; the second, the reshaping of whatever has still some power of service; and the third, the adding of whatever is required of the new to make the instrument with which we work efficient for its purposes today."[52]

Vincent Kumaradoss, a missiologist scholar from the Indian state of Tamilnadu, points out that the "three-self" test alone will not determine indigeneity since a church or movement could have all three qualities and yet not be indigenous.[53] He says an indigenous church or an indigenous movement may be described as one that is not the

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[50] Bo Ho Huang, *Mission from the Underside: Transforming Theological Education in Asia* (Bangalore: Programme for Theology and Cultures in Asia, 2010), 38-41.

[51] Ibid.

[52] Ibid.

[53] Charles H. Kraft and Tom N. Wisley, *Readings in Dynamic Indigeneity* (Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1979).

result of direct foreign work; rather, it is established primarily on indigenous initiative.[54] Church historians and missiologists make the observation that churches and independent movements of such description were generally birthed as a result of a search of native Christians for a public sphere without the supervision, direction, and monitoring of missionaries, where their full and free participation and expression of thought and opinion was possible.[55]

It is true that churches that missionaries helped establish provided a public space for the converts to gather without any discrimination of caste or race. But these gatherings were authorized and supervised by missionaries. As a result, there was a general feeling that the converts did not have the full freedom to discuss or carry out their own agenda for various reasons. Thus started the search for alternative space and opportunity that resulted in the rise of independent churches.[56] Such an awakening identified by Kumaradas is not exclusive to Tamilnadu, South India. Indian Christians in other parts of the country also shared the same emotions. The origins, structure, growth, and leadership of a few of such indigenous movements that had significantly contributed to the Indian church are discussed later.

It was pointed out earlier that Indian Christianity is generally found in the little tradition of the so-called fringe sections.[57] Questions of contextualization, adaptation, accommodation, and the cultural transformation of the Christian faith are

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[54] Ibid.

[55] Vincent Kumaradoss, "Creation of Alternative Public Spheres and Church Indigenization in 19th Century Colonial Tamilnadu," in *Christianity is Indian: The Emergence of an Indigenous Community,* ed. Roger E. Hedlund (Delhi: Published for MIIS, Mylapore by ISPCK, 2000), 3-5.

[56] Ibid.

[57] Roger E. Hedlund, *The Quest for Identity – India's Churches of Indigenous Origin* (Delhi: ISPCK, 2000), 3.

topics of hot debate in the traditional Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant denominations—all churches of the great tradition in religions studies—whereas cultural incarnation of the faith is a normal expression in churches of the little tradition.[58]

A weakness in the indigenous church perspective, pointed out by Gailyn Rheenen, is the implication that an indigenous church must become immersed in the culture, since the term literally translates as that which is "born from within."[59] In other words, *indigenous* should mean what is local, innate, or thoroughly native to a culture in contrast to what might be otherwise considered unfamiliar, foreign, exotic, or alien.[60] Rheenen builds his argument on the premise that on account of human fallenness, cultures may not always uphold the values of God. Following the cue from 1 John 5:19 that "the whole world is under the control of the evil one," he posits: "While acknowledging that the church must speak the language of culture and be sensitive to people's understanding of reality, the indigenous perspective fails to prepare disciples of Christ for countercultural living in pagan culture. If Christianity becomes totally indigenous, it loses its divine distinctiveness."[61] He therefore suggests an alternate perspective, saying the following:

> A better phrase for the indigenous concept is "building responsible churches". The term responsible implies many of the intended meanings of indigenous, without much of its baggage. Responsible implies that the church has grown to maturity in Christ and can now walk alongside those who founded her. The church is able to propagate itself, support itself, govern itself, and demonstrate the attributes of God in the midst of pagan society. Responsible churches are those

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[58] Ibid.

[59] Gailyn Rheenen, *Missions: Biblical Foundations & Contemporary Strategies* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Pub. House, 1996), 188.

[60] Ibid.

[61] Ibid.

> that have grown to maturity and are fully able to reflect the attributes of God in appropriate ways within their cultural contexts.[62]

On closer examination, however, it is not difficult to ascertain that these arguments are still inclined toward the discussion of the process of indigenization rather than what indigenous churches are from their very origin and birth. Whatever the case may be, Edward Dayton's words poignantly summarize the lengthy explanation above on this subject:

> God is willing to start with Christians where they are and move them forward toward greater peace, unity, and love, God is more willing than we often are to start with groups which do not meet his holy standards. He will more and more transform them into the image of his kingdom. . . The ultimate result we plan for and seek is a cluster of congregations able to complete the evangelization of their own people.[63]

Autochthonous

In ancient Greek mythology, *autochthones* were those mortals who sprang out from the soil, rocks, and trees. They were rooted in the soil and belonged to the land eternally. The practice in ancient Greece of describing legendary heroes and persons of ancient lineage as "earthborn" greatly strengthened the doctrine of autochthony.[64] In the present context, the term *autochthonous people* or *autochthones* is suggestive of people who are the original inhabitants of a place and those descended from them without any integration with people of foreign cultures. Current medical definitions of *autochthonous* also provide additional insights for this study and the attempt to describe indigenous movements:

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[62] Ibid., 188-189.

[63] Edward R. Dayton and David Allen Fraser. *Planning Strategies for World Evangelization* (Grand Rapids, MI: W.B. Eerdmans Pub. Co., 1980), 250.

[64] Ibid.

1. indigenous or endemic to a region
2. contracted in the area where reported
3. originated in that part of the body where found—used chiefly of pathological conditions[65]

The word *autochthonous* was first used by Eugene Nida with reference to indigenous churches and movements of a special nature that he identified in Latin America.[66] *Autochthonous* churches in Latin America as Nida described were the ones that

1. had developed spontaneously, without a history of missionary involvement; or
2. were planted by missionary efforts of other Latin American *autochthonous* churches; or
3. were formerly mission-related but have broken foreign links and reflect the people's culture in the deepest sense.[67]

The two main criteria were autonomy and contextualization.[68]

Church Planting Movement

According to David Garrison, first and foremost, a CPM is identified by its rapid reproduction.[69] Within a very brief span of time, churches that are newly planted start

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[65] Ibid.

[66] Eugene A. Nida, *Message and Mission: The Communication of the Christian Faith*, 1st ed. (New York: Harper, 1960).

[67] Ibid.

[68] Ibid.

[6969] David V. Garrison, *Church Planting Movements: How God Is Redeeming a Lost World* (Midlothian, VA: WIG Take Resources, 2004), 2.

other churches that follow the same pattern of rapid reproduction, swiftly moving toward reaching the entire people group. Second, a CPM does not simply add new churches in single file but multiplies with practically every church it engages. It starts several churches simultaneously, increasing the number of believers exponentially. The third characteristic of a CPM is that it is indigenous in origin. In other words, it is spawned from within through the witness and effort of the same people segment as opposed to external evangelism initiatives. Although the first church may begin through initial and limited help of outsiders, the movement rapidly shifts from outsiders to insiders. The fourth characteristic of a CPM is that it is launched as churches plant churches with the vibrant engagement of new Christians in witnessing and propagating their new faith, acting as spiritual multipliers. Again, outside church planters play a primary role in the formation of the first few churches, but soon their part in the process becomes secondary and supportive as a movement gets underway. Finally, a CPM gains rapid momentum when taking place within a people group or segments of a population that are bridged to one another through strong social and cultural ties.[70]

CPMs are unique and should not be mistaken for revival movements or spiritual awakenings that have occurred at various times in the history of the church. Garrison enlightens us on this truth by stating that "unlike the great revivals or spiritual awakenings that periodically occur among Christians, Church Planting Movements are centered within unreached people groups or concentrations of lostness. The lost aren't merely dozing in Christ—needing revival—they are dead in their sins and trespasses until

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[70] Ibid.,21-22.

Christ gives them life."[71] It is also important to point out how CPMs differ from mere people movements and church growth movements in order to avoid certain misconceptions. Whereas people movements could involve a mass conversion of people, they may not necessarily lead to church multiplication. They may be the result of mass evangelism or certain focused evangelistic efforts but lack the important element of church planting. Although there may be some overlap between the two, CPMs differ from church growth movements in that they are not focused on growing a church or sending missionaries and pouring resources into receptive harvest fields.[72]

Contextualization

Human beings do not exist in a void; they are a part of a community that shares a common language and customs; there exists a sense of commonality among them in the way social and economic aspects of life are played out. Common traditions and bonds dictate the manner in which they understand and deal with the happenings around them in the world that is shared.[73] Bishop Newbigin underscores the import of contextualization in these words:

> If the gospel is to be understood, if it is to be received as something which communicates truth about the real human situation, it is, as we say, to "make sense," it has to be communicated in the language of those to whom it is addressed and has to be clothed in symbols which are meaningful to them. And since the Gospel does not come as a disembodied message, but as the message of a community which claims to live by it and which invites others to adhere to it, the community's life must be so ordered that it "makes sense" to those who are invited. It must, as we say, "come alive."[74]

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[71] Ibid., 22.

[72] Ibid., 26-27.

[73] Ibid.

[74] Lesslie Newbigin, *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society* (Geneva: WCC Publications, 1990), 141.

As blood is to the body, contextualization is to Christianity. Christopher Duraisingh affirms: "At the heart of Christian faith lies the affirmation that the 'Word became flesh.'"[75] Charles Kraft endorses contextualization as "the scripturally endorsed approach to taking the gospel to the world."[76]

History reveals a wide spectrum of levels of contextualization used by churches and missionary efforts over the centuries, ranging from no contextualization, where the message is rejected by the receptors, to total adaptation, resulting in a complete watering down of the truth. In the first instance, the gospel is presented with no consideration of the cultural, socio-economic, historical, or political condition of the receptors; the gospel truth is held intact but not understood and left with no place for creativity. At the other extreme, the message may be presented in a way that is easily understood by the hearers and well received; however, extreme adaptation has resulted in syncretism and dilution of the message to a point of insignificance. The critical balance lies at some point between the extremities, where on one hand the gospel is presented in ways in which the truth is easily understood and grasped with the knowledge of its distinction from untruth and yet the cross is not "sanitized" for fear that it would become offensive.

Despite the challenges mentioned above, there is no option besides contextualization; there is an increasing need to delve deeper into the subject as people become more open and receptive to the gospel in regions where it has not been communicated thus far. Hiebert points out that "contextualization is an important and

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[75] Christopher Duraisingh, *Gospel and Culture: A Proposal for an Ecumenical Agenda* (Geneva: World Council of Churches, 1993), vi.

[76] Charles H. Kraft, *Christianity in Culture: A Study in Dynamic Biblical Theologizing in Cross-cultural Perspective* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1979), xxiii.

valuable process, necessary to the communication of the gospel."[77] Thanzauva also argues for the need of contextualization, saying: "Whenever the gospel is received from outside of one's own culture, contextualization is necessary. Since the gospel is present in every culture in an imperfect form, re-discovery of the hidden gospel from one's own culture is necessary to interact with the gospel received from outside. Only then the Christian gospel will be contextualized."[78]

Contextual Theology

The difference between contextual and classical theology also needs to be delineated at this juncture. Classical theology, seen as a science of Christian faith, is wrought from Scripture and tradition, whereas contextual theology, while giving due diligence to Scripture and tradition, also takes into account the cultural, socio-economic, and political elements and other pressing struggles of the people as its source of theology.[79]

Contextual theology naturally raises concerns that must be addressed. Foremost of these concerns is the need to maintain an authentic confession of Christ in a variety of cultures. Christopher Duraisingh's caution in this regard is worth citing as part of this discussion: "We are aware of the problem that unless there are certain criteria to judge the orthodoxy of contextual theology, there is the danger that a contextual theology may be captivated by the context. This would mean contextualized, not contextualization of

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[77] Ibid.[78] Ibid.

[78] Ibid.

[79] Ibid., 77.

Christian faith."[80] The second concern is the question, why should theology be contextualized? Christ and the gospel cannot be confined to any particular culture and such a confession then universalized. The message of the gospel and its implications are without doubt universal; nevertheless, its expression and articulation is shaped by the culture in which it is embedded. From another perspective, to be truly embedded in culture, the confession of Christ needs to take on the shape of that culture. If confession of Christ is articulated in the form of theology, then such confession in different cultural contexts stimulates the need for different theologies. The reign of God can be realized among the people of any culture; however, it can happen only when the gospel takes deep roots in that particular culture as a result of a profound understanding of the faith. Contextual theology is constructed to facilitate the community of faith in a given socio-cultural context gaining a clear understanding of the Christian faith.[81]

Inculturation

Inculturation means individuals turn to Christ, and the local church is formed, within the framework of a particular culture. The church is bound to exist within and express itself through the culture. The theological term *inculturation* implies three things: a) the insertion of the gospel within the very heart of a culture; b) the integration between the gospel and culture; and c) a process of exchange by which new insights of the message of Christ can be achieved.[82] Anthropologist Charles Kraft underscores the

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[80] Christopher Duraisingh, *Gospel and Culture: A Proposal for an Ecumenical Agenda* (Geneva: World Council of Churches, 1993), i.

[81] K. Thanzauva, *Theology of Community: Tribal Theology in the Making* (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2004), 9.

[82] Mario Saturnino Dias, *Rooting Faith in Asia: Source Book for Inculturation* (Quezon City, Philippines: Claretian, 2005), 250.

dominance of culture on an individual. "We cannot live without culture. It is that matrix within which we live and move and exist, the non-biological, non-environmental part of our lives that we learn from our elders, that we share with our community, and in which we are totally submerged from one end of life to the other."[83] *Kurukh* theologian Bishop Nirmal Minz defines *inculturation* as "a process by which a particular church expresses its faith and life in and through the local culture."[84] The core concept of inculturation has to be accepted, embraced, and implemented if a truly indigenous church is to emerge.

The Christian faith and its message, if not effectively lived out in a culturally relevant manner by its adherents, will fail to draw attention from non-adherents of the culture. The message conveyed is bound to be misunderstood or not understood by the hearers. In other words, the church within a particular cultural framework needs to be immersed in that culture in order to be contagious, attractive, and missional; to be effective in mission, the church must become indigenous in worship, life, and witness. Minz further emphasizes, "Inculturation is based on the concept of incarnation. Incarnation means that the transcendent has become immanent, the eternal has broken in to the temporal, that the Word has become flesh (Jn. 1:14 NIV)."[85]

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[83] Charles H. Kraft, *Anthropology for Christian Witness* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2007), 32.

[84] Nirmal Minz, *Rise Up, My People, and Claim the Promise: The Gospel among the Tribes of India* (Delhi: Indian Society for Promoting Christian Knowledge, 1997), 15.

[85] Ibid.,17.

APPENDIX B

Indigenous Movements in Africa, Latin America, and Asia

Indigenous Christianity in Africa

In the early 1900s, Africa had an estimated nine million Christians. It has seen an explosive growth in the last century.[1] Studies have revealed that much of the Christian growth in Africa is now due to African evangelism rather than European missionaries.[2] The new "independent"[3] churches, on account of their unique traits, may not be labeled as traditional Catholic or Protestant churches. Neither do they fall under any traditional denominational structures. Instead, they are distinctly African and indigenous. Hedlund, citing David Bebbington, states that the people movements of Africa to the Christian faith during the early twentieth century are only remotely connected to the original missionary effort. The process of indigeneity had already started, and on this foundation the next generation indigenous movement began to rise.[4] Several factors may have contributed to the mushrooming of independent indigenous movements in Africa.[5] The following observations may be important to note.

First, an adequate Christian worldview was not presented to the converts by the missionaries to replace the old one that the people were expected to reject. Consequently,

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[1] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000),28,29.

[2] Ibid.

[3] Ibid.

[4] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 30.

[5] Paul G. Hiebert, "Missiological Education for a Global Era," in *Missiological Education for the 21st Century,* ed. Dudley Woodberry, Charles Van Engen, and Edgar J. Elliston (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1996), 36.

as pointed out by Bengt Sundkler, adequate measures were not taken to address the issue of the "ancestor cult" in the early stages. Second, the gospel as it was presented failed to "touch the soul"—a need that was met later by the East Africa Revival movement.[6] F.B.A. Pauw observes that an ongoing encounter with the gospel through this movement was able to meet such needs, including that of healing and curative practices related to the realm of causation dealing with spirits, divinities, witchcraft, evil, and so on. These areas, of critical concern in the African religious world, were not adequately addressed by the Western rationalistic approach.[7] Hedlund puts forward his view that the inability of the missionaries to address the reality of evil powers is "at the heart of the causes of the Independent Church movement."[8] Third, unsettled economic conditions also seem to have had a significant contribution to the emergence of new movements.[9] Along with social marginalization, the economic conditions resulting in poverty and material need that affect people cause them to look for solutions from a variety of external sources.

Overall, many elements that run parallel to the context in India, along with certain contrasts, make a study of the African church relevant to this thesis. Particularly of interest is the increasing influence of Pentecostalism over the African Indian community

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[6] Bengt Sundkler, *Bantu Prophets in South Africa*, 2nd ed. (London: Published for the International African Institute by the Oxford University Press, 1961).

[7] B.A. Pauw, *Christianity and Xhosa Tradition: Belief and Ritual among Xhosa-speaking Christians* (Cape Town: Oxford University Press, 1975).

[8] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 30.

[9] Ibid., 31.

among the Tamil and Telugu peoples, since it coincides with similar movements among the same people groups in India as well.[10]

Indigeneity in Latin America

The indigenous Christian movements in Latin America were left mostly unrecognized until recent times.[11] Eugene Nida in 1961 brought to light the existence of churches in Latin America that could be categorized as totally indigenous in their origin, resources, and leadership.[12] They were different from the traditional mission-originated and mission-directed churches. They possessed a greater level of legitimacy and strength and projected themselves more as belonging to the people.[13] The term *autochthonous* was then used to describe this movement instead of *indigenous,* indicative of the fact that this movement belonged to a new wave of growing churches with marked differences from those of the past.

In recent years, the Pentecostal movement in Latin America has grown extensively. In the 1980s, the estimates were close to 50 million Christians, with 75 percent of them Pentecostal. By the year 2000, the number had exceeded 135 million.[14] William Taylor points out that while some of the churches established are offshoots of North American groups, most of them are the result of independent movements that find

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[10] Ibid., 32.

[11] Ibid., 34.

[12] Eugene A. Nida, *Understanding Latin Americans: With Special Reference to Religious Values and Movements*. (South Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1974).

[13] Ibid.

[14] David B. Barrett and Todd M. Johnson, "Annual Statistical Table on Global Mission: 2002," *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 26, no. 1 (January 2002): 23-24.

their origins among their own.[15] Results of Barrett's research indicate a rapid growth of the independent evangelical churches that demonstrate true indigeneity. Taylor points out that this explosive growth is "an autochthonous movement, coming primarily from the poor."[16]

The indigenous Pentecostal churches in Latin America are experiencing spontaneous growth among the urban poor. David Barrett's studies reveal that these churches are more contextual and find stronger ties with the marginalized of society.[17] Once again, similarity is spotted with the growth of independent Pentecostal churches among the urban poor in India. Hedlund, quoting Escobar, provides the explanation and the evidence: "The churches that grow faster are the popular churches of the Pentecostal type, the most contextual in liturgy and evangelistic methodology. These are the ones that have almost no foreign connections or influence."[18] Indigenous movements in Latin America grow in diversity but remain tied together by one common bond. None are imported, and each one is *autochthonous*. They are best described in Hedlund's words: "Latino incarnations of the Gospel of Christ."[19]

Asian Forms of Christianity

Asia, with its plurality of cultures, languages, and conflicting ideologies, is a fertile ground for study of the inculturation of the gospel. Indigenous movements in

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[15] C. Emilio Antonio Núñezand William David Taylor, *Crisis and Hope in Latin America: An Evangelical Perspective* (Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1996), 156.

[16] Ibid., 157.

[17] David B. Barrett and Todd M. Johnson, "Annual Statistical Table on Global Mission: 2002," *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 26, no. 1 (January 2002): 23-24.

[18] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 35.

[19] Ibid., 37.

Taiwan, the Philippines, Korea, China, and Japan are of particular interest because of their socio-cultural diversity. The movements in these countries of South Asia are considerably different than other locations where large Christward movements have been observed. A brief glance at each is fitting in this instance. More to the present issue is the rebirth of the Christian message into each segment of these Asian cultures, which are quite distinct from each other.

Philippines. The new indigenous church in the Philippines is a good first example. The Iglesia Ni Cristo is a growing indigenous movement in the Philippines. Although this church is rejected as a sect by larger denominations, A.L. Tuggy, following his in-depth research, strongly defends this movement as meeting the felt needs of the people and attributes this characteristic to its steady growth.[20] Hedlund observes, and it is of particular interest, that the membership of Iglesia is comprised of the "masses" and not the "classes."[21] Even though the great tradition Protestant and Catholic churches look down on the Iglesia as a wayward sect, it continues as a subaltern movement of the little tradition that is culturally adapted and one that is popularly and rapidly multiplying.[22] According to Tuggy, at the time of his study, it is considered to be the largest independent church in Asia.[23] It is to be noted that though similar to the present indigenous church movement in India, which is generally characterized as charismatic, the Iglesia is not classified as a "charismatic" church in the Philippines.

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[20] Ibid., 42.

[21] Ibid.

[22] Ibid.

[23] Ibid.

Korea. In Korea, Christianity entered the core of Korean culture and came to be identified with nationalism.[24] South Korea, which has witnessed explosive church growth, has produced the world's largest Christian congregations. A deeper look at the predominantly Presbyterian Christianity of Korea, according to John Connor, reveals a mixture of Confucian thought, which incorporates philosophical and socio-political thought as part of religion.[25] In what outwardly looks "Western" with vested choirs, Western music, and elaborate buildings, missiologists have observed distinctive indigenous forms of spirituality, including an abundance of "break-away" Presbyterian denominations and a variety of local expressions.[26] Hedlund makes the following observation:

> More than most other countries, Korea is marked by a militant indigeneity manifested in these and other denominations each with its own seminary and various ecclesiastical alignments. Korean Christianity is a study not only in independence and indigeneity but in Korean contextuality and leadership dynamics expressed in a succession of break-away movements. Large, Korean churches of various denominations are found in North America, and Korean missionaries have been sent to several countries of Africa, Asia, Latin America and the Pacific. Christianity in Korea appears distinctly Korean, and Korean Christianity is aggressively missionary.[27]

China. The current history of the Chinese church is a narrative of explosive growth under persecution and seclusion. Both factors have more or less forced the church to become fully indigenous. According to Barrett, China has over 80 million evangelical

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[24] Ibid., 44.

[25] Ibid.

[26] Ibid.

[27] Ibid., 45.

believers, with an estimated 30,000 conversions each day.[28] The Christian faith has survived through house fellowships and small groups with very little or no foreign connection whatsoever. The missionary era witnessed very few Christians during its time.[29] Indigenous movements that preceded this period have survived the cultural revolution on account of their flexibility and indigeneity. Similarities are noticed in certain regions of India that are undergoing oppression and persecution. House churches that proved to be the training ground for lay leadership during the repression seem to have spawned the indigenous church in China.[30]

Nepal. Closer to India, Nepal cannot be ignored since the Nepali church has emerged within the last fifty years and is almost totally indigenous.[31] The church continues to grow through Nepali initiative in the midst of persecution and repression. Barrett estimates over 100,000 new evangelical believers in the last two decades.[32] History does record very early missionary attempts by Roman Catholics as well as William Carey's translation of the New Testament into Nepalise as significant influences; the main influences in the recent years, however, have been through Nepal outside Nepal

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[28] David B. Barrett and Todd M. Johnson, "Annual Statistical Table on Global Mission: 2002," *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 26, no. 1 (January 2002): 23-24.

[29] Ibid.

[30] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000),44.

[31] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 46.

[32] David B. Barrett and Todd M. Johnson, "Annual Statistical Table on Global Mission: 2002," *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 26, no. 1 (January 2002): 23-24.

who came into contact with Protestant Christianity.[33] The Jesuits entered in 1951, and others have followed since, but the Nepali church is indigenous in origin.[34]

[33] Ibid.

[34] Ibid.

APPENDIX C

Noteworthy Contributions of Individuals to Indigenous Christianity

Vedanayagam Sastri of Thanjavur (1773-1864)

Vedanayagam Sastri of Thanjavur (1773-1864) was discipled by Christian Fredrick Schwartz, a German Lutheran missionary.[1] His scholarship in the Tamil language opened his eyes to see Christ through Indian culture. He tenaciously held on to his status as a *Vellalar* of noble birth and he never abandoned his close admiration for classical or high *Sangam* (Tamil) culture. "As an evangelical and an intellectual, he was both founder and fountainhead of modern Tamil literature and learning."[2] He faced criticism from missionaries on account of his stance toward caste segregation; however, he held the view along with Bishop Heber[3] that the missionaries from the West at that time had no moral right to criticize caste differences in India while they at home were still involved in slavery.[4] One English missionary with the Society for the Propagation of the Gospel (SPG) even had "*Tanjore* Christians" (native Christian converts belonging to a single caste in Tanjore District through Vedanayagam ministry) of Vedanayagam's congregations publicly flogged for refusing to abandon caste/class structures with the church.[5] With respect to his dealings with Tamilians and the Tamil language,

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[1] Roger E. Hedlund, ed., *The Oxford Encyclopaedia of South Asian Christianity* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2012), 723.

[2] Ibid.

[3] Ibid.

[4] Ibid.

[5] Robert Eric Frykenberg, *India and the Indianness of Christianity: Essays on Understanding, Historical, Theological, and Bibliographical, in Honor of Robert Eric Frykenberg* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Pub., 2009).

Vedanayagam Sastriar has been called the "uncrowned king of Tamil Christian *Bhakti*[6] lyrics."[7] He helped in the understanding of Christ in the Tamil culture through his devotional poetry. His unbiased, theological, poetic writings, along with his comparative religious ideology, facilitated the understanding and acceptance of Christianity as an Indian religion.[8]

Pandita Ramabai (1858-1922)

Ramabai stands out as a prominent woman who contributed significantly to the emergence of modern India and indigenous Christianity. As a social activist, she was well-known for her radical advocacy for the rights of suppressed women of India through her articulate speeches and writings.[9] It is said that Ramabai may have inherited her passion for reform from her father. Her early experiences in the loss of her father and mother in 1874 during the great famine and the death of her sister in 1875 left a great void in her life so she and her brother, Shrinivas Shastri, both equally learned and well taught by their father, then set out on what is described as a "perpetual tour of pilgrimage" to lecture on the need for education, emancipation, and uplifting of women.[10] It was during this period that Ramabai was acclaimed as "Pandita" (national title bestowed on individuals meaning "learned teacher") and "Saraswat" (learned and of high

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[6] Complete surrender and devotion to God.

[7] Roger E. Hedlund, ed., *The Oxford Encyclopaedia of South Asian Christianity* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2012), 723

[8] Roger E. Hedlund, *Christianity is Indian: The Emergence of an Indigenous Community* (Delhi: Published for MIIS, Mylapore by ISPCK, 2000), 208.

[9] Nicol Macnicol, and Vishal Mangalwadi, *Pandita Ramabai, a Builder of Modern India* (New Delhi: Good Books, 1996), 65.

[10] Roger E. Hedlund, ed., *The Oxford Encyclopaedia of South Asian Christianity* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2012), 582.

descent) and recognized as "the only woman in the whole of India who could be reckoned as one amongst the learned."[11] Meera Kosambi portrays Ramabai's nationalism and the love she had for her people during this time in her life before she converted to Christianity thus:

> Chafing against colonial subjugation, Ramabai repeatedly voiced her anti-British sentiment and her cultural and political nationalism. It stands to her credit that she did not discard her patriotism along with her religion. In December 1889, Ramabai had participated as one of only eight women delegates in the annual meeting of the newly established political association, the National Social Conference, held in tandem in Bombay. Subsequently, during the plague epidemic of the late 1890s, Ramabai had a brief but effective alliance with moderate nationalists.[12]

Pandita Ramabai's journey of life with Christ as a convert from Brahminic Hinduism may be described as "long and complex" due to a variety of factors that influenced and shaped it.[13] She was disillusioned with the Brahminic Hinduism with which she and her brother were familiar, taught by her scholarly father since childhood. She was drawn to the Christian faith that guaranteed salvation to all without discrimination.[14] Ramabai's perception of her conversion was a protest against the inherent discrimination against women in Hinduism. Rather than turning it into a social protest, she lived it out the remainder of her life, articulating it in words and works.[15] What is of importance to the present study is her contribution to indigenous Christianity,

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[11] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 157-158.

[12] Meera Kosambi and Ramabai Sarasvati, *Returning the American Gaze: Pandita Ramabai's The Peoples of the United States (1889)* (Delhi: Permanent Black, 2003), 31.

[13] Meera Kosambi, "Economic and Political Weekly," *Indian Response to Christianity, Church and Colonialism: Case of Pandita Ramabai,* 7, no. 43/44 (October 1992), 61-69.

[14] Ibid.

[15] Ibid.

which is overshadowed by her great reputation as a social reformist.[16] The apologetic writings and personal acquaintance of Marathi Brahmin convert and Sanskrit scholar Father Nehemiah Goreh seem to have made a deep impression in shaping her Christian beliefs.[17]

According to her grandniece, Ramabai's first contact with Christianity was through reading the Bible in Sanskrit in Calcutta. She decided then to follow Christ, but it wasn't until her visit to England later in 1883 that she and her daughter Manorama were baptized. Having been exposed to Western traditions and cultures during her study and stay in England and colonized India as well, she saw a distinction between the Christian faith and these cultures and traditions. She was convinced that her conversion to Christianity did not necessitate the rejection of her cultural background nor identification with what were clearly Western practices and observances. Ramabai's Christian experience as a convert is seen as a quest for intellectual and spiritual freedom.[18] Gauri Viswanathan writes: "Alienated from Hindu society, but also in conflict with the traditions of Anglican Christianity, Ramabai set about refashioning Christianity to her own requirements."[19] Ramabai, reluctant to give up her personal freedom to the traditional controls imposed by the Anglican Church and the paternalism of the missionaries, grew to be a driving force behind the critical ideology of free will and choice in Indian Christianity. The way she lived her life as a converted Christian without

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[16] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 157.

[17] Ibid., 157-158.

[18] Meera Kosambi and Ramabai Sarasvati, *Returning the American Gaze: Pandita Ramabai's The Peoples of the United States (1889)* (Delhi: Permanent Black, 2003), 32.

[19] Gauri Viswanathan, *Outside the Fold: Conversion, Modernity, and Belief* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1998), 118.

abrogating culture by itself makes her work a significant contribution to indigenous Christianity.[20] Hansdak explains:

> In Ramabai's conversion to Christianity, the search for an ideal socio-religious system is clearly visible. By converting, she visibly aligned herself to a system that she perceived as more rational, purer and nobler. Later, when she found her intellectual freedom curtailed by this system, she turned to alternative systems and finally tried to create the ideal system to which she aspired.[21]

R.S. Sugirtharaja says: "She found the doctrinal teachings of the Anglican Church cumbersome and unhelpful and saw them as the Church's way of controlling its believers. She was skeptical of the doctrinal developments of the post-biblical period as having no biblical validation."[22]

In 1897, a small village called Kedgaon saw the beginnings of an indigenous national evangelistic mission pioneered by Ramabai. This mission is said to be the first of its kind in the country.[23] Comprising a school and accommodations for famine orphans and widows, this initial secular outreach led to many conversions and evangelistic outreach into the surrounding villages. The church that was birthed, as a result, adopted an indigenous form of worship, unlike the traditional ways of established churches of that time.[24] Ramabai rendered her own new Marathi language translation of the Bible and

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[20] Jan N. Bremmer, Wout Jacvan Bekkum, and Arie L. Molendijk, *Cultures of Conversions* (Leuven, Belgium: Peeters, 2006), 22.

[21] Ibid.

[22] R.S. Sugirtharajah, *The Bible and the Third World Precolonial, Colonial, and Postcolonial Encounters* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001), 99.

[23] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 159.

[24] Ibid., 163.

"mobilized the Bible as a way of resisting the Church authorities and securing her identity, and more significantly, to make it accessible to the people of her community."[25]

Focusing mainly on the teaching of Jesus and the figure of Jesus, she was especially concerned with following Jesus' teaching as reported in the Gospels. Ultimately, that which made the greatest difference to Ramabai was this way of believing and practicing the Christian faith.[26] In Ramabai's words, "The Hindu religion brings the Supreme Being, the Holy God to the level of a creature like myself but Christianity lifts man up to God. What is the lifting up of man to God can be better understood by reading and imitating the life of Christ than by describing it in my defective words."[27] According to Roswith Gerloff, "Mukti [Salvation] Church established by Ramabai is a unique indigenous legacy and the first of its kind in India of one of India's greatest women, Pandita Ramabai Saraswati, one of the makers of modem India."[28]

Narayan Vaman Tilak (1862-1919)

Shortly before his death, Tilak wrote a letter to the missionaries of his time. It succinctly summarizes not only the nationalistic spirit of the time but also the fact that the church in India was no longer a child but had attained adulthood. His words were: "Cease

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[25] R.S. Sugirtharajah, *The Bible and the Third World Precolonial, Colonial, and Postcolonial Encounters* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001), 101.

[26] Ibid.

[27] Ibid., 104.

[28] Roswith Gerloff, "Asia & Africa in Christian Renewal," *Dharma Deepika: A South Asian Journal of Missiological Research*18, no. 40 (December 2014): 6.

to be fathers and mothers, be real brothers and sisters. Know how to appreciate, trust people, and take the place of India's revered saints."[29]

Narayan Vaman Tilak was a *Maratha (Chitpavan) Brahmin,* which means he was a high caste Brahmin hailing from the Konkan coastal region of western India. He had already become a celebrated poet, novelist, and thinker when, through reading the Bible, he became a convert. He may be rightly called an "intellectual convert."[30] When he was baptized in February of 1865, he insisted that it should be in the hands of an Indian rather than a missionary.[31] His lifelong quest, or *Parampara,*[32] was devoted to reconciling his Hindu cultural heritage and his commitment to Christ. Widely respected, he dedicated himself to the emancipation of oppressed and marginalized peoples, especially non-*Brahmins*, untouchables, and women.[33] From the end of 1912 until his death, he was editor of *Dnyansdaya*, an eight-page Marathi weekly that was published by the American Marathi Mission and which blended news with religious articles, poems, and translations. As a consequence of his many years of scholarship and writing, Tilak left an enormous corpus of writings—including some 700 hymns, many of which are still widely used in Indian churches among the Marathi-speaking people to this day. He urgently appealed for Indian Christians to shed their dependency upon the West and to eradicate all

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[29] Atul Y. Aghamkar, and Vishwas Padole, *Christian Missions in Maharashtra -Retrospect and Prospect* (Bangalore: TETRAWPOI, 2010), 119.

[30] S. Jacob Plamthodathil, *The Experiential Response of N.V. Tilak* (Madras: Published for the Christian Institute for the Study of Religion and Society by the Christian Literature Society, 1979), 94.

[31] Gerald H. Anderson, ed., *Biographical Dictionary of Christian Missions* (New York: Macmillan Reference USA, 1998).

[32] Sanskrit word denoting the succession of teacher-disciple in a lifelong search for spirituality.

[33] John Copley Winslow, *Narayan Vaman Tilak, the Christian Poet of Maharashtra* (London: Student Christian Movement, 1923), 20.

denominational divisions among their congregations. During his last years, he too became a *Bhakta* and a *Sanyasi*—giving up material possessions and institutional connections but never renouncing his family and home.[34] He is acknowledged in the state of Maharashtra by non-Christians and Christians alike as one who gave new life to Marathi poetry. According to Firth, his inheritance of lyricism from Tukaram and old Hindu *Bhaktas* was "baptized into Christ."[35]

Individual leaders mentioned above were converts; they were men and women whose new faith in Christ combined with a spirit of nationalism and affection to their Indian heritage instilled into the church the same fervor and zeal to keep culture and new spirituality duly aligned.[36] Many others who followed them as second-generation Christians have demonstrated the same if not higher levels of national self-consciousness during the first decade of the twentieth century. Christian nationalists such as V.S. Azariah, K.T. Paul, and V. Santiago, who all became prominent in church affairs later, seeking more freedom than being under missionary regime contributed to indigenous thought and theology.[37] They were also instrumental in the formation of several Indian missionary societies during this period, that is to say societies formed by Indian Christians to preach the gospel and carry on Christian work in other parts of India than their own. These indigenous missionary enterprises are mentioned briefly later in this chapter.

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[34] Robert Eric Frykenberg and Richard Fox Young, *India and the Indianness of Christianity: Essays on Understanding, Historical, Theological, and Bibliographical, in Honor of Robert Eric Frykenberg* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Pub., 2009).

[35] Cyril Bruce Firth, *An Introduction to Indian Church History* (Madras, India: Published for the Senate of Serampore College by ISPCK, 1968), 250.

[36] Ibid., 253.

[37] Ibid., 251.

Sadhu Sundar Singh (1889-1929)

Sadhu Sundar Singh finds a place in this study both as one who contributed to the shaping of indigenous theology and, later, through his followers, an indigenous church movement as well. He lived his life as an itinerant *Sadhu*[38] and a preacher of Christ, crossing denominational distinctions with his Christo-centric message.[39] His institutional, theological education was limited to just a few months, and he declined the offer of Anglican ordination, not desiring his ministry to be restricted to the Anglican Church although he was baptized in it.[40]

We find attempts made in the early twentieth century by certain individuals to live as independent *Sanyasis*[41] following the *Bhakti* tradition (Bhakti Marga).[42] Boyd writes that several of these individuals, like Nehemiah Goreh, considered it the best way to preach Christ to their own people, following the method adopted by Robert De Nobili,[43] who expressed his conviction in the following words: "We can have no rest until we see the religion of Christ lived by Hindu ascetics and preached by Hindu monks; until we

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[38] Sadhu meaning "holy" or "saint" or "ascetic." A title used for wandering holymen.

[39] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 165.

[40] Cyril Bruce Firth, *An Introduction to Indian Church History* (Madras, India: Published for the Senate of Serampore College by ISPCK, 1968), 251.

[41] Aiyadurai Jesudasen Appasamy, *Sundar Singh: A Biography* (Madras, India: CLS, 1996 Reprint), 18.

[42] Bhakti marga (translated in English: the way of devotion) insists that it is only through a total devotion to a single God/deity that salvation is attained. In answer to the question, "What must I do to be saved?" Bhakti rejects the Jnana marga (way of knowledge) and the Karma marga (way of good works); for although the Gita, for example, recognizes that good works must be performed, their performance cannot guarantee salvation. H.S. Robin Boyd, *An Introduction to Indian Christian Theology. 2nd Rev. ed*. (Madras, India: Christian Literature Society, 1975), 111.

[43] 1577-1656. Founder of the Catholic Madurai Mission prior to Protestant missions in south India.

behold the beauty of the Catholic Faith set off with oriental vestments."[44] It will be observed later that Narayan Vaman Tilak also resigned from his position in the American Marathi Mission and spent the last twenty months of his life as a *Sadhu* with the understanding that it would be a more natural and attractive way of bringing the Christian message to Hindus than the conventional methods.[45]

As the first Christian *Sadhu,*[46] a man of exceptional character and gifts, and one who caught the public imagination rising to fame both in India and abroad, Sundar Singh stands alone.[47] The son of a Sikh landlord in the Punjab region, as Sundar himself declares, he was deeply influenced by a religious mother who brought him up in both the Sikh as well as in the Hindu traditions. Even at an early age, he was familiar with scriptures of both these religions. A vision and voice of Christ, not unlike the experience of the apostle Paul, was the turning point of his life that marked his conversion to Christianity. A month after this dramatic experience, at sixteen years of age, he left home as a wandering *Sadhu*, donning the saffron robe.[48] The thoughts and writings of Sundar Singh give rise to a variety of indigenous theological elements.[49] "Union with God" was his aim; that, however, did not mean absorption but dialog with God. Sundar Singh

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[44] H.S. Robin Boyd, *An Introduction to Indian Christian Theology. 2nd Rev. ed*. (Madras, India: Christian Literature Society, 1975), 84.

[45] Cyril Bruce Firth, *An Introduction to Indian Church History* (Madras, India: Published for the Senate of Serampore College by ISPCK, 1968), 250-251.

[46] Literally means "one who is on the right path." In common parlance, it is used in India to mean "religious mendicant."

[47] Cyril Bruce Firth, *An Introduction to Indian Church History* (Madras, India: Published for the Senate of Serampore College by ISPCK, 1968).

[48] Ibid., 251.

[49] Em Sttiphan, *A Christian Theology in the Indian Context* (Delhi: ISPCK, 2001).

himself stated that "only those who commune with God in prayer can really know Reality."[50]

An in-depth study of his ministry brings up possibilities for uncovering fresh and indigenous Christian expressions.[51] Eric Sharpe expresses it thus:

> He closely resembled, in fact, the romantic Victorian image of Jesus Christ, and that gave him an incalculable advantage where the romantic West was concerned. Most of all, though, he summed up in his own person a great deal of what Christians had long hoped and prayed for from mission and church in India. It was not that he was a convert, but rather that unlike most converts he appeared to have access to the innermost chambers of Indian spirituality. As a Christian, he remained remarkably Indian.[52]

Although not a trained theologian in the traditional sense, his writings, according to Boyd, are filled with Christ-centered theology that strongly affirms the uniqueness of Christ's incarnation and claimed to be based substantially on his personal experience with Jesus Christ. Ecstatic experience was an ongoing part of his spirituality.[53] As a mystic, Sundar Singh had to face many detractors, and some of his narrated spiritual experiences have been questioned.[54] Nevertheless, as the Danish Scholar Kaj Baago is quick to affirm: "Contemporary theology with its aversion to metaphysics and with its emphasis upon the reality of this world and Christian social responsibility will probably shrink back in horror from Sundar Singh's ideas. Still, he is part of Indian theology and has a

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[50] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 164.

[51] Ibid., 163.

[52] Eric Sharpe, "The Legacy of Sadhu Sundar Singh" International Bulletin 40th Anniversary, vol. 14, no.4, October 1990, 161. International Bulletin. http://www.internationalbulletin.org/issues/1990-04/1990-04-161-sharpe.pdf (accessed April 21, 2015)

[53] H.S. Robin Boyd, *An Introduction to Indian Christian Theology* (Madras, India: Christian Literature Society, 1975), 108.

[54] Eric Sharpe, "The Legacy of Sadhu Sundar Singh" International Bulletin 40th Anniversary, vol. 14, no.4, October 1990, 163. International Bulletin. http://www.internationalbulletin.org/issues/1990-04/1990-04-161-sharpe.pdf (accessed April 21, 2015)

right to be heard."[55] Unquestionably Sundar Singh's impact on Indian Christianity is substantial. He did not start or leave behind an institutional church, and while his legacy may be generally considered theological, Hedlund affirms, "it may be concluded that the Sadhu's greatest impact was his indigeneity, a model of contextuality."[56] This impact led to the formation of indigenous churches following his model and teachings later.

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[55] Kaj Baagø, *Pioneers of Indigenous Christianity* (Bangalore: Christian Institute for the Study of Religion and Society and the Christian Literature Society, 1969), 70.

[56] Roger E. Hedlund, *Quest for Identity: India's Churches of Indigenous Origin: The "Little Tradition" in Indian Christianity* (Delhi: MIIS/ISPCK, 2000), 167.

APPENDIX D

Plate 1: Location of Kurukh Adivasis in Jharkhand

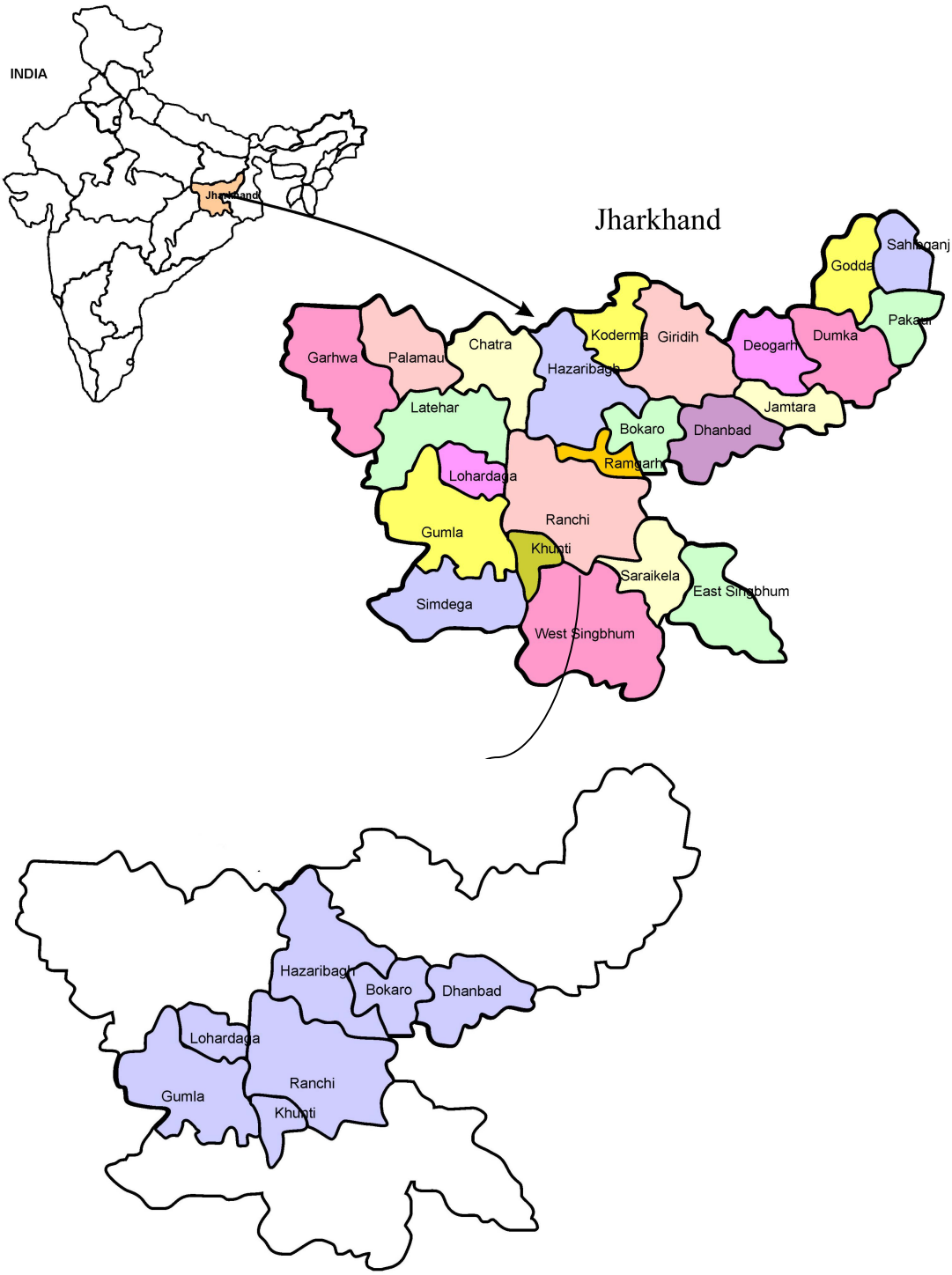


Plate 2: Movements of the Human Races



Plate 3: Theory of Oraons' Migration from South India



Plate 4: Advent of Christian Missions in Chota Nagpur

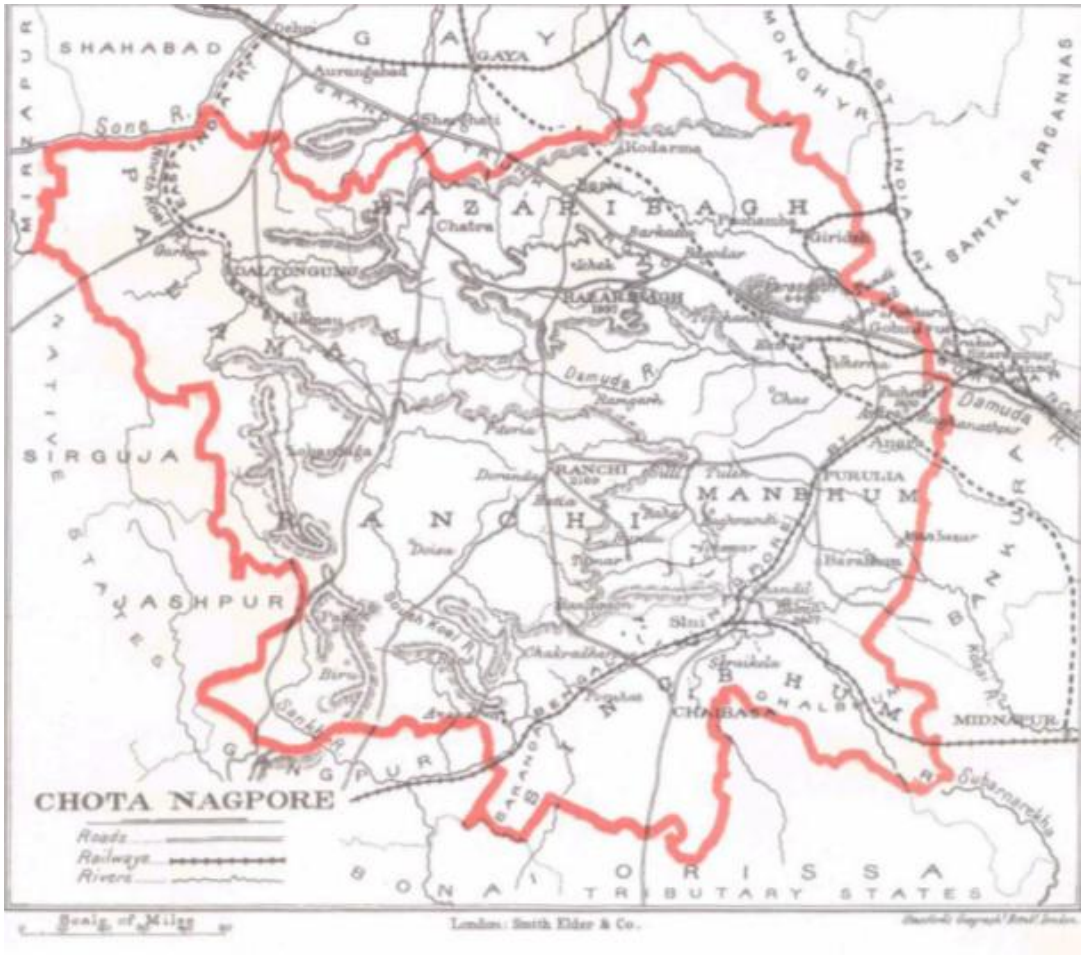


Plate 5: Distribution of Kurukhar in India



Plate6: Map of Chota Nagpur

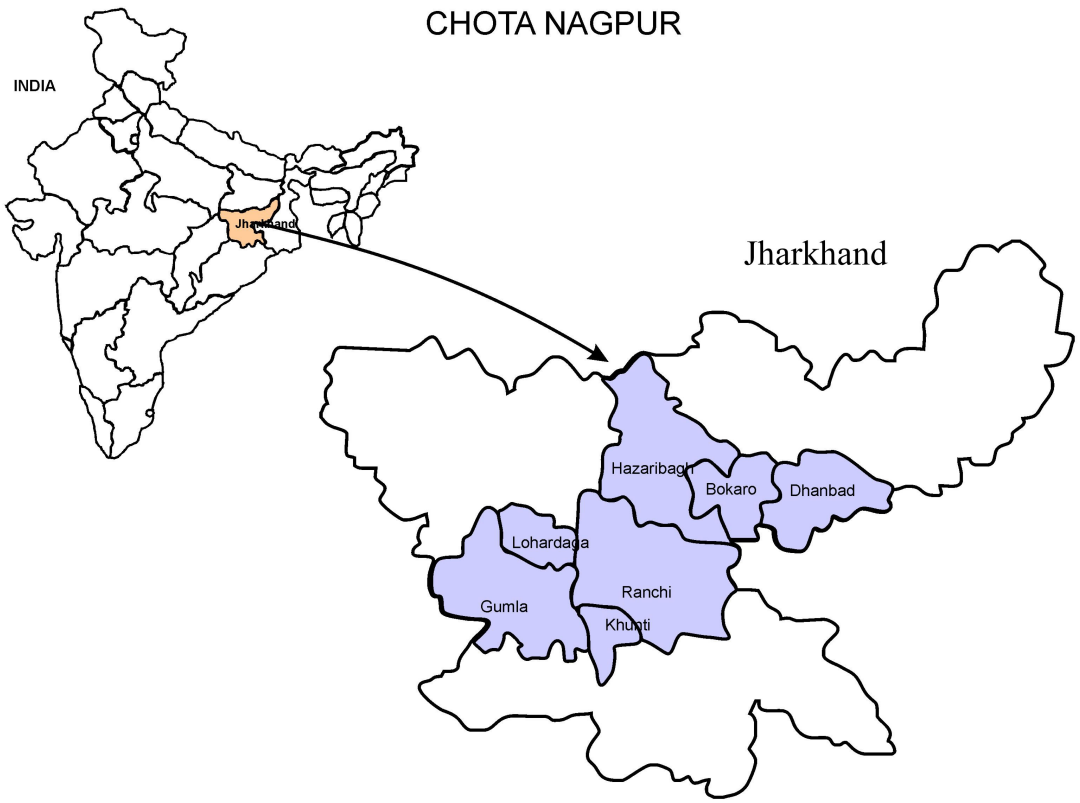
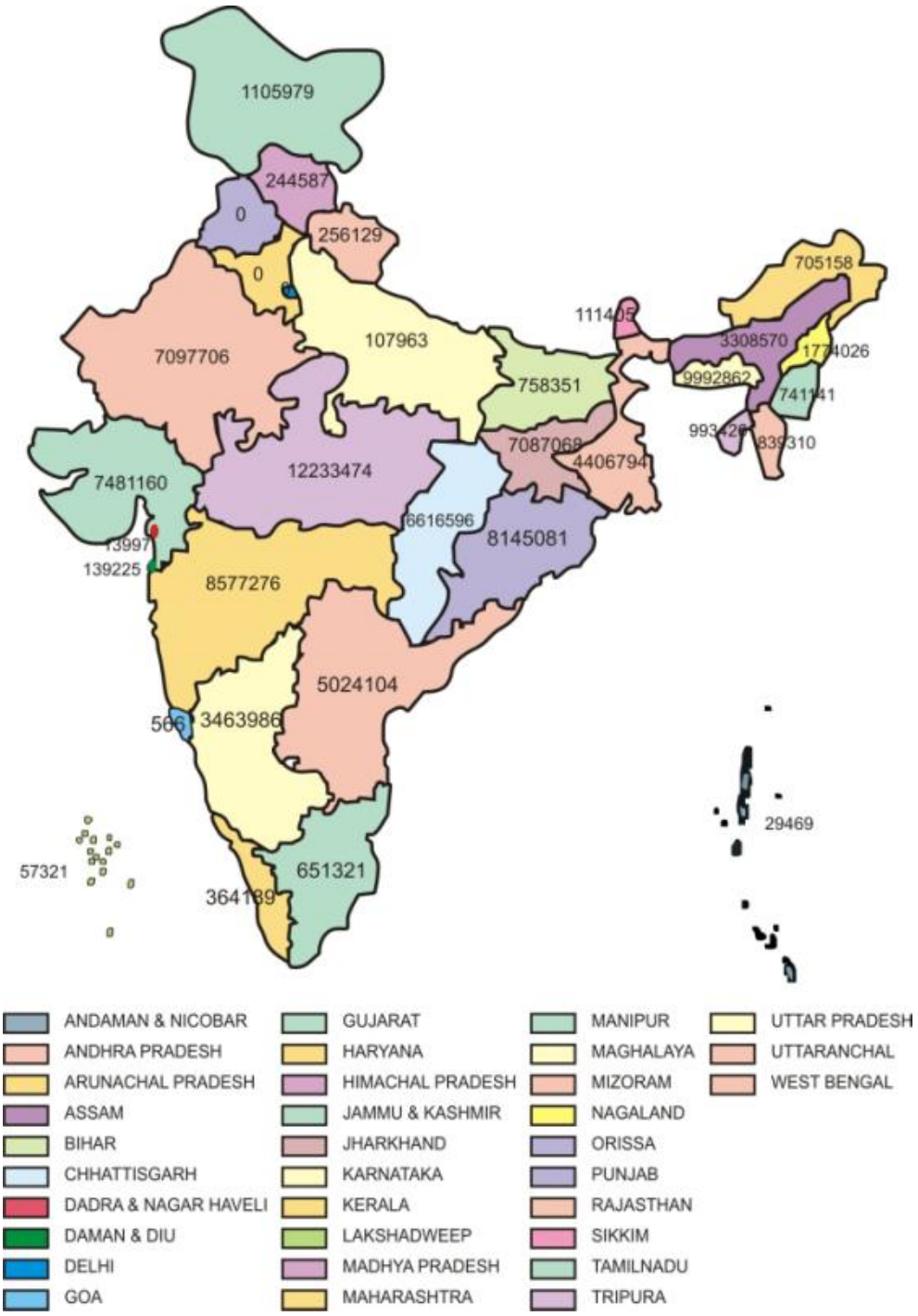
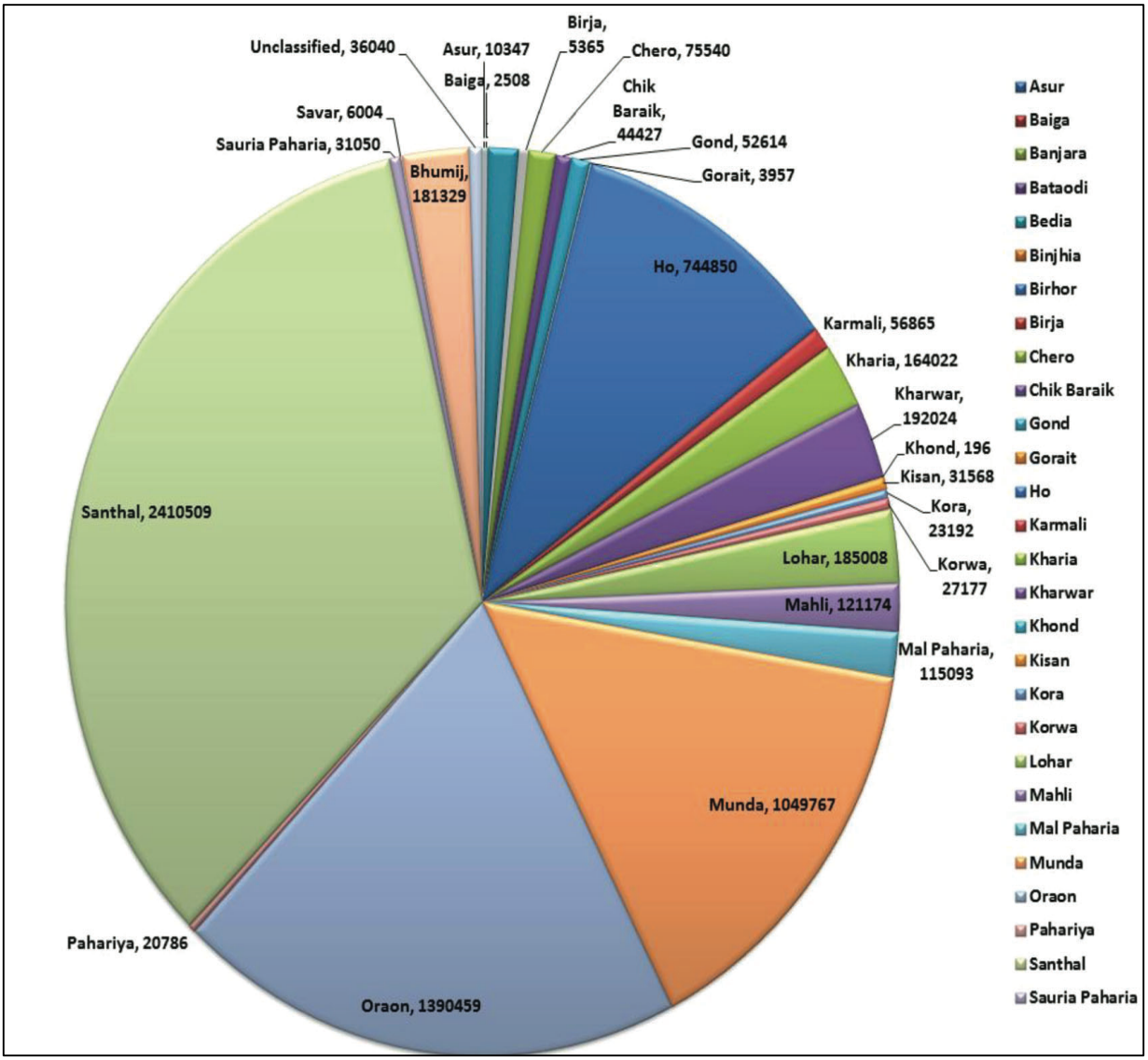


Plate 7: Statewide Tribal Population in India 2011[1]



[1] Manmasih Ekka, "Asur Myth of Oraons: A Resource for Human Liberative Spirituality," PhD diss., Gospel & Plough School of Theology, Allahabad, U.P., India, 30. In Shodhganga : a reservoir of Indian theses @ INFLIBNET, http://shodhganga.inflibnet.ac.in/bitstream/10603/38807/16/16_appendix.pdf (accessed April 21, 2015).

Plate 8: Tribal Population of Jharkhand, 2001[2]



[2] Manmasih Ekka, "Asur Myth of Oraons: A Resource for Human Liberative Spirituality," PhD diss., Gospel & Plough School of Theology, Allahabad, U.P., India, 3. In Shodhganga : a reservoir of Indian theses @ INFLIBNET, http://shodhganga.inflibnet.ac.in/bitstream/10603/38807/12/12_chapter%204.pdf (accessed April 21, 2015).

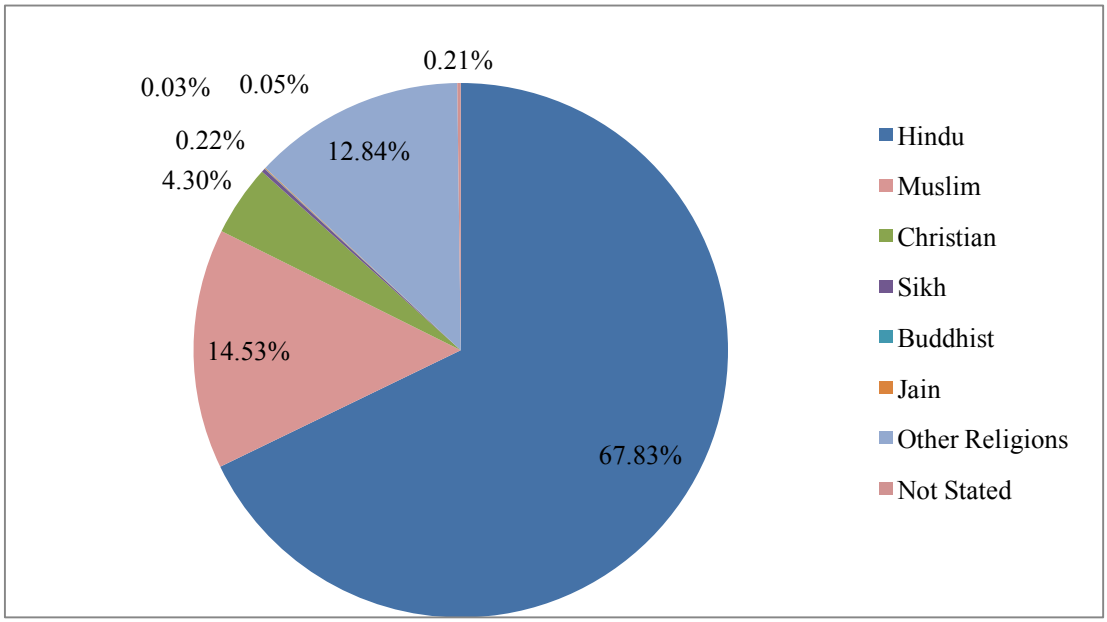
Plate 9: Oraon Population in Jharkhand[3]



[3] Manmasih Ekka, "Asur Myth of Oraons: A Resource for Human Liberative Spirituality," PhD diss., Gospel & Plough School of Theology, Allahabad, U.P., India, 7. In Shodhganga : a reservoir of Indian theses @ INFLIBNET, http://shodhganga.inflibnet.ac.in/bitstream/10603/38807/12/12_chapter%204.pdf (accessed April 21, 2015).

Plate 10: Faith of Oraons of Jharkhand[4]

Hindu	Muslim	Christian	Sikh	Buddhist	Jain	Other Religions	Not stated
67.83 %	14.53 %	4.30 %	0.22 %	0.03 %	0.05 %	12.84 %	0.21 %



[4] Census 2011- Jharkhand Religion Census 2011, http://www.census2011.co.in/data/religion/state/20-jharkhand.html(accessed April 21, 2015)

Plate 11: Karam Festival and Dance[5]



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[5] Chapainawabganj, Rabiul Hasan, "Karam festival in Naogaon". The Daily Star, http://www.thedailystar.net/karam-festival-in-naogaon-45171, (accessed April 21, 2015).

[6] Plus Life Style, "Culture and Festival of Jharkhand" http://pluslifestyles.com/articles/jharkhand-festivals/, (accessed April 21, 2015).

Plate 12: Karam Festival Celebrated in Honor of Women[7,8]





[7] Government of Jharkhand, "Festivals in Jharkhand" http://www.jharkhand.gov.in/festivals (accessed April 21, 2015).

[8] The Avenue Mail, "Karma festival celebrated at Sitaramdera" http://www.avenuemail.in/jamshedpur/karma-festival-celebrated-at-sitaramdera/1105/ (accessed April 21, 2015)

Plate 13: Saal Leaves and Flowers used during Sarhul Festival[9]



Sarna Forest (The Sacred Grove)[10]



[9] Jharkhand State News, "Sal trees sprinkled petals on Buddha," http://www.jharkhandstatenews.com/sal-trees-sprinkled-petals-on-buddha (accessed April 21, 2015).

[10] Jharkhand Biodiversity Board, http://jbbjharkhand.org (accessed April 21, 2015).

Plate 14: Kurukh Perception of Dharmes, the Supreme Being[11]



Oraon Priest (Pahan) Performing Dhanda-katta

[12]



[11] Manmasih Ekka, "Asur Myth of Oraons: A Resource for Human Liberative Spirituality," PhD diss., Gospel & Plough School of Theology, Allahabad, U.P., India, 7. In Shodhganga : a reservoir of Indian theses @ INFLIBNET, http://shodhganga.inflibnet.ac.in/bitstream/10603/38807/10/10_chapter%201.pdf(accessed April 21, 2015).

[12] Ibid., 9.

Plate 15: Plaque Commemorating the 150th Year of the Baptism of the First Tribal Convert in Jharkhand[13]



[13] Lutheran Church, Balalong, Ranchi, Jharkhand

Plate 16: Inculturation: A *Kurukh* Incarnation of Mary and Infant Jesus[14]



[14] Catholic Church, Singhpur, Ranchi, Jharkhand